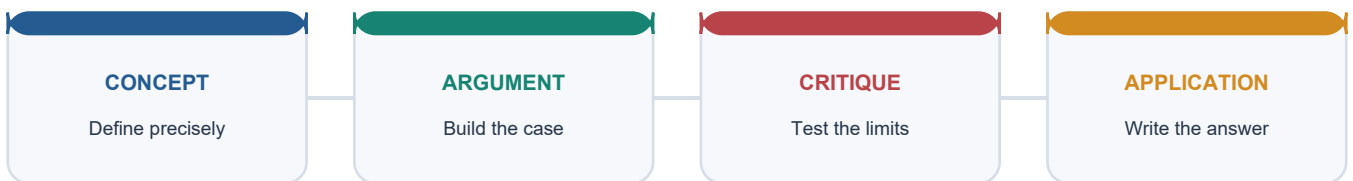


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Rationalism - Complete Learning Session

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section A | 12 teaching sessions, 32 diagnostics, 14 solved PYQs, 6 original Mains models and register notes

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Rationalism - Complete Learning Session	4
What this package contains	4
BASIC LEARNING SESSION	4
CONCEPT SPINE - ENGLISH FIRST, LATIN OR FRENCH IMMEDIATELY AFTER	4
ANSWER-WORTHINESS - WHAT EARNS MARKS AND WHAT DOES NOT	5
HOW TO READ THIS SESSION	6
ORIGIN AND CHRONOLOGY - THE MINIMUM NEEDED TO AVOID ANACHRONISM	6
ONE-SCREEN ROUTE MAP	7
SESSION 1 - WHAT MAKES RATIONALISM A SCHOOL, AND WHY THE THREE SYSTEMS DIVERGE	8
SESSION 2 - DESCARTES I: THE METHOD, METHODIC DOUBT AND THE THINKING SELF	11
SESSION 3 - DESCARTES II: CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION, THE THREE KINDS OF IDEAS, AND INNATE IDEAS AGAINST LOCKE	15
SESSION 4 - DESCARTES III: THE WAX ARGUMENT AND WHY BODY IS KNOWN BY INTELLECT	20
SESSION 5 - DESCARTES IV: THE THREE PROOFS OF GOD, THE CARTESIAN CIRCLE, AND THE EXTERNAL WORLD	24
SESSION 6 - DESCARTES V: SUBSTANCE, THE REAL DISTINCTION, INTERACTION, ERROR AND FREEDOM	29
SESSION 7 - SPINOZA I: ONE SUBSTANCE, ATTRIBUTES, MODES, GOD OR NATURE, AND THE PANTHEISM QUESTION	34
SESSION 8 - SPINOZA II: NECESSITY, "ALL DETERMINATION IS NEGATION", AND PARALLELISM	38
SESSION 9 - SPINOZA III: THE THREE KINDS OF KNOWLEDGE, STRIVING, BONDAGE AND FREEDOM	43
SESSION 10 - LEIBNIZ I: MONADS, PERCEPTION AND APPETITION, THE HIERARCHY, AND THE IDENTITY OF INDISCERNIBLES	48
SESSION 11 - LEIBNIZ II: SUFFICIENT REASON, TWO KINDS OF TRUTH, POSSIBLE WORLDS, PRE-ESTABLISHED HARMONY AND FREEDOM	53
SESSION 12 - COMPARISON, CRITICISMS AND REPLIES, ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVES AND PROVENANCE	58
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	65
32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills	65
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	81
Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below	81
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	96
OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER	99

Prerequisite check before using this block	99
A1. The Cartesian-circle literature CAUTION:	100
A2. Spinoza's attributes problem CAUTION:	100
A3. Leibniz on contingency by infinite analysis CAUTION:	100
A4. Pantheism, panentheism and the labelling dispute CAUTION:	100
A5. The analogical predication of "substance" in Descartes CAUTION:	101
A6. Is pre-established harmony unfalsifiable? CAUTION:	101
Conceptual links - not current-affairs items	101
Source trail for this block	101
CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES	101
A. Rationalist operating logic - the five tenets	101
B. Cartesian demolition and reconstruction spine	102
C. Ideas, innateness and the Locke exchange	102
D. The wax argument and certain knowledge	102
E. God in Descartes - three proofs, one objection, one world	102
F. Substance - one criterion, three enforcements	103
G. Spinoza as one integrated system	103
H. Leibniz - plurality without interaction	104
I. God across the trio	104
J. Mind-body and freedom - the ranking rail	104
K. Criticism -> reply -> residual matrix	105
L. Exam craft - PYQ routes, directives, provenance and the final trap sheet	105
COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM	106

Rationalism - Complete Learning Session

Syllabus, verbatim: *Rationalism (Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz); Cartesian Method and Certain Knowledge; Substance; God; Mind-Body Dualism; Determinism and Freedom* - UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section A, item 2.

Evidence discipline: FACT: marks doctrine on which the standard sources converge, ANALYSIS: marks analytical reconstruction for exam use, and CAUTION: marks a live scholarly dispute or a contested attribution. Spinoza is cited by structural reference (*Ethics* I, Definition 7; I, P15; II, P7) because those references are identical in every translation; Descartes is cited by Meditation and Leibniz by section of the *Monadology*. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the original Latin or French term follows immediately - *methodic doubt (dubitatio)*, *thinking thing (res cogitans)*, *God, or Nature (Deus sive Natura)*, *striving (conatus)*, *monads have no windows (les monades n'ont point de fenêtres)*.

What this package contains

Component	Count
Progressive teaching sessions in the Basic block	12
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	14
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6
Consolidated register parts	12 (A-L)
ASCII master flow panels	22

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

CONCEPT SPINE - ENGLISH FIRST, LATIN OR FRENCH IMMEDIATELY AFTER

THE ONE QUESTION ALL THREE MEN ANSWER
WHAT CAN REASON KNOW WITH NECESSITY, AND WHAT IS THERE TO KNOW?

SHARED PREMISE: experience may OCCASION a thought, but it cannot
by itself supply necessity, universality or a first principle

THE TEST THEY ALL INHERIT - WHAT IS A SUBSTANCE?
"that which is in itself and is conceived through itself,
needing nothing else in order to exist"

DESCARTES	SPINOZA	LEIBNIZ
applies the test LOOSELY	applies the test STRICTLY	adds SIMPLICITY to the test
THREE substances God + thinking thing (res cogitans) + extended thing (res extensa)	ONE substance God, or Nature (Deus sive Natura) thought and extension are ATTRIBUTES; minds and bodies are MODES	INFINITELY MANY substances monads: simple, unextended, perceiving, striving bodies = well-founded phenomena (phaenomena bene fundata)
MIND AND BODY INTERACT (pineal gland)	MIND AND BODY are ONE THING under TWO ATTRIBUTES	MIND AND BODY NEVER INTERACT pre-established harmony
GOD GUARANTEES knowledge (no deceiver)	GOD IS THE SYSTEM immanent, not transitive, cause	GOD SELECTS AND HARMONISES the best of all possible worlds
FREEDOM = the will can affirm, deny or withhold assent	FREEDOM = acting from one's own understood nature (adequate ideas)	FREEDOM = spontaneity + intelligence + contingency reasons "incline without necessitating"

THE COST EACH PAYS: Descartes cannot explain interaction;
Spinoza loses individuality and alternative possibilities;
Leibniz must buy correspondence from God in advance

Concept spine: read it downward. One inherited definition of substance, three different degrees of strictness in applying it, and everything else - God, mind, body and freedom - follows from that single decision.

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - substance count "3 -> 1 -> ∞"**. Descartes 3, Spinoza 1, Leibniz ∞. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - mind and body "I-P-H"**. Interaction -> Parallelism -> pre-established Harmony. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - what God does, "G-I-S"**. For Descartes God **Guarantees**, for Spinoza God **Is** the system, for Leibniz God **Selects**.

ANSWER-WORTHINESS - WHAT EARNS MARKS AND WHAT DOES NOT

Classification	Content
CORE MAINS	The basic tenets of rationalism; methodic doubt and the thinking self (<i>cogito</i>); clear and distinct perception; the three kinds of ideas and innate ideas against Locke; the wax argument; the three proofs of God and the Cartesian Circle; the proof of the external world; substance in all three thinkers; God in all three thinkers; interaction, parallelism and pre-established harmony; determinism, necessity and the three accounts of freedom
CORE SUPPORTING	Spinoza's three kinds of knowledge and the fourth-proportional example; striving (<i>conatus</i>) and the passive/active affects, exactly as far as they explain freedom; monadic perception, appetite and hierarchy; the identity of indiscernibles; truths of reason and truths of fact; the best of all possible worlds; the comparative tables; translation and provenance discipline
SUPPORTING	The four rules of method; "hats and coats"; the two-clocks image; the thrown-stone image; <i>natura naturans</i> and <i>natura naturata</i> ; the acosmism charge; Voltaire's <i>Candide</i> as reception, not as doctrine

Classification	Content
OPTIONAL ADVANCED	The Cartesian-circle interpretive literature; the exact status of Spinoza's unknown attributes; contingency by infinite analysis; the panentheism-versus-pantheism labelling dispute
NOT OWNED HERE	Locke's, Berkeley's and Hume's positive systems (Topic 03); Kant's critical synthesis and his refutation of the ontological proof as a <i>doctrine</i> (Topic 04); Descartes' detailed physiology, optics and cosmology; Spinoza's biblical criticism, political theory and full taxonomy of the affects; Leibniz's calculus disputes, relational theory of space and time and the full architecture of the <i>Theodicy</i>

ANALYSIS: **Ownership boundary, stated once.** Locke appears here **only** as the named counter-argument the 2023 paper demands, and Kant appears **only** as a one-line evaluative rider on the ontological proof. Both are legitimate cross-links; neither is marks-essential content in this item, and neither should displace Descartes, Spinoza or Leibniz from the page.

HOW TO READ THIS SESSION

Every subtopic below runs in the same order, so the shape becomes automatic:

Step	What it gives you
DEFINITION	plain-language definition, then the technical one
ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING	a sentence you can adapt directly as an introduction or a conclusion
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS	the terms that signal control of the topic
Plain-language visual	the idea before the vocabulary
VISUAL: VISUAL	the diagram that carries the argument
Numbered teaching	the doctrine, argument by argument, with sources
HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH	claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification, written out for this subtopic
Exam link	which PYQ this subtopic answers, and how
UPSC traps	the specific ways candidates lose marks here
Revision notes	the compressed recall list
CLOSING RECALL FLOW	the subtopic reduced to one flow you can redraw from memory

Complete the Basic block first. Interpretive depth is deliberately withheld until the clearly labelled optional block after the practice sections, so that the core doctrine stays easy to learn and immediately usable. Nothing in the optional block is needed to write a complete answer to any of the fourteen routed questions.

ORIGIN AND CHRONOLOGY - THE MINIMUM NEEDED TO AVOID ANACHRONISM

Rationalism is not three separate biographies. It is one argument that runs for roughly eighty years, in which each thinker reads his predecessor and tightens the same definition.

1596-1650 RENE DESCARTES

- 1637 Discourse on the Method (French) -> the four rules; "I think, therefore I am" (je pense, donc je suis)
- 1641 Meditations on First Philosophy (Latin; French 1647)
 - Meditation I -> senses, dream, evil genius (genius malignus)
 - Meditation II -> "I am, I exist"; the wax; mind better known than body
 - Meditation III -> the causal or "trademark" proof of God
 - Meditation IV -> error: the will outruns the intellect
 - Meditation V -> the ontological proof
 - Meditation VI -> the real distinction; the external world
- 1641 Objections and Replies -> ARNAULD states the Circle (Fourth Objections)
- 1643 Correspondence with PRINCESS ELISABETH OF BOHEMIA -> the interaction problem
- 1644 Principles of Philosophy -> "substance" defined and conceded to be analogical
- 1649 Passions of the Soul -> the pineal gland and the mind-body union

1632-1677 BENEDICT DE SPINOZA (reads Descartes; refuses the looseness)

- 1663 Descartes' Principles of Philosophy, set out geometrically
- 1670 Theological-Political Treatise (published anonymously)
- 1674 LETTER 50 to Jarig Jelles -> "determination is negation"
- 1677 Ethics (posthumous), demonstrated in geometrical order (more geometrico)
 - Part I -> substance, God or Nature, necessity, immanent cause
 - Part II -> attributes, modes, parallelism, the three kinds of knowledge
 - Part III -> striving (conatus) and the affects
 - Part IV -> human bondage; Deus sive Natura appears in the Preface
 - Part V -> freedom, intuitive knowledge, intellectual love of God

1646-1716 GOTTFRIED WILHELM LEIBNIZ (reads both; refuses the single substance)

- 1686 Discourse on Metaphysics -> the complete individual concept
- 1704 New Essays on Human Understanding -> written against Locke (published 1765)
- 1710 Theodicy -> the best of all possible worlds (le meilleur des mondes possibles)
- 1714 Monadology (French; printed 1720/1840) -> Section 7 "monads have no windows"
- 1715-16 Leibniz-Clarke correspondence -> sufficient reason; indiscernibles

- 1759 Voltaire, Candide -> satirises "the best of all possible worlds"
- ANALYSIS: reception, not doctrine: never cite Candide as Leibniz's own position

- FACT: The order is causal, not merely chronological. Spinoza's monism is a *correction* of the equivocation Descartes himself concedes in the *Principles*; Leibniz's pluralism is a *correction* of Spinoza's absorption of individuals.
- ANALYSIS: **Two cautions.** First, the *Ethics* was published only after Spinoza's death, so contemporary reaction to "Spinozism" often ran ahead of the text. Second, the *Monadology* was written in 1714 but printed later, so "Leibniz's system" must be assembled from the *Discourse*, the *Theodicy*, the *Monadology* and the correspondence together - a point that matters when an examiner quotes one work.

ONE-SCREEN ROUTE MAP

WHAT MAKES RATIONALISM A SCHOOL - THE TENETS AND THE SHARED SUBSTANCE TEST

- > DESCARTES I: THE METHOD, METHODIC DOUBT AND THE THINKING SELF
- > DESCARTES II: CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION, THE THREE KINDS OF IDEAS, INNATE IDEAS AND LOCKE'S CHALLENGE
- > DESCARTES III: THE WAX ARGUMENT AND WHY BODY IS KNOWN BY INTELLECT
- > DESCARTES IV: THE THREE PROOFS OF GOD, THE CIRCLE, THE EXTERNAL WORLD
- > DESCARTES V: SUBSTANCE, THE REAL DISTINCTION, INTERACTION, ERROR AND FREEDOM
- > SPINOZA I: ONE SUBSTANCE, ATTRIBUTES, MODES, GOD OR NATURE, PANTHEISM
- > SPINOZA II: NECESSITY, "ALL DETERMINATION IS NEGATION", PARALLELISM
- > SPINOZA III: THREE KINDS OF KNOWLEDGE, STRIVING, BONDAGE AND FREEDOM
- > LEIBNIZ I: MONADS, PERCEPTION AND APPETITION, HIERARCHY, INDISCERNIBLES
- > LEIBNIZ II: SUFFICIENT REASON, TWO KINDS OF TRUTH, POSSIBLE WORLDS, PRE-ESTABLISHED HARMONY AND COMPATIBILIST FREEDOM
- > COMPARISON: SUBSTANCE, GOD, MIND-BODY AND FREEDOM ON MATCHED AXES
- > ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVE DECODING, PROVENANCE AND CITATION DISCIPLINE

This is a route map, not a substitute for the twelve complete Basic subtopics below.

SESSION 1 - WHAT MAKES RATIONALISM A SCHOOL, AND WHY THE THREE SYSTEMS DIVERGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Rationalism is the view that the mind's own resources - not the senses - are what make certain, necessary and universal knowledge possible, and that reality is built so that reason can reach it.

Technical definition: Early-modern rationalism is the doctrine that some concepts and principles are innate or self-evident to the intellect, that intellectual intuition and deduction rather than sense-experience supply the warrant for necessity and universality, that reality has an intelligible rational structure, and that this structure is to be expressed through a metaphysics of substance, attribute and mode.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

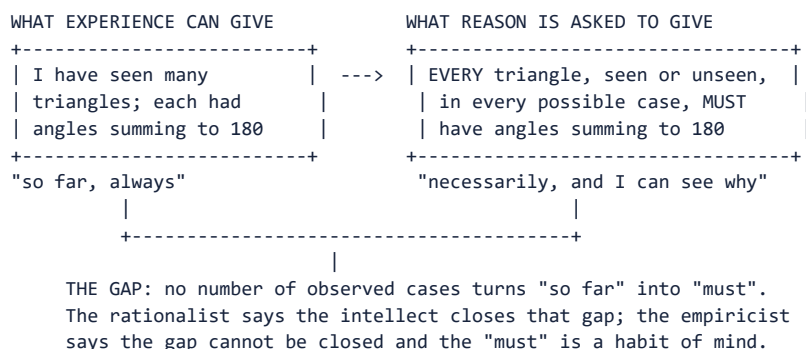
Rationalism is not the denial of experience but a claim about *warrant*: experience may occasion a thought, yet only the intellect can certify that a truth is necessary and universal - and because Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz enforce that single claim with different degrees of strictness on one inherited definition of substance, the same method yields three incompatible worlds, of three substances, of one, and of infinitely many.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **a priori warrant** - necessity and universality, not mere generalisation
- **innate cognitive resources** - native capacities, not preformed conscious propositions
- **intellectual intuition and deduction**
- **intelligibility of the real** - the real is the rational
- **substance, attribute and mode**
- **the "3 -> 1 -> ∞" sequence**

How to use them: Open with warrant rather than with a caricature of the senses; state the five tenets; then use the substance test to show that the divergence is *internal to* rationalism, not evidence against it.

Plain-language visual - why "the senses are enough" is not enough

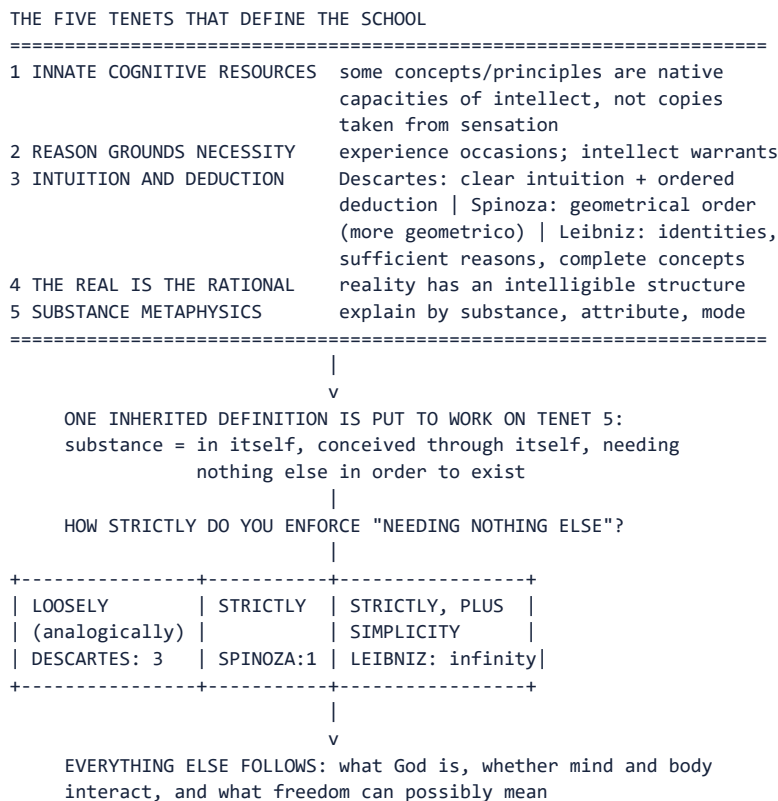


In simple words: everyone agrees that we *learn* about triangles by drawing them. The dispute is about what makes the conclusion *binding*. A rationalist says the binding force comes from the intellect grasping why the thing could not be otherwise. That is the whole quarrel in one line, and it is the line that must open a rationalism answer.

Remember first	Meaning
Occasion vs warrant	sense may <i>start</i> the thought; intellect <i>licenses</i> it
Necessary	could not be otherwise
Universal	holds for all cases, not for all observed cases
<i>A priori</i>	justified independently of any particular experience
Not the claim	that the senses always deceive or that the world is unreal

One-line memory: rationalism is a thesis about **warrant**, not a phobia about **eyes**.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the five tenets and the single test that splits the school



ANALYSIS: Caption. The five tenets are the *shared* content; the single question under them is where the school breaks. An answer that lists the tenets and stops has given the examiner half a page of agreement and no explanation of the disagreement.

1. The five tenets, stated exactly

FACT: The following table is the answer to the first limb of the 2025 twenty-mark question.

Tenet	Content	The precision that earns the mark
Innate cognitive resources	Some concepts and principles are native capacities or structures of the intellect rather than copies derived from sensation	Say <i>capacities</i> or <i>dispositions</i> , not "truths known at birth" - otherwise Locke's objection lands before you have finished the sentence
Reason as the ground of necessity	Experience may occasion thought, but the intellect supplies the warrant for necessity, universality and first principles	The word to use is warrant , not "source of ideas"
Intuition and deduction	Descartes uses clear intellectual intuition and ordered deduction; Spinoza adopts geometrical demonstration (<i>more geometrico</i>); Leibniz reasons through identities, sufficient reasons and complete concepts	Naming the three <i>different</i> methods shows you are not writing a school summary
The intelligibility of reality	The real is the rational: the structure of the world is accessible to reason	This is the tenet that licenses metaphysics at all
Substance metaphysics	Reality is explained in terms of substance or substances, their attributes and their modes	This is the tenet that splits the school, so introduce it last

WRONG: Rationalism is not the claim that all sensory beliefs are false, that the senses are useless, or that every truth is consciously present in the mind at birth. Each of those is a caricature, and each is refuted in one line by an examiner.

2. The one definition all three inherit

FACT: **Substance** is *that which exists in itself, is conceived through itself, and needs nothing else in order to exist*.

The definition contains a hidden dial: **how much dependence is compatible with "needing nothing else"?**

- Descartes turns the dial **down**. God alone needs absolutely nothing; but mind and matter need only God, so they may be called substances in a *dependent* or *created* sense. He concedes the equivocation himself in the *Principles of Philosophy* I.51.
- Spinoza turns the dial **up to maximum**. If a thing is conceived through itself, it cannot depend on anything at all - so only the infinite qualifies, and there is exactly one such thing.
- Leibniz keeps Descartes' plurality but adds a second requirement, **simplicity**: what is extended is divisible, what is divisible is composite, and a composite is not ultimate. So the real units must be partless, and there are infinitely many of them.

MEMORY: **Memory chain: attribute separates -> independence unifies -> simplicity multiplies.**

3. Why a shared method does not force a shared metaphysics

ANALYSIS: This is the mechanism the 2018 twenty-mark question asks for, and it must be stated as a *mechanism*, not as a table.

1. A method tells you **how** to argue: begin from what is evident, proceed in order, admit nothing unexamined.
2. A method does not tell you **which** criterion of "ontologically basic" to enforce, nor how strictly.
3. Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz enforce different criteria - real distinction by principal attribute, absolute independence, and simplicity with internal activity.
4. □ Their disagreement is *produced by* rationalism operating consistently, not by one of them abandoning it.

4. The three consequences that follow immediately

Decision on substance	What God must then be	What mind and body must then be	What freedom can then mean
Descartes - three	a transcendent creator who guarantees knowledge	two really distinct substances that nevertheless interact	the will's power to affirm, deny or withhold assent
Spinoza - one	the one immanent substance, God, or Nature (<i>Deus sive Natura</i>)	one and the same thing under two attributes	acting from one's own understood nature
Leibniz - infinitely many	the necessary being who selects and harmonises the best world	two series of monadic states that correspond without interacting	spontaneity, intelligence and contingency together

FACT: Read the table across, not down. Each row is a single decision worked out to its end, which is why answers that treat "God", "mind-body" and "freedom" as three unrelated questions never reach the top band.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Rationalism is a thesis about the warrant for necessary truth, and its internal disagreements are generated by one shared definition of substance rather than by any departure from the method. **Named evidence.** All three inherit the formula that substance is what exists in itself and is conceived through itself; Descartes concedes in *Principles* I.51 that only God satisfies it without qualification, yet still admits created substances, while Spinoza's *Ethics* I refuses that concession and Leibniz's *Monadology* Section 1-3 adds simplicity as a further requirement. **Analysis.** The concession is the hinge. Once "needing nothing else" is allowed to mean "needing nothing except God", the number of substances becomes a matter of how strictly the phrase is read - and Spinoza and Leibniz simply read it more strictly in two different directions. **Qualification.** The mechanism explains the divergence without settling it: rationalism supplies the deductive ambition and the vocabulary, but it contains no neutral procedure for deciding which criterion of substancehood is the correct one, and that is the honest limit of the school.

Exam link

- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks** - "the basic tenets of Rationalism" is answered from Section 1, and the second limb is answered by carrying those tenets stage by stage through Descartes in Sessions 2 to 6.

- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks** - "the reason for the difference" is answered from Section 2 and Section 3; the examiner is asking for the dial, not for the three positions.
- Every comparative question in the paper opens more strongly if Section 4 is stated as a single decision worked out three times.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
"Rationalists reject sense-experience"	They reject sense-experience as a <i>warrant</i> for necessity; Descartes rebuilds the physical world and Spinoza calls sense the first kind of knowledge, not a nullity
"Innate ideas means babies know geometry"	Innateness is dispositional - a native capacity elicited on an appropriate occasion
Listing the tenets and stopping	The 2025 question has two limbs; the tenets are the smaller one
Treating the three thinkers as three biographies	The examiner rewards the mechanism that connects them
"Rationalism is Western logic, empiricism is Western observation"	Both are theories of justification; the contrast is about warrant, not about temperament

Revision notes

- Five tenets: innate resources; reason grounds necessity; intuition and deduction; the real is the rational; substance metaphysics.
- One definition: in itself, conceived through itself, needing nothing else.
- The dial: loosely -> 3; strictly -> 1; strictly plus simplicity -> ∞.
- Method fixes *how* to argue, not *which* criterion to enforce.
- Substance decision drives God, mind-body and freedom in one movement.
- Never define the school by hostility to the senses.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - WHAT MAKES RATIONALISM A SCHOOL

```

NECESSITY AND UNIVERSALITY NEED A WARRANT EXPERIENCE CANNOT SUPPLY
|
v
FIVE TENETS: innate resources | reason warrants | intuition+deduction |
               the real is rational | substance metaphysics
|
v
ONE INHERITED DEFINITION OF SUBSTANCE -> HOW STRICT IS "NEEDS NOTHING ELSE"?
|
+--> LOOSE (analogical)   -> DESCARTES 3 -> interaction problem
+--> STRICT               -> SPINOZA 1  -> individuality problem
+--> STRICT + SIMPLICITY -> LEIBNIZ oo -> harmony must be bought from God
|
v
GOD, MIND-BODY AND FREEDOM ARE NOT THREE TOPICS BUT ONE DECISION WORKED OUT
TRAP: not anti-sense | not innate propositions | not three biographies
ANSWER LINE: a shared method underdetermines the metaphysics, and that is
              rationalism's honest limit

```

SESSION 2 - DESCARTES I: THE METHOD, METHODIC DOUBT AND THE THINKING SELF

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Descartes deliberately pretends that everything doubtful is false, in order to find out whether anything at all survives - and what survives is the thinking that is doing the doubting.

Technical definition: Methodic or hyperbolic doubt (*dubitatio hyperbolica*) is a foundationalist device that suspends assent to whole classes of belief - the sensory, the perceptual-world-involving and even the mathematical - in order to isolate an indubitable first truth, which Descartes finds in the performative self-verification of "I am, I exist" whenever it

is thought.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Descartes' doubt is not scepticism but scepticism turned into an instrument: it is pushed to the point of self-destruction, because the one proposition it cannot touch is the existence of the thinker who is performing it - and that single performative certainty, not any argument, is the foundation on which the whole rationalist reconstruction is built.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **methodic and hyperbolic doubt** - deliberate, universal, provisional
- **the four rules of method** (*Discourse on the Method*, Part II)
- **sense-deception, the dream argument, the evil genius (genius malignus)**
- **"I am, I exist"** - the *Meditations* formulation
- **"I think, therefore I am" (cogito, ergo sum)** - the *Discourse* and *Principles* formulation
- **immediate intuition, not a syllogism**
- **the Archimedean point**

How to use them: Name the three stages of doubt in order of increasing power, then show that the third stage generates its own defeat, and only then state the *cogito* - with its exact status as an intuition.

Plain-language visual - a ladder of doubt that eats its own last rung

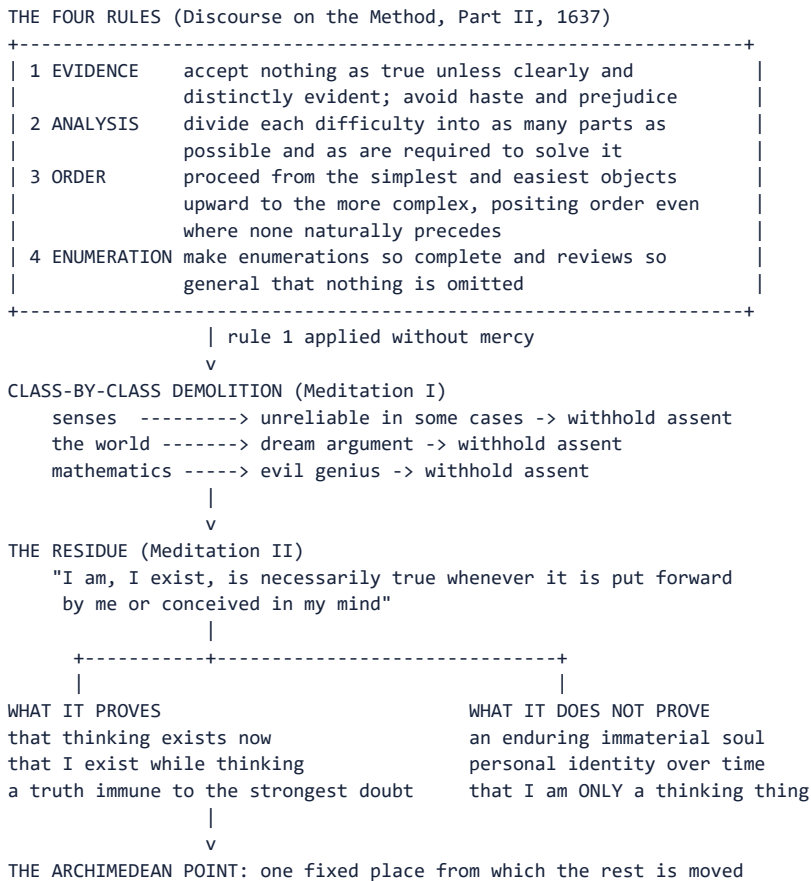
```
RUNG 1  THE SENSES SOMETIMES DECEIVE
         a straight stick looks bent in water; a tower looks round
         -> so sensory beliefs are not certain
         BUT: "I am sitting here holding this paper" still feels safe
         |
RUNG 2  THE DREAM ARGUMENT
         there is no mark by which I can tell waking from dreaming
         -> so the WHOLE external world may be absent
         BUT: 2 + 3 = 5 whether I am awake or asleep
         |
RUNG 3  THE EVIL GENIUS (genius malignus)
         suppose an omnipotent deceiver makes me err even in arithmetic
         -> so even mathematics is suspended
         BUT: to be deceived, I must EXIST to be deceived
         |
         v
        THE LADDER BREAKS UNDER ITS OWN WEIGHT
        "I am, I exist" is true whenever I think it
```

In simple words: each rung is stronger than the last, and Descartes builds them in that order on purpose. The evil genius is not a horror story; it is the strongest possible doubt, invented so that whatever survives *it* cannot be doubted at all. And the deceiver argument is exactly the one that cannot work, because there must be somebody there to be fooled.

Remember first	Meaning
Methodic	adopted deliberately, as a procedure
Hyperbolic	pushed further than ordinary life warrants
Provisional	Descartes does not <i>believe</i> the world is absent
Target	not "many beliefs" but whole <i>classes</i> of belief at once
Result	one proposition that resists the strongest doubt

One-line memory: the doubt is a **tool**, and the *cogito* is what the tool cannot cut.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the method, the doubt and the foundation as one movement



ANALYSIS: **Caption.** Read the two lower boxes together. Almost every avoidable mark loss on this topic comes from letting the left box quietly expand into the right box.

1. The four rules - and why rule 1 does all the damage

FACT: The four rules of the *Discourse on the Method*, Part II are: accept nothing that is not evidently true; divide each problem into parts; proceed in order from simple to complex; make enumerations complete.

ANALYSIS: Rules 2 to 4 are ordinary intellectual hygiene, borrowed from mathematical practice. Rule 1 is the explosive one: if assent is to be withheld from whatever is not *evident*, and if a single counterexample makes a class of beliefs non-evident, then whole classes must go at once. The *Meditations* is rule 1 executed without mercy.

2. The three stages of doubt, in their strict order

Stage	Argument	What it removes	What still survives
Sense-deception	the senses have deceived me before - about a bent stick, a distant tower - and it is imprudent to trust wholly what has deceived even once	the reliability of particular perceptual judgements	apparently, my immediate situation: this hand, this paper
The dream argument	there are no certain marks by which waking can be distinguished from sleep	the immediate situation too, and with it the whole external world	the simple and universal - extension, shape, quantity, number; and mathematics
The evil genius (genius malignus)	suppose not a good God but a supremely powerful malicious deceiver devotes all his effort to deceiving me	even arithmetic and geometry; even "2 + 3 = 5"	only what cannot be false while I am thinking it

FACT: The order is cumulative and deliberate: each stage attacks what the previous stage left standing. Reporting the three arguments in any other order shows the structure has not been understood.

3. The cogito - its exact status

FACT: In the *Discourse* (1637) Descartes writes *je pense, donc je suis*, and the Latin tag *cogito, ergo sum* appears in the *Principles* I.7. In the *Meditations* the formulation is different and more careful: "**I am, I exist, is necessarily true whenever it is put forward by me or conceived in my mind.**"

- FACT: It is **not a syllogism**. Descartes explicitly denies that it is deduced from a suppressed major premise such as "everything that thinks exists"; he says it is grasped by a simple intuition of the mind.
- FACT: Its force is **performative and present-tense**. It is not the claim that thought guarantees existence in general, but that the very act of entertaining the doubt certifies the existence of the doubter at that moment.
- FACT: It defeats the evil genius by *using* him: "let him deceive me as much as he can, he can never bring it about that I am nothing so long as I think I am something."
- ANALYSIS: It is the **Archimedean point** - Descartes' own image of one firm and immovable point sufficient to move the earth.

4. What the cogito does not yet establish

ANALYSIS: This is the single most examined limit in the whole topic, and it is where the 2022 question is won or lost.

1. It establishes that **thinking exists**, and that the thinker exists *while thinking*. It does not by itself establish an **enduring immaterial substance**.
2. It does not establish **diachronic personal identity** - that the thinker now is the same thinker as a moment ago.
3. It does not establish that the thinker is **only** a thinking thing; the real distinction of mind from body is argued much later, in Meditation VI.
4. Descartes therefore spends the rest of Meditation II developing the **thinking thing (res cogitans)** - "a thing that doubts, understands, affirms, denies, is willing, is unwilling, and also imagines and has sensory perceptions."

CAUTION: Later critics press exactly here: Lichtenberg's remark that Descartes was entitled only to "there is thinking", and Hume's bundle theory of the self, both attack the slide from an occurring thought to a substantial thinker. Naming that gap *and* saying that Descartes takes further steps to close it is the mark of a controlled answer.

5. Why this is the rationalist foundation and not just a clever puzzle

ANALYSIS: Three features make the *cogito* a rationalist starting point rather than a sceptical curiosity:

- it is reached **without any sensory premise** - it survives the hypothesis that no body and no world exists;
- it is grasped by **intellectual intuition**, the very faculty tenet 3 of Session 1 privileges;
- it supplies the **model** from which the criterion of truth is read off in Session 3 - Descartes asks what it is about this proposition that makes it certain, and answers: it is clearly and distinctly perceived.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Cartesian doubt is an instrument of certainty rather than an expression of scepticism, because it is designed to isolate a proposition that the strongest possible doubt cannot reach. **Named evidence.** Meditation I proceeds through sense-deception, the dream argument and the hypothesis of an evil genius (*genius malignus*); Meditation II then finds that "I am, I exist" is necessarily true whenever it is put forward or conceived, and the *Principles* I.7 records the shorter tag *cogito, ergo sum*. **Analysis.** The deceiver hypothesis defeats itself: deception presupposes somebody deceived, so the very supposition that maximises doubt guarantees the existence of the doubter. This is why Descartes insists the *cogito* is an immediate intuition and not an inference from "whatever thinks exists". **Qualification.** What is secured is narrower than it looks. The *cogito* certifies present thinking existence, not an enduring immaterial substance or personal identity through time; Descartes needs the rest of Meditation II and the real distinction of Meditation VI for that, which is precisely the gap Lichtenberg and Hume later exploit.

Exam link

- **2022 Q4(b), 15 marks** - the whole first limb, "certainty with reference to knowledge of the self", is Section 2 to Section 4; the second limb needs Session 5.
- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks** - the *cogito* is stage one of "how Descartes builds a system in consonance with" the tenets.
- **2019 Q1(d), 10 marks** - this session supplies the starting point from which the proof of other things must begin.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
Calling the <i>cogito</i> a syllogism	Descartes explicitly denies a suppressed major premise; it is an intuition
Attributing " <i>cogito, ergo sum</i> " to the <i>Meditations</i>	The <i>Meditations</i> has "I am, I exist"; the Latin tag is from the <i>Discourse</i> and <i>Principles</i> I.7
Making the <i>cogito</i> prove an immortal soul at once	It proves thinking existence; substantiality comes later and separately
Describing Descartes as a sceptic	The doubt is methodic, hyperbolic and provisional
Giving the three doubts in the wrong order	The order is cumulative and is itself an argument

Revision notes

- Four rules: evidence, analysis, order, enumeration; rule 1 drives the demolition.
- Doubt in three cumulative stages: senses -> dream -> evil genius.
- *Meditations* wording: "I am, I exist ... whenever it is put forward by me or conceived in my mind".
- Status: immediate intuition, performative, present-tense; not a syllogism.
- Limit: thinking existence, not enduring substance or identity through time.
- Archimedean point: one fixed place from which everything else is moved.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - DESCARTES I: DOUBT AND THE THINKING SELF

```

FOUR RULES -> rule 1: admit only the evident
|
v
SENSE-DECEPTION -> DREAM ARGUMENT -> EVIL GENIUS (genius malignus)
| each stage attacks what the last left standing
v
DECEPTION PRESUPPOSES SOMEONE DECEIVED
|
v
"I AM, I EXIST" whenever it is thought | intuition, NOT a syllogism
|
+--> thinking thing (res cogitans): doubts, understands, affirms,
|     denies, wills, imagines, seems to sense
|
v
ARCHIMEDEAN POINT -> the criterion of truth is read off it (Session 3)
LIMIT: present thinking certain | enduring substance and identity NOT yet
TRAP: not scepticism | not a syllogism | Meditations wording differs from the tag
ANSWER LINE: the doubt is an instrument that destroys itself on the one thing
              it cannot reach

```

SESSION 3 - DESCARTES II: CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION, THE THREE KINDS OF IDEAS, AND INNATE IDEAS AGAINST LOCKE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Having found one certain truth, Descartes asks what made it certain, generalises the answer into a rule, then sorts his ideas by where they come from and argues that the most important ones come from the mind's own nature.

Technical definition: Clear and distinct perception (*perceptio clara et distincta*) is Descartes' criterion of truth, abstracted from the *cogito* as its model; ideas are classified as adventitious (*adventitiae*), factitious (*factitiae*) and innate (*innatae*), and innateness is understood dispositionally as a native capacity of rational cognition rather than as a preformed conscious proposition.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

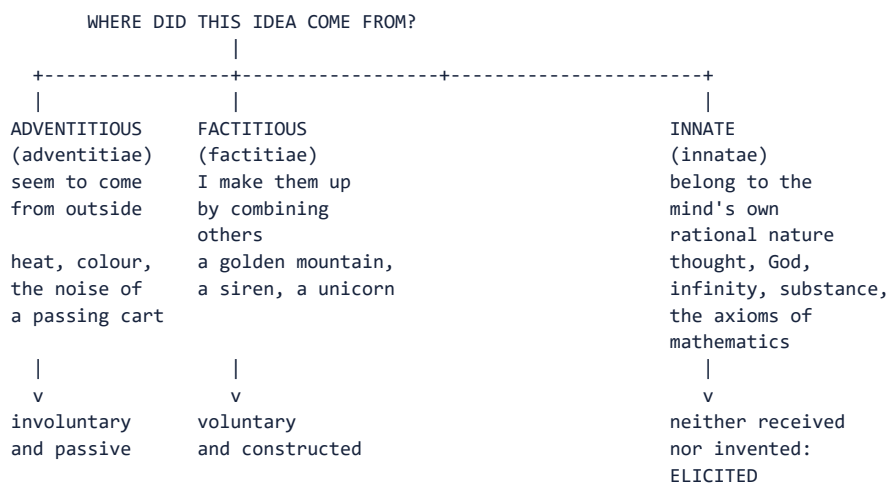
Descartes does not assert innate ideas as an article of faith; he reaches them by an argument from insufficiency - finite, changing sensation cannot be the adequate source of the ideas of infinity, of substance or of exact mathematical necessity - and the strongest version of his claim, that innateness is a disposition rather than a preformed proposition, is precisely the version Locke's universal-assent objection does not touch.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **clear and distinct perception** - the criterion of truth
- **adventitious, factitious and innate ideas**
- **dispositional innateness** - "seeds of knowledge", not conscious propositions
- **objective reality and formal reality** of an idea
- **Locke's tests: universal assent; the transparency of mental content; sensation and reflection**
- **the Essay concerning Human Understanding, Book I**

How to use them: State the criterion and where it comes from; give the threefold classification; state innateness in its *strongest* dispositional form; only then let Locke attack, and adjudicate.

Plain-language visual - three doors into the mind



In simple words: the first two doors are uncontroversial. Everyone agrees I receive a smell and can invent a unicorn. The fight is entirely about the third door - and the fight is won or lost on what "innate" is allowed to mean. If it means "the baby already believes it", Descartes loses immediately. If it means "the mind is so built that, given the occasion, it produces this", he does not.

Remember first	Meaning
Clear	present and open to an attentive mind
Distinct	so sharply separated from everything else that it contains nothing unclear
Adventitious	apparently received from outside
Factitious	made by me out of other ideas
Innate	native to the mind's rational nature, elicited rather than copied

One-line memory: innate is a **capacity**, not a **memory**.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the criterion, the classification and the argument from insufficiency

```

STEP 1 READ THE CRITERION OFF THE MODEL
+-----+
| Why is "I am, I exist" certain? |
| Because I perceive it CLEARLY and DISTINCTLY. |
| RULE: whatever I perceive very clearly and distinctly is true |
+-----+
| (this rule is later put under strain: see the Circle, |
| Session 5, and note that its GENERAL reliability is |
| what God is brought in to secure) |
| v |
STEP 2 SORT THE CONTENTS OF THE MIND
ADVENTITIOUS ----- FACTITIOUS ----- INNATE
passive, involuntary voluntary, made native capacity
| |
| v | v |
STEP 3 THE ARGUMENT FROM INSUFFICIENCY (why the third door is needed)
+-----+
| An idea's OBJECTIVE REALITY (what it represents) must have a |
| cause with at least as much FORMAL REALITY (what it is). |
| |
| IDEA OF THE INFINITE cannot be assembled by adding to |
| or negating the finite, because |
| the finite is understood BY |
| CONTRAST with the infinite |
| IDEA OF SUBSTANCE no sense-organ delivers "bearer |
| of qualities" |
| MATHEMATICAL NECESSITY no finite set of measured figures |
| delivers "must, in every case" |
+-----+
| |
| v |
STEP 4 STATE IT DISPOSITIONALLY, OR LOSE TO LOCKE IN ONE LINE
"innate" = the mind is so constituted that on an appropriate
occasion it produces the idea from its own resources

```

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** Step 4 is the whole examination. Candidates who present Descartes at Step 2 and then report Locke's objections have staged a fight in which one side never got up.

1. The criterion of truth, and where it comes from

FACT: Descartes does not begin with the criterion; he *derives* it. He asks what it is about the *cogito* that makes it indubitable, finds that it is nothing but the clarity and distinctness of the perception, and generalises: **whatever I perceive very clearly and distinctly is true.**

- **Clear** - present and open to an attentive mind, as a plainly visible object is present to the eye.
- **Distinct** - so precisely separated from all other perceptions that it contains within itself only what is clear.

ANALYSIS: Note the structure carefully, because it matters for the Circle in Session 5: at this point Descartes has a rule extracted from *one* instance. Turning it into a general guarantee for perceptions no longer being attended to is exactly the work God is later asked to do.

2. The three kinds of ideas

Kind	Latin	How it arises	Examples	Status
Adventitious	<i>adventitiae</i>	seem to come to me from outside, involuntarily	heat, colour, the sound of a cart	passively received; their external cause is not yet established
Factitious	<i>factitiae</i>	constructed by me from other ideas	a golden mountain, a siren	voluntary; obviously mind-dependent
Innate	<i>innatae</i>	native to the mind's own rational nature	thought, God, infinity, substance, the axioms of mathematics	elicited by occasion, not copied from sense

FACT: The classification appears in Meditation III, and its point is to prepare the causal proof of God: the idea of God is placed in the third class, and its content is then argued to exceed anything a finite mind could have manufactured.

3. The argument from insufficiency - why innate ideas are needed

ANALYSIS: Do not present innate ideas as a bare assertion. Present them as the conclusion of an argument:

1. Some of my ideas have a content - an **objective reality**, in Descartes' technical vocabulary - that no finite, changing sensation could supply.
2. The idea of the **infinite** is the clearest case: it cannot be built by extending or negating the finite, because I recognise myself as finite only by contrast with an already-possessed idea of the infinite.
3. The idea of **substance** - a bearer that persists through changing qualities - is delivered by no sense-organ, as the wax argument in Session 4 shows directly.
4. **Mathematical necessity** cannot be read off any number of measured figures, because measurement yields "so far" and never "must".
5. □ These ideas must be native to the intellect's own constitution.

4. Innateness stated at its strongest

FACT: Descartes' own qualification is essential and is exactly what the 2023 question rewards: innateness need **not** mean an explicitly entertained proposition present in an infant's consciousness. It may be a **disposition** or native capacity, activated on an appropriate occasion - the mind carries "seeds of knowledge" which experience may prompt but does not create.

ANALYSIS: Analogy Descartes himself uses in the *Comments on a Certain Broadsheet*: we say a family has an inherited disposition to a certain disease not because the infant suffers it in the womb but because the constitution is such that the condition will develop. Innateness is a constitution, not a content.

5. Locke's three grounds of refutation, and the Cartesian replies

FACT: Locke attacks innate principles in the *Essay concerning Human Understanding*, Book I, and offers the mind as "white paper, void of all characters", furnished from **sensation** and **reflection**.

Locke's objection	The Cartesian reply	What still stands CAUTION:
No universal assent. Children and "idiots" - Locke's word - do not affirm the alleged innate principles; and a principle assented to by nobody in particular is assented to by nobody	Innateness is dispositional, not continuous conscious assent; universal <i>assent</i> was never the claim	A disposition must be specified narrowly enough that not <i>every</i> learnable truth counts as innate - Locke's sharpest residual point
Nothing can be "in the mind" and unknown. If mental content is transparent, an unperceived principle is not in the mind at all; on that standard every truth the mind can ever reach is already "in" it	Native capacities can operate before reflective recognition; the mind's structure is not the same as the mind's occurrent contents	The reply risks shifting from <i>innate ideas</i> to an uncontroversial <i>capacity to learn</i> , which is not a rationalist thesis at all
Sensation and reflection suffice. All the materials of ideas can be traced to experience and to the mind's observation of its own operations	Finite experience cannot by itself yield the positive idea of infinity or the warrant for mathematical necessity	Locke can reconstruct infinity by repetition and negation, and necessity by abstraction - whether that reconstruction succeeds is the live question

ANALYSIS: **The adjudication that earns the mark:** Locke decisively refutes *occurrent* innatism - the doctrine that the mind is born consciously holding propositions. He does not as clearly refute *dispositional* innatism. But the burden then shifts to the rationalist to say what makes a disposition specifically innate rather than merely a general capacity to learn, and that is the point at which the debate is genuinely unresolved.

6. Where this feeds the system

- The criterion of truth from Section 1 is the rule that God will be asked to underwrite (Session 5).
- The innate **idea of God** from Section 2 and Section 3 is the premise of the causal proof (Session 5).
- The innate **idea of extension** is what the wax argument isolates (Session 4).
- The innate **idea of substance** is what makes the whole substance metaphysics of Session 6 available at all.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Descartes' doctrine of innate ideas is an argument from the insufficiency of sensation, and it survives Locke only in its dispositional form. **Named evidence.** Meditation III divides ideas into adventitious, factitious and innate and locates the idea of God in the third class on the ground that its objective reality exceeds what a finite mind could supply; Locke's *Essay* I replies with the absence of universal assent among children, the transparency of mental content, and the sufficiency of sensation and reflection. **Analysis.** The two sides are not disagreeing about infants. Descartes' considered claim is that the mind's constitution produces certain ideas on an appropriate occasion, so absence of infant assent is simply irrelevant to it; Locke's real force lies in his second objection, which demands a criterion separating an innate disposition from a general capacity to learn. **Qualification.** On that demand Descartes is weaker than he needs to be: he shows convincingly that infinity and necessity are not copies of sensation, but he does not supply an independent test for innateness, so the doctrine ends the exchange defensible in its dispositional form and unproven in its strong form.

Exam link

- **2023 Q2(c), 15 marks** - this session is the answer: Section 2 to Section 4 for Descartes, Section 5 for Locke's grounds and the adjudication.
- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks** - tenet 1, "innate cognitive resources", is instantiated here, and the criterion of Section 1 is the second stage of the system.
- **2019 Q1(d) and 2022 Q4(b)** - both depend on the criterion of Section 1 being in place before God is proved.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
"Innate ideas = knowledge present at birth"	Dispositional innateness: a native capacity elicited on occasion
Presenting Locke's objections without the strongest Descartes	The 2023 question asks for the theory <i>and</i> the grounds of refutation; a weak Descartes forfeits half the marks
Treating "clear and distinct" as a mere synonym for "obvious"	Clear = present to an attentive mind; distinct = containing nothing else
Saying Locke proves ideas come from the senses	Locke's sources are sensation and reflection ; omitting reflection misstates him
Forgetting that the criterion is <i>derived</i> from the <i>cogito</i>	It is read off the model case, which is why its general reliability later needs God

Revision notes

- Criterion: whatever is perceived clearly and distinctly is true; derived from the *cogito*, not assumed.
- Three kinds of ideas: adventitious, factitious, innate.
- Innate is dispositional - "seeds of knowledge", a constitution not a content.
- Argument from insufficiency: infinity, substance, mathematical necessity.
- Locke, *Essay* I: no universal assent; nothing unknown is in the mind; sensation and reflection suffice.
- Verdict: occurrent innatism refuted; dispositional innatism survives but under-specified.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - DESCARTES II: IDEAS AND THE CRITERION

WHY WAS THE COGITO CERTAIN? -> because clearly and distinctly perceived
|
v
RULE: whatever is perceived clearly and distinctly is true
| (its GENERAL reliability is what God will underwrite)
v
IDEAS SORTED: adventitious | factitious | INNATE
|
v
ARGUMENT FROM INSUFFICIENCY: infinity | substance | mathematical necessity
| finite sensation cannot be their adequate cause
v
INNATE = DISPOSITION (seeds of knowledge), not a preformed proposition
|
+--> LOCKE, Essay I: no universal assent | nothing unknown is in
| the mind | sensation and reflection suffice
+--> REPLY: dispositions need no infant assent; capacities precede
| reflective recognition; infinity is not built from the finite
v
VERDICT: occurrent innatism falls | dispositional innatism stands, but owes
| a criterion distinguishing it from a bare capacity to learn
TRAP: never defend the caricature; never omit Locke's "reflection"
ANSWER LINE: Locke refutes the version Descartes' best texts do not hold

SESSION 4 - DESCARTES III: THE WAX ARGUMENT AND WHY BODY IS KNOWN BY INTELLECT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Descartes takes the clearest possible physical object, melts it, notices that every sensible feature has changed while he still judges it to be the same thing, and concludes that what he grasps as "the wax" was never delivered by the senses at all.

Technical definition: The wax argument of Meditation II is a thought-experiment showing (a) that the identity of a body through total qualitative replacement is grasped by the intellect alone - by "mental scrutiny" (*inspectio mentis*) rather than by sense (*sensus*) or imagination (*imaginatio*) - (b) that the essence of body is extension, and (c) that the mind is better known (*notior*) than any body.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

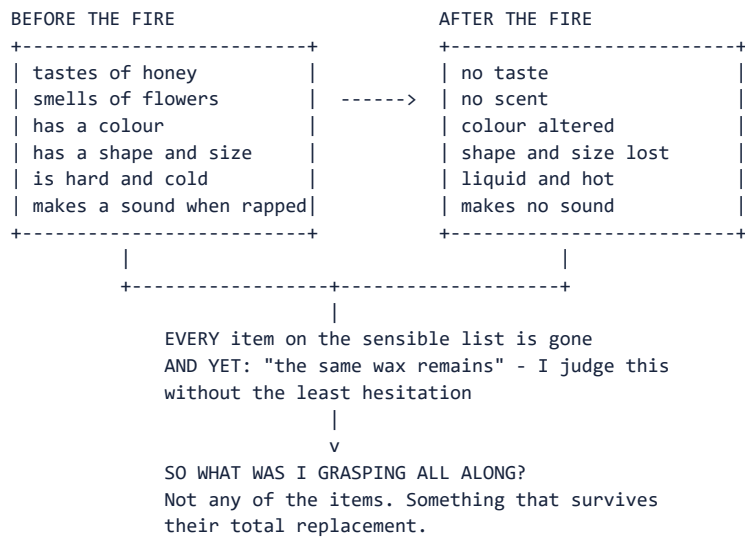
The wax argument is the missing half of "certain knowledge": the thinking self (*cogito*) tells Descartes *that* he exists, and the wax tells him *what kind* of thing he is and *how* bodies are known - for when every sensible property of the wax has been destroyed and the same wax is still judged to remain, what remains cannot be anything the senses ever supplied.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **the wax (cera)** - the clearest possible case of a body
- **mental scrutiny (inspectio mentis)** - rendered "purely mental scrutiny" in the Cottingham-Stoothoff-Murdoch translation
- **sense (sensus), imagination (imaginatio), understanding (intellectus)**
- **"flexible and changeable" (flexibile et mutabile)**
- **the extended thing (res extensa)**
- **"hats and coats"** - the paired case in the same Meditation
- **better known (notior)** - the printed sub-title of Meditation II

How to use them: Number the steps. The examiner is looking for a reconstruction, not for a story about a candle.

Plain-language visual - everything changes, and yet it is the same wax



In simple words: ask a friend what the wax *is*. They will list what they can see, smell and touch. Melt it, and every item on their list is false - yet nobody says a *new object* has appeared. That judgement of sameness is doing work no sense-organ could have done, and Descartes' entire point is to make that invisible work visible.

Remember first	Meaning
The catalogue	taste, scent, colour, shape, size, hardness, coldness, sound
What survives	something extended, flexible and changeable
Who grasps it	the understanding (<i>intellectus</i>), not sense or imagination
The paired case	"hats and coats": I say I see men, but strictly I judge
The conclusion	the mind is <i>notior</i> - more evidently known - than the body

One-line memory: the wax does **not** prove that bodies exist; it proves *how* they would be known if they do.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the eight steps, and the four presuppositions underneath them

- 1 TAKE THE CLEAREST CASE: wax fresh from the honeycomb
sensible catalogue = taste | scent | colour | shape | size |
hardness | coldness | sound when rapped
- 2 MOVE IT TO THE FIRE -> every item destroyed or replaced
- 3 YET I JUDGE, WITHOUT HESITATION, THAT THE SAME WAX REMAINS
- 4 THEREFORE what I take the wax to BE is not identical with any
item at step 1 - all were replaced while the wax persisted
- 5 NOR IS IT IMAGINATION: heat can give the wax an INDEFINITE
number of shapes and sizes; I cannot run through indefinitely
many images (this is the force of *flexibile et mutabile*)
- 6 THEREFORE the wax is grasped as an EXTENDED, FLEXIBLE,
CHANGEABLE thing by the INTELLECT ALONE - by *inspectio mentis*
- 7 FURTHER: at every stage - judging the wax present, doubting it,
being deceived about it - I perceive MYSELF judging
- 8 THEREFORE (a) bodies are known by understanding, not by sense
(b) the mind is NOTIOR - more evidently known - than
any body, because it survives even if the body
does not exist

----- WHAT THE ARGUMENT ASSUMES -----

P1 SUBSTANCE/ATTRIBUTE METAPHYSICS IS ALREADY IN PLACE
identity through total qualitative replacement needs a BEARER
distinct from the qualities - step 3 uses the very metaphysics
the Meditations claim to derive

P2 SENSE IS EXHAUSTED BY THE CATALOGUE
if sense could deliver a structural or relational item, step 4 fails

P3 IMAGINATION IS IMAGE-BOUND and therefore finite in range,
while intellect is not

P4 PERCEPTION IS SELF-INTIMATING
I cannot perceive without perceiving THAT I perceive - step 7
depends wholly on this

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** State the presuppositions. They are where the fifteen-mark and twenty-mark marks are, because they show you can see what an argument *costs* as well as what it delivers.

1. The paired case in the same Meditation

FACT: Descartes immediately supplies a second, homelier example: looking from a window he says he **sees men** crossing the square; strictly he sees only **hats and coats**, and *judges* that men are underneath. The moral is identical - what passes for seeing is in fact judging, an operation of the intellect.

ANALYSIS: Use "hats and coats" when the answer needs a second illustration in one line. It is Descartes' own, it is memorable, and it shows the argument is not a one-off trick with a candle.

2. What the argument establishes, exactly

Claim	Established?	Note
Bodily identity through change is grasped by intellect	FACT: yes	This is the argument's main result
The essence of body is extension	FACT: yes, within this Meditation	Which is why Meditation VI's dualism is partly pre-installed here
The mind is better known than the body	FACT: yes, in the sense of <i>more indubitable</i>	Epistemic priority, not richer content
Bodies exist	WRONG: no	External existence is restored only in Meditation VI by divine veracity
Knowledge of body is <i>a priori</i>	CAUTION: contested	Descartes shows the concept is not an image; he has not shown the knowledge is independent of experience

3. The three strongest objections, with replies

Objection	Source	Reply	Residual CAUTION:
What survives melting is just "extended stuff", an abstraction built up from repeated sense-experience, not an intellectual intuition	Gassendi, <i>Fifth Objections</i> ; the empiricist line generally	The abstraction still has to be of something identical across the change; the empiricist must name the sensory item that registers identity , and there is none	Descartes has shown the <i>concept</i> is not an image; he has not shown that the <i>knowledge</i> is a priori
Strip away every sensible quality and nothing remains to be known - "extension" without sensible qualities is unintelligible	Berkeley, <i>Principles</i> Section 9-11	Extension is not a further quality but the <i>mode of being</i> of every quality that could be sensed	The reply presupposes exactly what Berkeley denies
Step 7 confuses certainty with content : that my knowledge of mind is more <i>certain</i> does not make it richer or prior in <i>content</i>	ANALYSIS: analytic reconstruction	Descartes needs only epistemic priority for the order of the <i>Meditations</i>	Fair; "better known" must be read strictly as <i>more indubitable</i>

4. Why the rationalist programme needs this session

ANALYSIS: Without the wax, "Cartesian Method and Certain Knowledge" is a half-answer. The *cogito* gives one certain existential truth; the wax gives the **general epistemology** - that even in the most favourable case for the senses, it is the intellect that does the knowing. That is the claim which makes the reconstruction in Session 5 a *rationalist* reconstruction rather than a lucky escape from doubt.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. The wax argument establishes not that bodies exist but that, if they are known at all, they are known by the intellect and not by the senses - and that self-knowledge is epistemically prior to knowledge of the world. **Named evidence.** In Meditation II a piece of wax loses taste, scent, colour, shape, size, hardness, coldness and sound near the fire, yet is judged to be the same wax; imagination cannot supply the indefinitely many shapes that "flexible and changeable" (*flexibile et mutabile*) requires; the same Meditation adds the "hats and coats" case, and its printed sub-title already announces that the mind is better known than the body. **Analysis.** Since every member of the sensible catalogue is replaced while the object persists, what is grasped cannot be any of them; and because the range of possible shapes is indefinite, no image can be the vehicle. Only mental scrutiny (*inspectio mentis*) remains, and each such act of judging simultaneously discloses the judging mind. **Qualification.** The result is bought at a price the answer should name: identity through total qualitative replacement already presupposes a bearer distinct from its qualities, so Meditation II installs the substance-attribute framework and the essence of body as extension before Meditation VI claims to prove the real distinction - the *Meditations* must therefore be read as one deductive arc, not six independent exercises.

Exam link

- **2022 Q4(b), 15 marks** - Section 2 supplies the exact asymmetry between knowledge of self and knowledge of the world that the question turns on.
- **2019 Q1(d), 10 marks** - the wax must be *excluded* from the proof of external things; saying so explicitly is itself a mark.
- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks** - the wax is the clearest single demonstration that Descartes' system makes intellect, not sense, the judge.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
"The wax argument proves the external world exists"	It proves nothing about existence; Meditation VI does that, through divine veracity
Retelling the melting as a story	The examiner wants numbered steps and a conclusion
Omitting imagination from the argument	Step 5 is essential: imagination fails because the possible shapes are indefinite
"Better known" means the mind is richer or more fully understood	It means <i>more indubitable</i> - epistemic, not content, priority
Ignoring the presuppositions	P1 in particular is where a fifteen- or twenty-mark answer separates itself

Revision notes

- Catalogue: taste, scent, colour, shape, size, hardness, coldness, sound.
- All replaced; the same wax is still judged to remain.
- Not sense (all items gone), not imagination (indefinitely many shapes), therefore intellect - *inspectio mentis*.
- Result: extended, flexible, changeable thing; bodies known by understanding; mind *notior*.
- Paired case: "hats and coats" - seeing is judging.
- Presuppositions: bearer metaphysics; sense exhausted by the catalogue; imagination image-bound; perception self-intimating.
- The wax does **not** prove that bodies exist.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - DESCARTES III: THE WAX

```

CLEAREST CASE OF A BODY: wax from the honeycomb
  | sensible catalogue: taste scent colour shape size hardness cold sound
  v
FIRE DESTROYS EVERY ITEM -> YET "the same wax remains"
  |
  +--> not any sensible item (all replaced)
  +--> not imagination (indefinitely many shapes: flexible et mutabile)
  v
INTELLECT ALONE: inspectio mentis -> extended, flexible, changeable thing
  |
  +--> "hats and coats": what passes for seeing is judging
  v
EVERY JUDGEMENT OF WAX DISCLOSES THE JUDGING MIND -> mind is NOTIOR
  |
  v
ASSUMES: bearer metaphysics | sense = the catalogue | imagination image-bound |
          perception self-intimating
LIMIT: proves HOW body is known, NOT THAT body exists
ANSWER LINE: Meditation II installs extension as body's essence, so Meditation VI's
              dualism is partly presupposed rather than proved

```

SESSION 5 - DESCARTES IV: THE THREE PROOFS OF GOD, THE CARTESIAN CIRCLE, AND THE EXTERNAL WORLD

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Descartes argues that a perfect God exists, that a perfect being would not systematically deceive, and that this is what finally licenses him to trust his own clear thinking and to believe there is a physical world outside his mind.

Technical definition: Descartes offers a causal or "trademark" proof (Meditation III), a conservation or cosmological variant (Meditation III) and an ontological proof (Meditation V); divine veracity is then used to underwrite the general reliability of clear and distinct perception and, through the involuntariness of sensory ideas and an uncorrectable natural inclination, to demonstrate the existence of extended material things (Meditation VI).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

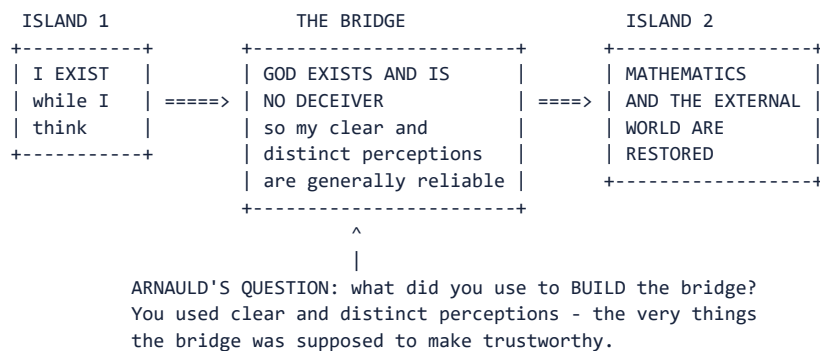
God is not an appendix to Descartes' epistemology but its load-bearing joint: the thinking self yields one certainty and no more, and it is only a non-deceiving God who converts a rule read off a single case into a general licence to trust reason - which is why the Cartesian Circle is not a peripheral blemish but an objection aimed exactly at the point where the system carries its weight.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **the trademark or causal proof** - objective reality requires a cause with at least as much formal reality
- **the conservation proof** - I cannot sustain myself from moment to moment
- **the ontological proof** - existence belongs to the concept of a supremely perfect being
- **divine veracity** - "God is no deceiver"
- **the Cartesian Circle** - Arnauld, Fourth Objections
- **the memory reply** - present intuition versus remembered demonstration
- **passive faculty of sensory reception; great natural inclination**

How to use them: Give the three proofs compactly; state the Circle in one sentence and the reply in one sentence; then run the external-world proof as a numbered argument. Do not let the proofs of God swallow the whole answer.

Plain-language visual - the bridge, and the crack in it



In simple words: Descartes is standing on a small safe island and wants to reach a large one. He builds a bridge out of God. The objection is that the planks of the bridge were cut from the far island he has not yet reached. That is the Circle in one picture - and the reply is that some planks are so solid that you can stand on them while you are looking at them, and God is needed only to certify the ones you have laid down and walked past.

Remember first	Meaning
Objective reality	how much reality an idea <i>represents</i>
Formal reality	how much reality a thing <i>has</i>
Causal principle	the cause must have at least as much reality as the effect represents
Divine veracity	a perfect being will not systematically deceive
The Circle	the criterion proves God; God certifies the criterion

One-line memory: God is the **bridge**, and the Circle is the question of where the **planks** came from.

VISUAL: VISUAL - three proofs, one objection, one world

PROOF 1 - TRADEMARK / CAUSAL (Meditation III)

```
+-----+
| 1 I have an idea of God: an infinite, perfect being |
| 2 The cause of an idea must have at least as much FORMAL reality |
|   as the idea has OBJECTIVE reality |
| 3 I, finite and imperfect, cannot be the adequate cause of an |
|   idea of an infinite perfect being |
| 4 THEREFORE God exists as its cause - He "stamped" the idea on my |
|   mind as a craftsman's mark on his work (hence "trademark") |
+-----+
```

PROOF 2 - CONSERVATION / COSMOLOGICAL VARIANT (Meditation III)

```
+-----+
| I exist now; nothing in me gives me the power to sustain myself |
| from one moment to the next; the cause of my continued existence |
| must therefore ultimately be God |
+-----+
```

PROOF 3 - ONTOLOGICAL (Meditation V)

```
+-----+
| 1 The concept of God = the concept of a supremely perfect being |
| 2 Existence is a perfection |
| 3 A supremely perfect being lacking existence would lack a |
|   perfection - a contradiction, like a triangle without three |
|   angles or a mountain without a valley |
| 4 THEREFORE God necessarily exists |
| [Kant will later object that existence is not a real predicate; |
|   that is Topic 04 doctrine and belongs here only as one rider] |
+-----+
```

|
v

DIVINE VERACITY: a perfect being is no deceiver

|

+-----+	+-----+
GENERAL RELIABILITY OF CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION	THE EXTERNAL WORLD (Meditation VI)
<-- ARNAULD'S CIRCLE STRIKES HERE (Fourth Objections) criterion -> God -> criterion	1 sensory ideas come involuntarily -> I have a PASSIVE faculty
	2 a passive faculty needs an ACTIVE cause
REPLY: while a clear intuition is being ATTENDED TO it compels assent without a guarantee; God is needed for perceptions merely REMEMBERED, and for long chains of reasoning	3 I have a great natural INCLINATION to refer them to bodies
	4 if no bodies existed and God permitted this uncorrectable inclination, God would be a deceiver
RESIDUAL: the divine proofs THEMSELVES use remembered premises and extended inference	5 THEREFORE material things exist as extended realities

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** The right-hand column is a five-step argument and should be written as one. Candidates who write "God guarantees the world" have compressed away every mark in the question.

1. The three proofs - what each is for

FACT: Descartes does not repeat himself. The three proofs answer different questions:

- The **trademark or causal proof** answers: *where could this idea have come from?* It is the proof that uses the innate idea of God established in Session 3.
- The **conservation proof** answers: *what keeps me in existence?* It converts the *cogito*'s momentary certainty into a demand for a continuing cause.
- The **ontological proof** answers: *what does the concept itself contain?* It requires no premise about me at all, which is why Descartes places it after the criterion has been secured.

ANALYSIS: Naming the division of labour is worth more than reciting all three at length.

2. The Cartesian Circle, stated fairly

FACT: **The objection (Arnauld, Fourth Objections).** Descartes uses clear and distinct perception to prove that God exists; he then uses God's veracity to guarantee that clear and distinct perception is reliable. The guarantee therefore presupposes what it is meant to establish.

FACT: **The reply.** Descartes distinguishes two situations. While a clear and distinct perception is **actually before the mind**, it compels assent and needs no external certificate. What needs certifying is (i) the perception merely **remembered** as having been clear, and (ii) any **extended chain** of reasoning whose earlier steps are no longer in view. God secures the second class, not the first.

CAUTION: **What still stands.** The proofs of God are not single-flash intuitions; they are arguments with premises, and by the time the conclusion is reached the earlier premises are being remembered rather than attended to. So the reply softens the objection without eliminating it, and honest answers say so.

3. The proof of the external world - the 2019 question in five steps

FACT: Meditation VI:

1. Sensory ideas occur **involuntarily**: I cannot decide not to feel heat when near the fire. So I have a **passive faculty** of receiving them.
2. A passive faculty requires an **active cause** which contains that reality formally or eminently.
3. The candidates are: myself, God directly, or bodies. It is not myself, because the ideas arrive without my willing them.
4. I have a **great natural inclination** to refer them to bodies, and no faculty by which God could have given me the means to correct it. If no bodies existed, God would be permitting an uncorrectable systematic error - that is, deceiving.
5. ☐ Material things exist as **extended** realities.

ANALYSIS: **What the proof secures and what it does not.** It secures the existence of body and the reality of extension far more strongly than the literal accuracy of any particular colour, size, distance or sensible quality. Descartes insists that the intellect must correct sensory error; the senses are reliable for what is useful to the mind-body union, not for metaphysics.

WRONG: **The wax argument does not do this work.** The wax shows how bodies would be known; it says nothing about whether any exist.

4. God's place in the architecture

What God supplies	Where it is used	If God fails
General reliability of clear and distinct perception	everywhere after Meditation III	nothing beyond the momentary <i>cogito</i> survives
Trustworthiness of memory and long proofs	mathematics; all systematic science	the system contracts to isolated intuitions
The non-deceiving guarantee behind natural inclination	the external world	the world remains unproved
Continuous conservation of finite substances	the substance metaphysics of Session 6	"created substance" loses its ground

ANALYSIS: This table is the reason the standard verdict runs: *the Meditations stand or fall on Meditation III, not Meditation II.*

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Descartes proves the existence of things other than himself and God by a causal argument that is licensed entirely by divine veracity. **Named evidence.** Meditation VI observes that sensory ideas arrive involuntarily and so imply a passive faculty needing an active cause; it identifies a great natural inclination to attribute them to bodies and no faculty by which the inclination could be corrected; and it concludes that a non-deceiving God, already established in Meditation III by the trademark and conservation proofs and in Meditation V by the ontological proof, could not permit such an uncorrectable error. **Analysis.** The structure is therefore theological rather than perceptual: what is doing the work is not the vividness of experience but the impossibility of divine deception, which is why the conclusion secures extension and body while leaving the accuracy of particular sensible qualities to be corrected by intellect. **Qualification.** The whole bridge inherits Arnauld's Circle: if the proofs of God themselves proceed by extended reasoning whose earlier premises must be remembered, then the memory-reply cannot fully insulate them, and the external world is only as secure as the divine proofs on which it rests.

Exam link

- **2019 Q1(d), 10 marks** - Section 3 is the answer, and Section 2 supplies the evaluative paragraph.
- **2022 Q4(b), 15 marks** - the second limb, "how it differs from the knowledge of the world", is exactly the contrast between immediate self-knowledge and this mediated, theologically licensed world-knowledge.
- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks** - stages 4 and 5 of "how Descartes builds a system in consonance with" the tenets.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
"Descartes proved the external world first, then God"	The order is: thinking self -> God -> world. God is the bridge
Merging the three proofs into one	They answer three different questions; the division of labour is examinable
Presenting the Circle without Descartes' reply	And presenting the reply without its residual weakness
"God guarantees the world" as a whole answer	The 2019 question wants the five-step causal argument
Treating Kant's objection as Descartes' own problem	Kant belongs to Topic 04; use one rider line, not a paragraph

Revision notes

- Three proofs: trademark/causal (III), conservation (III), ontological (V).
- Objective versus formal reality; the causal adequacy principle.
- Divine veracity -> general reliability of clear and distinct perception.
- Circle (Arnauld, Fourth Objections): criterion -> God -> criterion.
- Reply: attended intuition compels; God certifies memory and long chains. Residual: the proofs use remembered premises.
- World: involuntary ideas -> passive faculty -> active cause -> great natural inclination -> no correcting faculty -> bodies exist.
- Secured: existence of body and extension. Not secured: literal accuracy of sensible qualities.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - DESCARTES IV: GOD, THE CIRCLE AND THE WORLD

INNATE IDEA OF GOD (Session 3)

- |
- +++> TRADEMARK: objective reality needs an adequate formal cause
- +++> CONSERVATION: I cannot sustain myself moment to moment
- +++> ONTOLOGICAL: existence belongs to a supremely perfect being
- v

GOD EXISTS -> GOD IS NO DECEIVER (divine veracity)

- |
- +++> general reliability of clear and distinct perception
- |
- | ^
- | | ARNAULD'S CIRCLE: criterion proved God; God certifies criterion
- | | REPLY: attended intuition needs no certificate; God secures
- | | memory + long chains. RESIDUAL: the proofs use memory too
- |
- v

EXTERNAL WORLD (Meditation VI), five steps:

- involuntary sensory ideas -> passive faculty -> needs an active cause ->
- great natural inclination to bodies -> no faculty to correct it ->
- a non-deceiving God could not permit it -> BODIES EXIST, AS EXTENDED
- |
- v

SECURED: body and extension | NOT SECURED: exact colours, sizes, distances

TRAP: order is self -> God -> world | the wax proves no existence

ANSWER LINE: the Meditations stand or fall on Meditation III, not Meditation II

SESSION 6 - DESCARTES V: SUBSTANCE, THE REAL DISTINCTION, INTERACTION, ERROR AND FREEDOM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Descartes concludes that mind and body are two completely different kinds of thing, each able to exist without the other, and then has to explain how two such different things manage to affect each other in a human being.

Technical definition: Cartesian substance dualism holds that thinking substance (*res cogitans*), whose principal attribute is thought, and extended substance (*res extensa*), whose principal attribute is extension, are really distinct created substances under the infinite substance God; interactionism holds that they nevertheless act causally on one another in the human being, a union Descartes treats as a primitive notion and locates physiologically at the pineal gland.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

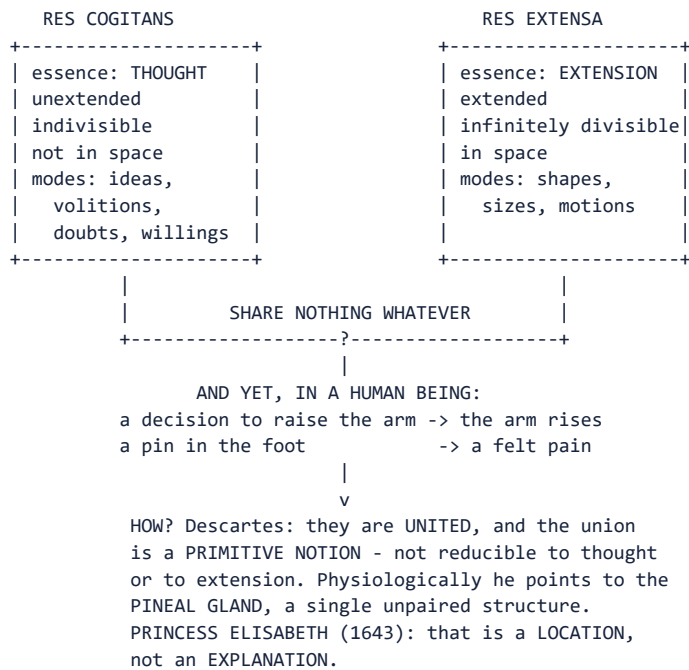
Cartesian dualism is generated by Descartes' own criterion rather than by any prejudice about souls: because thought and extension are conceived clearly and distinctly without one another, they must be really distinct - and the price of that clean separation is an interaction problem so intractable that both Spinoza and Leibniz build entire metaphysics to avoid it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **thinking thing (*res cogitans*) and extended thing (*res extensa*)**
- **principal attribute; modes**
- **real distinction** - clear and distinct conception of each without the other
- **created substance** - the analogical use conceded in *Principles* I.51
- **the substantial union; a primitive notion**
- **the pineal gland** (*Passions of the Soul*)
- **the interaction problem** - Princess Elisabeth of Bohemia, 1643
- **error: the will (infinite) outruns the intellect (finite)**

How to use them: Derive the dualism from the criterion; state the union honestly; then present the interaction problem as the objection that shapes the rest of the syllabus item.

Plain-language visual - two things with nothing in common, joined anyway

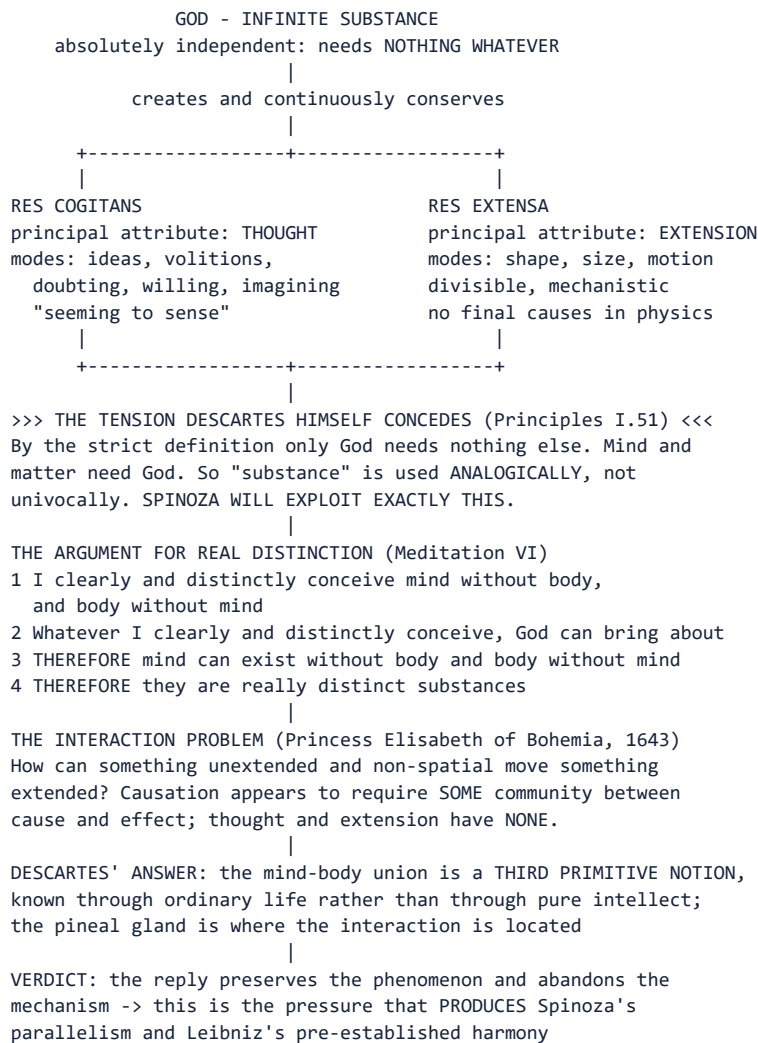


In simple words: two boxes that share no property at all are asked to push each other. Descartes' honest answer, given to Elisabeth, is that the union is something we all *experience* and nobody can *analyse* - that it is a third primitive notion alongside thought and extension. That is a concession, not a solution, and saying so is what an examiner is waiting for.

Remember first	Meaning
Principal attribute	the one property that constitutes a substance's essence
Mode	a particular way of being that attribute
Real distinction	each can be clearly conceived without the other, so each can exist without the other
Created substance	needs God, and nothing else
Primitive notion	not analysable into thought or extension

One-line memory: the pineal gland gives interaction an **address**, not an **explanation**.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the three substances, the real distinction and the objection



ANALYSIS: **Caption.** The arrow at the bottom is the reason this session must come *before* Spinoza and Leibniz. Their systems are not alternatives chosen at random; they are answers to this box.

1. Substance, attribute and mode - the Cartesian vocabulary

FACT: Each substance has exactly **one principal attribute** which constitutes its essence and to which all its other properties are referred. Thought is the principal attribute of mind; extension is the principal attribute of body. Everything else - a particular idea, a particular volition, a particular shape or motion - is a **mode**, a determinate way of being that attribute.

ANALYSIS: The vocabulary matters for comparison: Spinoza will keep the words *attribute* and *mode* and change what they attach to. Getting this right in Session 7 is the difference between a comparison and a muddle.

2. The real distinction, as an argument

FACT: Meditation VI:

1. I have a clear and distinct idea of myself as a thinking, non-extended thing, and a clear and distinct idea of body as an extended, non-thinking thing.
2. Whatever I can clearly and distinctly conceive as separate, God is able to create as separate.
3. ☐ Mind can exist without body, and body without mind.
4. ☐ They are **really distinct** - two substances, not two aspects of one.

ANALYSIS: Everything in this argument rests on the criterion of Session 3 and therefore on the divine guarantee of Session 5. The dualism is a *conclusion* of the system, not its starting assumption.

3. The concession that Spinoza will use

FACT: In the *Principles of Philosophy* I.51 Descartes concedes that, strictly, only God satisfies the definition of substance, since only God depends on nothing whatever; created things depend on God's concurrence for their existence. He therefore uses "substance" **analogically**.

ANALYSIS: This concession is the single most productive sentence in the topic. It is the reason Spinoza can claim to be a *more consistent Cartesian* rather than an opponent, and it is the exact answer to the 2018 twenty-mark question.

4. Interaction, the union, and Elisabeth's objection

FACT: In a human being, mind and body are not merely juxtaposed like a pilot in a ship; they are **intimately united**, which is why we feel pain rather than merely observe damage.

FACT: Descartes locates the point of interaction at the **pineal gland**, chosen because it is a single unpaired structure at the centre of the brain, whereas most brain structures are duplicated.

FACT: **Princess Elisabeth of Bohemia** (correspondence of 1643) presses the question that has defined the problem ever since: how can a thing whose entire nature is thought determine the animal spirits to move the body, when causation of motion seems to require contact and extension?

FACT: Descartes' considered reply is that the **union** is a third **primitive notion**, alongside thought and extension, grasped through ordinary living rather than through pure intellect - and that trying to conceive it through the intellect alone is precisely what makes it seem impossible.

CAUTION: Whether this is a genuine philosophical answer or an admission that the question cannot be answered within the system is exactly what "critically discuss" invites you to rule on. The examiner-safe ruling: it preserves the **phenomenon** and abandons the **mechanism**.

5. Error and freedom - Meditation IV

FACT: The **will** is infinite in scope: I can affirm or deny anything whatever. The **intellect** is finite: I perceive clearly only a limited range. **Error** arises when the will affirms beyond what the intellect clearly perceives - so error is not caused by God, but by my misuse of a perfect faculty on an incomplete perception.

FACT: Freedom includes the power to **affirm, deny or withhold assent**, and it is not reducible to bodily mechanism.

FACT: Descartes ranks the grades of freedom in a way candidates often reverse: **mere indifference is the lowest grade**. When the intellect clearly perceives the truth, the will assents more freely, because it is moved by evident reason rather than by external compulsion or by ignorance.

CAUTION: Descartes is usually classified as a libertarian about the will, but the relation between alternative possibilities, clear intellectual determination and God's complete causal preordination is contested, and he does not fully reconcile them.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Cartesian dualism is derived from Descartes' own criterion of truth, and the interaction problem it generates is the engine that drives the rest of rationalism. **Named evidence.** Meditation VI argues from the clear and distinct conception of mind without body, and body without mind, to their real distinction; *Principles* I.51 concedes that only God strictly satisfies the definition of substance; the correspondence with Princess Elisabeth of 1643 raises the question how an unextended thing can move an extended one; the *Passions of the Soul* locates the interaction at the pineal gland. **Analysis.** Because thought and extension are defined so as to exclude one another completely, they share no property through which causal influence could be transmitted; the pineal gland supplies a place but not a mechanism, and calling the union a primitive notion concedes that no mechanism will be forthcoming. **Qualification.** The concession is not a refutation. Descartes preserves what experience insists on - that a pain is felt and not merely observed - while admitting that the union is not intelligible through the same pure intellect that established the distinction; the honest verdict is that he keeps the phenomenon and loses the explanation, which is precisely the vacancy Spinoza and Leibniz then compete to fill.

Exam link

- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks** - Section 3 is the hinge of the whole answer.

- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks** - Descartes' position in the three-way ranking is established here, both its strength (libertarian will) and its cost (no intelligible interaction).
- **2022 Q4(b), 15 marks** - the substance metaphysics behind the self/world asymmetry.
- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks** - stages 6 and 7 of the system.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
"Descartes says the mind is a ghost in the machine"	That is Gilbert Ryle's hostile coinage (<i>The Concept of Mind</i> , 1949), not Descartes' phrase; attribute it correctly and the same sentence earns a mark
Treating the pineal gland as Descartes' solution	It is a location; the philosophical answer is the primitive notion of union
Saying Descartes holds three substances "in the same sense"	He concedes in <i>Principles</i> I.51 that the use is analogical
Making dualism an assumption	It is a conclusion drawn from the criterion, via God's omnipotence
"Indifference is the highest freedom for Descartes"	He says the opposite: indifference is the lowest grade

Revision notes

- Principal attribute: thought / extension; particular ideas and motions are modes.
- Real distinction: clear separate conception -> God can separate -> really distinct.
- *Principles* I.51: only God needs nothing whatever; "substance" is analogical.
- Union: intimate, not pilot-in-ship; a third primitive notion; pineal gland as location.
- Elisabeth 1643: how can the unextended move the extended?
- Error: infinite will outruns finite intellect; indifference is the lowest grade of freedom.
- Never use Ryle's phrase as if it were Descartes'.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - DESCARTES V: DUALISM AND INTERACTION

CRITERION OF CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION (Session 3) + DIVINE GUARANTEE (Session 5)

|
v

REAL DISTINCTION: conceive mind without body, body without mind ->
God can separate them -> they ARE separate substances

|

+++> RES COGITANS: thought | unextended | indivisible | modes = ideas, volitions
+++> RES EXTENSA: extension | divisible | mechanistic | modes = shape, motion
+++> GOD: infinite substance; created substances need only God
|
(Principles I.51 - "substance" used ANALOGICALLY)

v

UNION IN A HUMAN BEING: pain is FELT, not observed -> pineal gland as the site

|

+++> ELISABETH 1643: how can the unextended move the extended?
+++> REPLY: the union is a THIRD PRIMITIVE NOTION
+++> RESIDUAL: phenomenon preserved, mechanism abandoned

v

MEDITATION IV: infinite will + finite intellect -> ERROR when will outruns intellect
FREEDOM: affirm, deny or withhold; indifference is the LOWEST grade

|

v

THIS VACANCY IS WHAT SPINOZA AND LEIBNIZ FILL

TRAP: "ghost in the machine" is Ryle 1949 | pineal = address, not explanation

ANSWER LINE: dualism is the criterion's own conclusion, and interaction is its bill

SESSION 7 - SPINOZA I: ONE SUBSTANCE, ATTRIBUTES, MODES, GOD OR NATURE, AND THE PANTHEISM QUESTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Spinoza takes Descartes' own definition of substance completely seriously, finds that only one thing can possibly satisfy it, calls that one thing God or Nature, and makes everything else - including you and your body - a way in which that one thing exists.

Technical definition: Spinozist monism is the doctrine, demonstrated in geometrical order (*more geometrico*) in *Ethics* I, that there exists exactly one absolutely infinite, self-caused (*causa sui*) substance possessing infinitely many attributes, of which the human intellect knows Thought and Extension; every finite thing is a mode (*modus*), an affection of that substance which exists in it and is conceived through it.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Spinoza is not attacking Descartes from outside but completing him from within: once "needing nothing else in order to exist" is applied without the analogical softening Descartes himself conceded, dependent created substances become a contradiction in terms, and the definition collapses of its own weight into a single, absolutely infinite substance which may equally be called God or Nature.

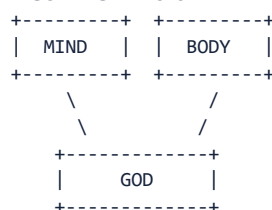
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **substance (substantia)** - in itself and conceived through itself
- **self-caused (causa sui)**
- **attribute (attributum)** - what the intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance
- **mode (modus)** - an affection of substance, in and conceived through another
- **God, or Nature (Deus sive Natura)** - *Ethics* IV, Preface
- **active nature and produced nature (natura naturans / natura naturata)**
- **immanent, not transitive, cause** - *Ethics* I, P18
- **"Whatever is, is in God"** - *Ethics* I, P15
- **acosmism** - Hegel's charge

How to use them: Run the four-step monism argument first. Only after the argument is on the page should you use the vocabulary or discuss the pantheism label, because the label is a conclusion, not a premise.

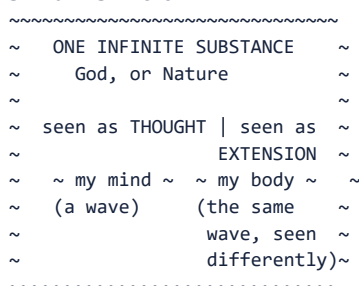
Plain-language visual - from three boxes to one ocean

DESCARTES' PICTURE



three things, one of which the other two depend on

SPINOZA'S PICTURE



one thing; the "things" are
WAYS IT IS, not things in it

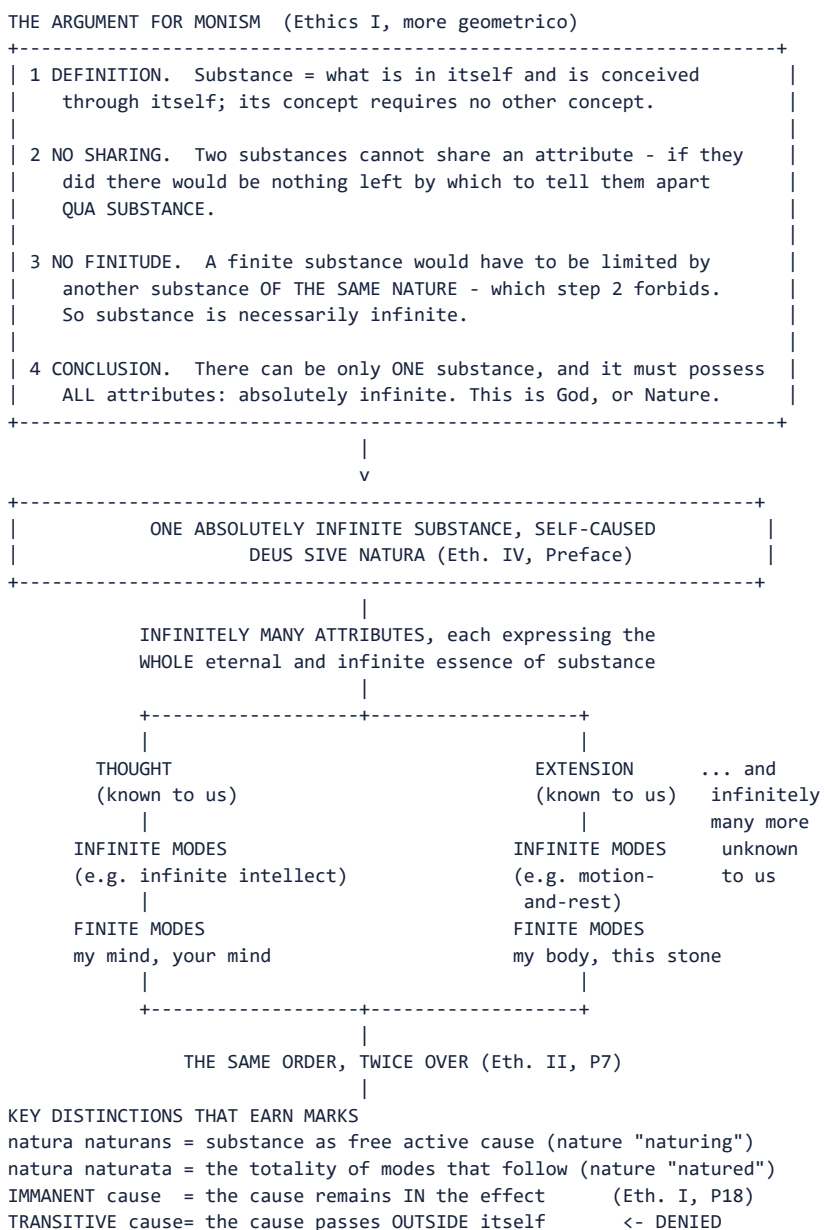
In simple words: think of the sea and a wave. A wave is not a *thing sitting in* the sea; it is the sea, doing something, here. That is what a mode is. And "Thought" and "Extension" are not two seas - they are two complete ways of describing the one sea, each of which describes all of it.

Remember first	Meaning
Substance	what is in itself and conceived through itself
Attribute	what the intellect perceives as constituting substance's essence

Remember first	Meaning
Mode	an affection of substance; in another and conceived through another
<i>Deus sive Natura</i>	God, or Nature - the same thing under two names
Immanent cause	the cause is <i>in</i> the effect, not outside it

One-line memory: for Descartes, thought and extension are two **substances**; for Spinoza, they are two **attributes of one**.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the four-step demonstration and the resulting architecture



ANALYSIS: Caption. The two vertical columns are the same reality counted twice, not two halves of it. Every error about parallelism in Session 8 begins with reading them as halves.

1. The demonstration, step by step

FACT: *Ethics* Part I proceeds by definitions, axioms and demonstrations. The chain that matters is:

1. **Substance** is what is in itself and is conceived through itself - its concept does not require the concept of anything else.
2. **No two substances can share an attribute.** If they did, there would be nothing by which they could be distinguished as *substances*.

3. **Substance cannot be finite.** To be finite is to be limited by something of the same nature; but by step 2 there is nothing of the same nature to do the limiting. Substance is therefore necessarily infinite.

4. □ There is exactly **one** substance, possessing **all** attributes - absolutely infinite. This is God.

FACT: Because it is in itself and conceived through itself, this substance is **self-caused (causa sui)**: its essence involves existence.

2. Attributes - what they are and what they are not

FACT: An **attribute** is what the intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance. Substance has **infinitely many** attributes; the human intellect knows exactly **two**, Thought and Extension.

ANALYSIS: Three precisions that examiners test:

- Each attribute expresses the **whole** essence of substance, not a portion of it. Thought is not half of God.
- Attributes are **not** substances. This is the exact point of difference from Descartes, and it is the answer to the standard comparison question.
- Attributes are not **parts**. Substance is not built out of them; they are complete ways in which one indivisible reality is intelligible.

3. Modes - what a finite thing is

FACT: A **mode** is an affection of substance, that which is *in another* and is *conceived through another*. My mind is a mode of God under the attribute of Thought; my body is a mode of God under the attribute of Extension.

FACT: *Ethics* I, P15: "**Whatever is, is in God, and nothing can be or be conceived without God.**" The word "in" is **ontological, not spatial**: it means "exists as a determination of, and is conceivable only through".

ANALYSIS: Modes come in two grades - **infinite modes** which follow immediately or mediately from the absolute nature of an attribute (motion-and-rest under Extension; the infinite intellect under Thought), and **finite modes**, which are determined by other finite modes in an endless causal series. Mentioning the two grades in a fifteen-mark answer signals real familiarity with *Ethics* I.

4. God, or Nature - and what this God is not

FACT: **God is not a person, and does not choose.** God acts from the **necessity of the divine nature**, not by will, design or providence.

FACT: *Ethics* I, P18: **God is the immanent, not the transitive, cause of all things.** A transitive cause produces something outside itself, as a carpenter produces a table; an immanent cause remains in its effect, as the sea remains in the wave.

FACT: **Active and produced nature.** *Natura naturans* is substance and its attributes considered as free active cause; *natura naturata* is everything that follows from the necessity of that nature - the totality of modes.

FACT: The phrase **God, or Nature (Deus sive Natura)** appears in the Preface to *Ethics* IV and again in IV, P4 Demonstration. It is safe to quote in Latin.

WRONG: **Spinoza is not an atheist.** He was excommunicated from the Amsterdam Jewish community in 1656 for heterodoxy; the substance of his position is an unorthodox theism or pantheism in which God is indispensable, not absent. Writing "Spinoza denies God" inverts his system.

5. Does the doctrine of substance lead to pantheism? - the 2022 question, answered

ANALYSIS: This question demands that you **take a side and defend it**, so the structure below is the structure of the answer.

Step	Position
What is established	FACT: Nothing exists outside God; all finite things are modes existing in and conceived through God; God is the immanent cause. In that precise sense the system does entail pantheism
What is not established	WRONG: It does not follow that any finite thing, or the visible aggregate of finite things, is numerically identical with the whole infinite divine essence. Substance exceeds the two attributes we know

Step	Position
The rival label	ANALYSIS: "Panentheism" - all things are <i>in</i> God while God exceeds them - captures the second point better; interpreters genuinely dispute which label is more accurate CAUTION:
The opposite objection	CAUTION: Hegel's acosmism charge: if only substance is real, the finite world dissolves into nothing - Spinoza is accused not of deifying the world but of <i>denying</i> it
The reply	Modes are real as expressions of substance, possessing dependent rather than independent reality; "not self-subsistent" is not the same as "not real"
The defended verdict	ANALYSIS: Spinoza is best described as a qualified pantheist : divine immanence is undeniable, but divine infinity blocks the reduction of God to the world we perceive

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Spinoza's monism is the strict application of a definition Descartes had already accepted and then softened, and it entails pantheism in a precise and defensible sense. **Named evidence.** *Ethics* I defines substance as what is in itself and conceived through itself, denies that two substances can share an attribute, and infers that substance must be infinite and unique; P15 states that whatever is, is in God; P18 makes God the immanent and not the transitive cause; the Preface to Part IV gives the formula God, or Nature (*Deus sive Natura*). **Analysis.** The argument works by exhaustion rather than by assertion: if distinctness among substances requires distinct attributes, and if finitude requires limitation by something of the same nature, then a plurality of substances is not merely unnecessary but incoherent - so minds and bodies must be redescribed as modes, and creation becomes immanent self-expression rather than external production. **Qualification.** The pantheistic conclusion should be stated carefully: everything is in God, but God is not exhausted by the totality of finite things or by the two attributes we know, which is why the panentheist label has defenders and why Hegel's opposite charge of acosmism - that the finite disappears rather than being deified - has to be answered by insisting that modes are real precisely as determinate expressions of substance.

Exam link

- **2022 Q2(c), 15 marks** - Section 1 to Section 3 for the concept of substance, Section 5 for the pantheism verdict; the directive "substantiate your view" forbids fence-sitting.
- **2024 Q2(b), 15 marks** - "Whatever is, is in God" is Section 3 plus Section 4, with the critical evaluation drawn from Section 5.
- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks** - Spinoza is the middle term: he enforces strictly what Descartes conceded loosely.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
"Spinoza is an atheist"	He is a pantheist; God is the one substance and is indispensable to the system
Confusing Spinoza's attributes with Descartes' substances	For Descartes thought and extension are essences of two substances; for Spinoza they are two attributes of one
Reading "in God" spatially	It means existing as a determination of, and conceivable only through
Saying God chose to create the world	God acts from the necessity of the divine nature; there is no choice and no design
Treating pantheism and acosmism as the same charge	Pantheism deifies the world; acosmism denies it. They are opposite objections
Forgetting infinite modes	Motion-and-rest and the infinite intellect are the bridge between attribute and finite thing

Revision notes

- Four steps: definition -> no shared attribute -> no finitude -> one absolutely infinite substance.

- *Causa sui*: essence involves existence.
- Attribute expresses the **whole** essence; infinitely many; two known.
- Modes: infinite (motion-and-rest; infinite intellect) and finite (this mind, this body).
- *Ethics* I, P15 "whatever is, is in God"; P18 immanent not transitive cause.
- *Natura naturans* / *natura naturata*; *Deus sive Natura* (Part IV, Preface).
- Verdict: qualified pantheist; answer acosmism by dependent-but-real modes.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SPINOZA I: ONE SUBSTANCE

DESCARTES CONCEDED: only God needs NOTHING WHATEVER (Principles I.51)
 | Spinoza refuses the softening
 v
 DEFINITION -> two substances cannot share an attribute -> a finite substance
 would need limiting by one of the same nature -> substance is infinite
 v
 EXACTLY ONE ABSOLUTELY INFINITE, SELF-CAUSED SUBSTANCE = DEUS SIVE NATURA
 |
 +--> INFINITELY MANY ATTRIBUTES, each expressing the WHOLE essence
 | we know two: THOUGHT and EXTENSION (NOT substances, NOT parts)
 +--> MODES: infinite (motion-and-rest, infinite intellect) and finite
 | "Whatever is, is in God" (I P15) - ONTOLOGICAL "in", not spatial
 +--> GOD is the IMMANENT, not transitive, cause (I P18)
 +--> *natura naturans* (active) / *natura naturata* (produced)
 v
 PANTHEISM? YES in the precise sense that nothing exists outside God
 NO in the crude sense that the visible world = the whole divine essence
 HEGEL'S OPPOSITE CHARGE: acosmism - the finite disappears
 REPLY: modes are dependently but genuinely real
 TRAP: not an atheist | attributes are not substances | God does not choose
 ANSWER LINE: Spinoza is the consistent Descartes, and the price of consistency
 is that individuals become ways in which one thing exists

SESSION 8 - SPINOZA II: NECESSITY, "ALL DETERMINATION IS NEGATION", AND PARALLELISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Because there is only one thing and it acts from its own nature alone, everything that happens had to happen exactly as it did; and because minds and bodies are the same reality described twice, they never need to push each other.

Technical definition: Spinozist necessitarianism holds that infinitely many things follow in infinitely many ways from the necessity of the divine nature (*Ethics* I, P16) and that nothing in nature is contingent (I, P29); psychophysical parallelism holds that the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things (II, P7), so that a mental and a physical event are one and the same mode expressed under two attributes rather than two things in causal commerce.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Spinoza does not solve the mind-body problem; he dissolves it - for the problem was manufactured by Descartes' assumption that mind and body are different *substances*, and once they are recognised as one and the same mode expressed under Thought and under Extension, there is simply nothing left for a causal bridge to span.

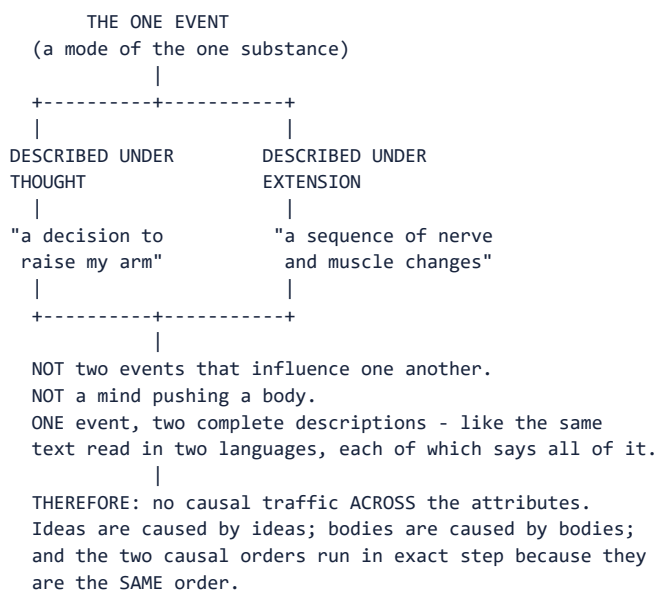
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **necessitarianism** - nothing could have been otherwise
- **Ethics I, P16** - infinitely many things follow from the necessity of the divine nature
- **Ethics I, P29** - nothing in nature is contingent
- **Ethics II, P7** - the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things
- **Ethics II, P13** - the human mind is the idea of the human body
- **parallelism / the double-aspect reading**
- **"determination is negation"** - Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles, 2 June 1674

- under the aspect of eternity (sub specie aeternitatis)

How to use them: Establish necessity first, then parallelism as its consequence in the two known attributes, and treat "determination is negation" as a corollary about finitude - always with the provenance caution.

Plain-language visual - one event, described twice



In simple words: Descartes asked how the mind could push the body. Spinoza's reply is that the question assumes two things where there is one. Ask instead how the English of a sentence pushes its Sanskrit translation - the question does not arise, because there is one meaning expressed twice.

Remember first	Meaning
Necessitarianism	everything follows necessarily; nothing is contingent
Contingency	a name for our ignorance of causes, not a feature of the world
Parallelism	one order, two expressions; no cross-attribute causation
The mind	the <i>idea of</i> the human body (II, P13)
Determination	to be <i>this</i> is not to be everything else - hence negation

One-line memory: Spinoza does not build a **bridge**; he denies there is a **gap**.

VISUAL: VISUAL - necessity, parallelism and negation as one system

A. NECESSITY

| I P16 From the necessity of the divine nature there must
| follow INFINITELY MANY THINGS in INFINITELY MANY WAYS.
| -> the inference is LOGICAL/ONTOLOGICAL, not a story in
| which God first exists and later makes a world
| I P29 Nothing in nature is contingent; all is determined by
| the necessity of the divine nature to exist and act
| in a certain way
| I P33 Things could have been produced in no other way and in
| no other order

B. PARALLELISM (the same necessity, seen in two attributes)

```
| II P7 The order and connection of IDEAS is the same as the  
| order and connection of THINGS  
| II P13 The human mind IS THE IDEA of the human body  
| -> so the mind's confusion tracks the body's being acted  
| upon, and the mind's power tracks the body's power  
  
|  
| IDEA_1 -> IDEA_2 -> IDEA_3 (causation WITHIN Thought)  
| || || || same modes, same order  
| BODY_1 -> BODY_2 -> BODY_3 (causation WITHIN Extension)  
  
| NO ARROWS BETWEEN THE ROWS. That is the whole doctrine.
```

C. "DETERMINATION IS NEGATION"

PROVENANCE FIRST: Spinoza writes "determination is negation" (determinatio negatio est) in LETTER 50 to Jarig Jelles, 2 June 1674. The universalised Latin slogan OMNIS DETERMINATIO EST NEGATIO is HEGEL'S rendering, which is how it entered the textbook tradition. It is NOT a sentence of the Ethics.

MEANING: to determine is to bound; to say a thing is THIS is to say it is NOT everything else. Finitude therefore contains negation.

FOR GOD: absolutely infinite, bounded by nothing external, therefore PURE AFFIRMATION - no negation whatever

FOR MODES: each finite mode is limited by other modes of the same nature - determinate, and so partly negative

FOR KNOWING: adequate knowledge sees the finite THROUGH the affirmative whole, sub specie aeternitatis

HEGEL'S CRITICISM: if determination is negation, the finite becomes mere negation -> ACOSMISM

SPINOZIST REPLY: what is negated is INDEPENDENT SELF-SUBSISTENCE not reality; modes positively express divine power in determinate ways

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** Box C is the 2025 fifteen-mark question in full. The provenance line at its top is itself worth a mark, because most scripts attribute the slogan to the *Ethics*.

1. Necessity - what "what is, cannot be other than what it is" means

FACT: The 2019 question quotes this thesis. Its derivation is:

1. God, or Nature, is the one self-caused substance, and acts from the necessity of the divine nature alone.
2. *Ethics* I, P16: infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from that necessity - modes follow from *what substance is*, as conclusions follow from premises.
3. □ Modes are not products of a discretionary decree; there is no deliberation, no selection among alternatives, no purpose.
4. *Ethics* I, P29: nothing in nature is contingent. Apparent contingency records **our ignorance of causes**, not an objective gap in the order.
5. Finite modes are determined by other finite modes in an endless series *within* the one necessary order.

ANALYSIS: Three distinctions to keep clean: (i) God is free not because God could have chosen otherwise but because God is determined by nothing external (*Ethics* I, Definition 7); (ii) necessity is **logical-ontological**, not fatalistic compulsion by an external agent; (iii) denying contingency is not denying causality - it is denying that the causal order could have run differently.

2. Three criticisms of P16, and Spinoza's replies

Objection	Spinoza's reply	Residual force CAUTION:
Necessity removes divine personality, will and choice, leaving nothing worth worshipping	Will and intellect are not faculties standing outside nature; anthropomorphic choice would <i>limit</i> God rather than exalt him	Religion loses providential personality and petitionary prayer entirely
If all follows from God, then evil and bondage follow necessarily from God	Good and evil express relations to human flourishing and power, not properties of infinite substance	Suffering still belongs, unredeemed, to the necessary order
P16 asserts more than the definitions and axioms actually prove	An infinite cause must express itself infinitely; anything less would be an arbitrary limitation	The precise derivation of <i>determinate finite</i> modes from an infinite nature remains the hardest step in <i>Ethics</i> I

3. Parallelism - the mind-body doctrine

FACT: Mind and body are **not two substances interacting** but **one and the same thing expressed under two attributes**.

- *Ethics* II, P7: "The order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things."
- *Ethics* II, P13: the human mind **is the idea of** the human body. This is why the mind's adequacy tracks the body's power of acting.
- There is **no causal interaction across attributes**. My decision to raise my arm and the arm's movement are the same event under Thought and under Extension.

FACT: **The dissolution**. The mind-body problem was generated by Descartes' assumption that mind and body are different substances. Remove the assumption and the problem does not get solved - it stops arising.

ANALYSIS: **The cost, stated honestly**. If no idea can cause a bodily motion, then "mental causation" in the ordinary sense disappears; and since Thought and Extension are causally closed, some critics say Spinoza secures the correspondence at the price of making mind explanatorily idle. Spinoza's answer is that the mind is not idle *within* Thought - an adequate idea genuinely causes further adequate ideas - but the ordinary intuition that a decision moves a limb is indeed abandoned.

4. "All determination is negation" - provenance, meaning, consequences

FACT: **Provenance caution - this earns a mark**. The exact Latin formula *omnis determinatio est negatio* is **not** in the *Ethics*. Spinoza writes *determinatio negatio est* in **Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles, 2 June 1674**. The universalised slogan is **Hegel's** rendering, and it entered the textbook tradition through him. The safe sentence to write is: "*Spinoza's dictum, in Letter 50, that determination is negation - universalised by Hegel as omnis determinatio est negatio.*"

FACT: **The meaning**. To determine something is to make it definite, finite, bounded. To say a thing is *this* is to say it is *not* everything else. Finitude therefore contains negation.

FACT: **Three consequences, which is exactly what a "comment" answer needs:**

- **For God**. Being absolutely infinite and limited by nothing external, God involves **no** negation: pure affirmation, undetermined by anything outside.
- **For finite modes**. Each is bounded by other modes of the same nature - a body occupies this region and excludes others; an idea expresses a bounded causal perspective. Their determinacy marks dependence.
- **For knowledge and freedom**. Inadequate knowledge treats a finite thing in isolation; adequate knowledge understands it through the affirmative whole, seeing it **under the aspect of eternity (sub specie aeternitatis)**.

CAUTION: **Hegel's criticism and the reply**. If determination is negation, the finite threatens to become mere negation, and the world vanishes into substance - the **acosmism** charge. The Spinozist reply is that what is negated is *independent self-subsistence*, not reality as such: modes positively express divine power in determinate ways.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Spinoza's necessitarianism and his parallelism are one doctrine seen from two sides: because there is a single necessary order, that order must appear complete under each attribute, and no causal traffic between attributes is either possible or required. **Named evidence.** *Ethics* I, P16 derives infinitely many things in infinitely many ways from the necessity of the divine nature; I, P29 denies contingency in nature; II, P7 states that the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things; II, P13 identifies the human mind as the idea of the human body. **Analysis.** If modes follow from what substance is, then each attribute expresses the same complete sequence; a mental item and a bodily item are therefore not two relata but one mode twice expressed, and the Cartesian demand for a mechanism of influence is revealed as a demand generated by a false premise rather than a genuine explanatory debt. **Qualification.** The dissolution is bought with two concessions the answer should make: mental causation in the ordinary sense is abandoned, since no idea moves a limb; and apparent contingency is redescribed as ignorance, so nothing in nature could have been otherwise - a result many find harder to accept than the problem it removes.

Exam link

- **2019 Q2(c), 15 marks** - "what is, cannot be other than what it is" is Section 1 exactly; the directive "explain" demands the derivation, not a restatement.
- **2020 Q4(b), 15 marks** - the quoted line *is* P16; Section 1 explains it and Section 2 supplies the three criticisms the question asks for.
- **2025 Q2(b), 15 marks** - Section 4 is the answer, and the provenance line should open it.
- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks** - Section 3 supplies Spinoza's entry in the three-way ranking.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
Attributing "all determination is negation" to the <i>Ethics</i>	It is Letter 50, universalised by Hegel
"Necessity means fate pushes us"	Necessity is logical-ontological; there is no external agent doing the pushing
Saying parallelism means mind and body "run alongside like two trains"	They are one thing twice expressed; the two-train picture reinstates two things
Confusing acosmism with pantheism	Opposite charges: one says the world is deified, the other that it disappears
Treating P16 as a creation story	The inference is ontological, not temporal

Revision notes

- I, P16: infinitely many things in infinitely many ways from divine necessity.
- I, P29: nothing contingent; contingency = ignorance of causes.
- I, P33: things could have been produced in no other way or order.
- II, P7: order and connection of ideas = order and connection of things.
- II, P13: the mind is the idea of the body.
- No cross-attribute causation; the problem is dissolved, not solved.
- "Determination is negation": Letter 50, 2 June 1674; Hegel universalised it.
- For God, pure affirmation; for modes, limitation; for knowledge, *sub specie aeternitatis*.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SPINOZA II: NECESSITY AND PARALLELISM

ONE SUBSTANCE ACTING FROM ITS OWN NATURE ALONE
|
+--> I P16: infinitely many things in infinitely many ways
+--> I P29: nothing contingent; contingency = ignorance of causes
+--> I P33: no other way, no other order
v
THE SAME NECESSARY ORDER MUST APPEAR COMPLETE UNDER EACH ATTRIBUTE
|
v
II P7: order and connection of IDEAS = order and connection of THINGS
II P13: the human mind IS THE IDEA of the human body
| idea -> idea -> idea (causation stays inside Thought)
| body -> body -> body (causation stays inside Extension)
| NO ARROWS ACROSS -> the mind-body problem does not arise
v
COST: ordinary mental causation is abandoned; nothing could be otherwise
|
v
"DETERMINATION IS NEGATION" - Letter 50, 2 June 1674 (Hegel universalised it)
+--> GOD: infinite, bounded by nothing -> PURE AFFIRMATION
+--> MODES: bounded by other modes -> determinate, dependent
+--> KNOWING: see the finite through the whole, sub specie aeternitatis
+--> HEGEL: acosmism | REPLY: independence is negated, reality is not
TRAP: never cite the slogan to the Ethics | parallelism is not two trains
ANSWER LINE: Spinoza dissolves the problem by denying the premise that made it

SESSION 9 - SPINOZA III: THE THREE KINDS OF KNOWLEDGE, STRIVING, BONDAGE AND FREEDOM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Spinoza sorts knowing into three levels, argues that each level is a different way of *being* rather than merely a different degree of confidence, and concludes that becoming free just is climbing from the lowest level to the highest.

Technical definition: *Ethics* II, P40, Scholium 2 distinguishes imagination or opinion (*imaginatio, opinio*), reason (*ratio*) grounded in common notions (*notiones communes*), and intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*); *Ethics* III, P6-P7 identify each thing's striving to persevere in being (*conatus*) as its actual essence; and *Ethics* I, Definition 7 defines as free that which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature and is determined to action by itself alone.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Spinoza does not abolish freedom, he relocates it - from the will's indifference to the intellect's adequacy - so that knowledge is not a means to liberation but is liberation itself: to move from imagination through reason to intuitive knowledge is precisely to move from being determined by causes outside one's nature to being determined by one's own.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- imagination or opinion (*imaginatio, opinio*); random experience (*experientia vaga*); from signs (*ex signis*)
- reason (*ratio*) grounded in common notions (*notiones communes*)
- intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*)
- adequate and inadequate ideas
- striving (*conatus*) - *Ethics* III, P6-P7
- passive affects and active affects; bondage (*servitus*)
- the intellectual love of God (*amor Dei intellectualis*); blessedness (*beatitudo*)
- the free thing - *Ethics* I, Definition 7

How to use them: Give the three kinds with Spinoza's own example, then the six-step argument that converts knowledge into freedom, then Definition 7 as the anchor the 2023 question quotes.

Plain-language visual - three ways of getting the same right answer

THE PROBLEM: given 1, 2 and 3, find the fourth proportional.
 (1 : 2 :: 3 : ?) The answer is 6 in every case.
 The DIFFERENCE is in what the knower is doing.

THE MERCHANT	multiplies the 2nd by the 3rd, divides by
first kind	the 1st - because he was taught the rule,
imaginatio	or has seen it work. He knows THAT, from
	signs and vague experience. No grasp of WHY.
THE MATHEMATICIAN	demonstrates it from the common property of
second kind	proportionals (Euclid VII.19). Adequate -
ratio	but DISCURSIVE, reached through a chain.
ANYONE, WITH	with 1, 2, 3 you SEE AT A GLANCE that the
THESE NUMBERS	fourth is 6. The ratio is grasped in the
third kind	essences themselves, IN ONE ACT.
scientia intuitiva	

MEMORY: Mnemonic - "Merchant · Mathematician · Seer" (M-M-S) = imagination · reason · intuitive knowledge.

In simple words: all three get 6. The merchant is being carried by a rule from outside; the mathematician is walking the road himself; the seer is standing where the road ends. Spinoza's radical claim is that these are three different *conditions of the person*, not three grades of confidence - and that is why the epistemology is already an ethics.

Remember first	Meaning
Adequate idea	understood through its cause, from within the mind's own power
Inadequate idea	mutilated and confused; the trace of external bodies in mine
Common notion	a property equally in the part and in the whole
<i>Conatus</i>	the striving to persevere in being; a thing's actual essence
Bondage	being determined by causes external to one's nature

One-line memory: knowledge is not a **means** to freedom for Spinoza; it **is** freedom.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the three kinds, and the six-step route from bondage to freedom

THE THREE KINDS (Ethics II, P40, Scholium 2)

KIND	NAME	SOURCE	ADEQUACY
FIRST	imaginatio / opinio	(a) experientia vaga - random experience through the senses (b) ex signis - hearsay, words, memory -> II P41: this is THE ONLY CAUSE OF FALSITY	INADEQUATE mutilated and confused
SECOND	ratio	COMMON NOTIONS - what is equally in the part and in the whole; adequate ideas of properties	ADEQUATE necessarily true (II P41)
THIRD	scientia intuitiva	from an adequate idea of the formal essence of certain ATTRIBUTES OF GOD to adequate knowledge of the ESSENCE of things	ADEQUATE, in ONE ACT the highest (V P25)

THE ARGUMENT THAT MAKES KNOWLEDGE INTO FREEDOM

- Everything follows necessarily from the nature of God or Substance.
- An idea is ADEQUATE when it is understood through its cause - that is, through its place in that necessary order.
- BONDAGE (servitus) = being determined by causes EXTERNAL to my nature; and that is exactly the condition of one whose ideas are inadequate, since inadequate ideas are the traces of other bodies in mine.
- FREEDOM (Eth. I, Def. 7) = being determined by MY OWN nature alone.
- Adequate ideas ARE the mind acting from its own nature, for in having them the mind is the ADEQUATE CAUSE of what follows from them.
- THEREFORE moving from the first kind to the second and third IS moving from bondage to freedom.
- At the limit, the third kind sees things SUB SPECIE AETERNITATIS and generates the INTELLECTUAL LOVE OF GOD (amor Dei intellectualis, Eth. V, P32 Cor.) - the mind's highest good and blessedness.

THE SELF-CERTIFICATION PROBLEM (concede this; it is the strongest objection)

OBJECTION: if intuitive knowledge is not demonstrative, what distinguishes it from the first kind's confident guessing?

REPLY: Eth. II, P43 - he who has a true idea knows at the same time that he has a true idea; truth is the standard of itself and of the false (verum index sui et falsi).

COUNTER: self-certification is exactly what confident imagination FEELS like. This remains the live objection to Spinoza's epistemology.

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** The seven-step argument in the middle box is what turns a fact about knowledge into a doctrine about freedom. It should be visible in any answer on Spinozist freedom, in compressed form.

1. The three kinds - precisions that earn marks

FACT: The **first kind** has two sub-sources which examiners like to separate: **random experience (experientia vaga)**, in which the senses present things mutilated and confused, and **from signs (ex signis)**, in which words, hearsay and memory produce ideas. *Ethics* II, P41 says this kind is **the only cause of falsity**.

FACT: The **second kind** is grounded in **common notions** - properties **equally present in the part and in the whole**, which for that reason cannot be conceived inadequately. This is what makes reason necessarily true.

FACT: The **third kind** proceeds from an adequate idea of the formal essence of certain **attributes of God** to adequate knowledge of the **essence of things**, and grasps this in a single act. *Ethics* V, P25 makes it the highest endeavour of the mind.

ANALYSIS: The three kinds are **three ontological positions of the knower**: the first is a mind pushed about by external bodies; the second a mind reasoning along the true causal order; the third a mind seeing things as they follow from God's essence.

2. Striving (conatus) - and why it belongs here

FACT: *Ethics* III, P6: each thing, as far as it lies in itself, strives to persevere in its being. P7: this striving is nothing but the **actual essence** of the thing itself. In a human being, conscious striving appears as **desire**.

FACT: **Passive affects (passions)** arise when the person is only a *partial* cause of what happens, under external determination. **Active affects** arise from adequate ideas and register an increase in the power of acting.

ANALYSIS: Keep the scope tight. Spinoza's full taxonomy of the affects is optional enrichment; *conatus*, the passive/active distinction and the increase of power are retained here **only** because they are what make "freedom = adequate self-determination" a substantive doctrine rather than a slogan.

3. Freedom and determinism - the 2023 question, answered

FACT: **The anchor.** *Ethics* I, Definition 7: "That thing is said to be free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature, and is determined to action by itself alone." Note that the definition contrasts freedom with **compulsion**, not with **causation**.

FACT: **Free will is an illusion.** Human beings believe themselves free because they are **conscious of their desires** but **ignorant of the causes** that determine them. Spinoza's image: a thrown stone, if it were conscious, would believe it was flying because it chose to.

FACT: **Only God is absolutely free**, because only God exists and acts from the divine nature alone, without external determination. Human freedom is therefore **relative** and is achieved, not possessed.

FACT: **Bondage and action.** When we are governed by external causes and inadequate ideas we suffer *passions* and are in **bondage (servitus)**; when we understand adequately, we **act**, and that is freedom.

FACT: **The culmination** is not escape from necessity but the **intellectual love of God (amor Dei intellectualis)** and blessedness (*beatitudo*) - *Ethics* V, P32 Corollary. Spinoza's famous closing note is that blessedness is not the reward of virtue but virtue itself.

ANALYSIS: **The honest verdict.** Spinoza offers freedom as adequate self-activity *within* necessity, not free will as an uncaused power to choose otherwise. Whether that counts as freedom depends entirely on whether "could have done otherwise" is essential to the concept - Spinoza denies it, and denies it consistently.

4. Is this merely determinism renamed?

The charge	The defence	What remains CAUTION:
If everything is necessary, calling some of it "free" is a verbal manoeuvre	The distinction between being an adequate cause and a partial cause is real and has consequences: understanding an affect changes one's relation to it and increases the power of acting	Every achievement of understanding is itself necessitated, so nobody could have failed to be free who is, or become free who is not
Moral responsibility disappears	Responsibility founded on an uncaused will was confused to begin with; ethics becomes the cultivation of rational power rather than the allocation of blame	Praise and blame in the ordinary retributive sense are indeed abandoned
Alternative possibilities never return	Correct, and Spinoza says so	The disagreement is now openly about the <i>definition</i> of freedom, which is the honest place to leave it

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Spinoza reconciles freedom with determinism by making freedom a higher form of determination rather than an exception to causation. **Named evidence.** *Ethics* I, Definition 7 defines as free what exists solely from the necessity of its own nature and is determined to action by itself alone; the conscious-stone image shows that the sense of free will rests on awareness of desire together with ignorance of causes; *Ethics* II, P40 Scholium 2 grades knowing into imagination, reason and intuitive knowledge; III, P6-P7 make striving (*conatus*) the actual essence of each thing; V, P32 Corollary reaches the intellectual love of God. **Analysis.** Because Definition 7 opposes freedom to external compulsion rather than to causation, a being becomes freer exactly as its actions follow from its own understood nature; and since adequate ideas are the mind acting as the adequate cause of what follows from them, the ascent through the three kinds of knowledge *is* the ascent from bondage to freedom rather than a preparation for it. **Qualification.** Two costs must be conceded rather than concealed: alternative possibilities never return, so this is not free will in the libertarian sense; and because every act of understanding is itself necessitated, even the achievement of freedom could not have been otherwise - which is why critics ask whether the doctrine is emancipation or determinism under a more attractive name.

Exam link

- **2023 Q1(c), 10 marks** - the quotation is Definition 7; Section 3 is the whole answer, with Section 4 supplying the assessment.
- **2019 Q2(c) and 2020 Q4(b)** - this session supplies the ethical pay-off that turns necessity into a doctrine rather than a bare metaphysics.
- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks** - Spinoza is ranked using Section 3: deepest self-mastery, no free will.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
Treating Spinoza's freedom as libertarian free will	He explicitly denies contra-causal freedom
"The three kinds are three degrees of certainty"	They are three ontological positions of the knower
Omitting the fourth-proportional example	It is Spinoza's own and takes three lines; it converts a definition into a demonstration
Making <i>conatus</i> a separate topic	It is retained only to explain bondage, action and freedom
Saying blessedness is the reward of virtue	<i>Ethics</i> V: blessedness <i>is</i> virtue itself, not its wage

Revision notes

- First kind: *imaginatio/opinio* from *experientia vaga* and *ex signis*; the only cause of falsity (II, P41).
- Second kind: *ratio*, from common notions - equally in part and whole; necessarily true.
- Third kind: *scientia intuitiva*, from attributes of God to essences of things, in one act (V, P25).
- Example: merchant, mathematician, seer - the fourth proportional, answer 6.
- *Conatus* (III, P6-P7) = actual essence; passive affects = partial cause; active affects = adequate cause.
- Definition 7: free = exists from the necessity of its own nature, determined by itself alone.
- Stone analogy: conscious of desire, ignorant of causes.
- Culmination: *amor Dei intellectualis*; blessedness is virtue itself.
- Self-certification (II, P43, *verum index sui*) is the live weakness - concede it.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SPINOZA III: KNOWLEDGE AND FREEDOM

THREE KINDS OF KNOWLEDGE (Eth. II P40 Sch.2)

- 1 imaginatio: experientia vaga + ex signis -> INADEQUATE -> only cause of falsity
 - 2 ratio: common notions (equally in part and whole) -> ADEQUATE
 - 3 scientia intuitiva: from God's attributes to essences, IN ONE ACT -> HIGHEST
- EXAMPLE: merchant | mathematician | seer -> the fourth proportional is 6

|
v

ADEQUATE IDEA = understood through its cause = the mind as ADEQUATE CAUSE

INADEQUATE IDEA = the trace of external bodies in mine = PARTIAL cause

|
v

CONATUS (III P6-P7): striving to persevere = the thing's ACTUAL ESSENCE

passive affects -> bondage (servitus) | active affects -> power of acting

|
v

DEFINITION 7: free = exists from the necessity of its OWN nature and is determined to action BY ITSELF ALONE (opposed to COMPULSION, not to CAUSE)

|

---> free will is an illusion: conscious of desire, ignorant of causes
| (the conscious stone)

---> only God is ABSOLUTELY free; human freedom is achieved, relative

---> culmination: sub specie aeternitatis -> amor Dei intellectualis;
| blessedness is not virtue's reward but virtue itself

|
v

CONCEDE: no alternative possibilities; even becoming free is necessitated

LIVE WEAKNESS: verum index sui - self-certification also describes confident
imagination (II P43)

ANSWER LINE: freedom is relocated from the will's indifference to the
intellect's adequacy

SESSION 10 - LEIBNIZ I: MONADS, PERCEPTION AND APPETITION, THE HIERARCHY, AND THE IDENTITY OF INDISCERNIBLES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Leibniz agrees with Spinoza that Descartes' extended substance cannot be ultimate, but refuses to let individuals disappear into one thing - so he makes the world out of infinitely many partless, soul-like units, each of which mirrors the whole universe from its own point of view.

Technical definition: A monad (*monas*) is a simple, unextended, indestructible substance without parts, endowed with perception (*perceptio*) - an internal representation of the manifold in the unity - and appetite (*appetitus*) - the internal principle by which it passes from one perception to the next; monads are windowless, differentiated by the identity of indiscernibles, arranged in a hierarchy, and extended bodies are well-founded phenomena (*phaenomena bene fundata*) grounded in ordered aggregates of them.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Leibniz's monads are not a mystical addition to metaphysics but the conclusion of a short and severe argument: whatever is extended is divisible, whatever is divisible is composite, and a composite presupposes the simples of which it is composed - so if there are aggregates at all, there must be partless units, and since these can have no shape or size, their only available inner states are perception and striving.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- monad (*monas*) - simple, partless, unextended, indestructible
- "monads have no windows" (*les monades n'ont point de fenêtres*, *Monadology* Section 7)
- perception (*perceptio*) and appetite (*appetitus*)
- minute perceptions (*petites perceptions*) and apperception
- bare monads, animal souls and rational spirits
- dominant monad and organic aggregate
- identity of indiscernibles
- well-founded phenomena (*phaenomena bene fundata*)

How to use them: Give the argument to simples first; then perception and appetite as the only inner states available; then the hierarchy; then indiscernibles as the guarantee of individuality.

Plain-language visual - why the world cannot be made of stuff

```

TAKE ANY EXTENDED THING
|
it has left and right halves -> IT IS DIVISIBLE
|
a divisible thing is a COMPOSITE - a collection
|
a collection is made of members; the members, if extended, are
themselves collections; and so on WITHOUT END
|
BUT: an aggregate must be an aggregate OF something.
A heap of heaps of heaps, with no grains anywhere, is no heap.
|
v
THEREFORE there must be SIMPLER: partless units
|
A partless unit has no shape, no size, no position
(all of those require parts)
|
SO WHAT INNER STATES CAN IT HAVE AT ALL?
|
Only states of REPRESENTING (perception) and of
PASSING FROM ONE REPRESENTATION TO THE NEXT (appetition)
|
v
THIS IS A MONAD

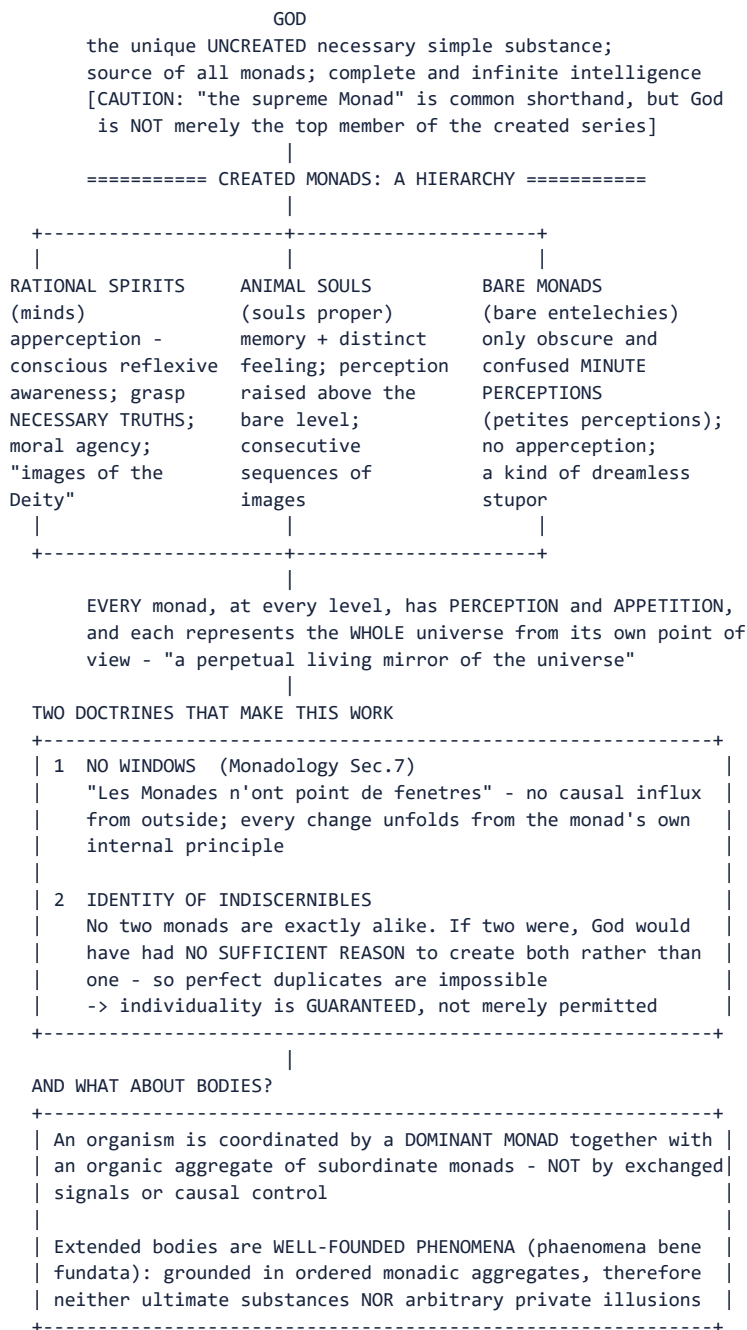
```

In simple words: Leibniz's monads look strange until you see that they are forced. Once you agree that a pile must be a pile of something, and that a partless something can have no geometry, the only properties left for it are inner ones - and "inner state" plus "change of inner state" just is perception plus appetite.

Remember first	Meaning
Simple	having no parts; therefore indivisible and naturally indestructible
Perception	the representation of many in one; not necessarily conscious
Appetition	the internal tendency carrying one perception into the next
Windowless	nothing enters or leaves; all change is internal
Well-founded phenomenon	not an illusion, but not an ultimate substance either

One-line memory: monads have no **windows** - and therefore no **imports** and no **exports**.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the monadic hierarchy and the two doctrines that individuate it



ANALYSIS: **Caption.** The bottom box is the one candidates omit, and it is the one that stops "monads" sounding like idealism. A well-founded phenomenon is *objective* - it has a real ground - without being *ultimate*.

1. Why extension cannot be the essence of substance

FACT: Leibniz's argument against Descartes is short:

1. Extension is essentially **divisible**.
2. Whatever is divisible is a **composite**, an aggregate of parts.
3. An aggregate derives its reality from the reality of its constituents.
4. ☐ Extended things cannot be ultimate; there must be **simple** substances, and these cannot themselves be extended.

ANALYSIS: Note that this is an attack on Spinoza too. If extension is not a possible essence of substance, then Extension cannot be an attribute expressing the essence of the one substance in the way Spinoza needs.

2. Perception and appetite - the only inner states available

FACT: **Perception** in Leibniz's technical sense is "the representation of the manifold in the simple" - the monad's internal representation of the entire universe from its own point of view. It does **not** imply consciousness.

FACT: **Appetition** is the internal principle producing change: the tendency by which a monad passes from one perception to the next. It is what makes the monad an active, self-unfolding thing rather than a static point.

FACT: **Minute perceptions (petites perceptions)** are perceptions below the threshold of reflective awareness. Leibniz's own illustration is the roar of the sea: we hear the whole roar, so we must in some way perceive each wave, though we notice none individually.

FACT: **Apperception** is conscious, reflexive awareness of perception. ANALYSIS: Crucially, apperception must **not** be attributed to every monad - this is the single most common error in monadology answers. Every monad perceives; only some apperceive.

3. The hierarchy

Level	Perception	Distinctive capacity
Bare monads (bare entelechies)	obscure, confused, minute perceptions only	no memory, no apperception; a dreamless stupor
Animal souls	perception raised to distinct feeling	memory , which produces a "consecutiveness" resembling reason
Rational spirits (minds)	distinct perception plus reflexive awareness	apperception ; knowledge of necessary and eternal truths ; science and morality; capable of entering into a moral community with God

ANALYSIS: **God's place.** God is the unique **uncreated** necessary simple substance and the source of all created monads. Calling God "the supreme Monad" is common shorthand, but it is a shorthand - God is not merely the highest member of the created series.

4. "Monads have no windows"

FACT: *Monadology* Section 7, as it is usually rendered: **"Monads have no windows through which anything could come in or go out."** No causal influx enters a monad; nothing is transferred between them. All change arises internally, from the monad's own appetition, unfolding what its nature already contains.

ANALYSIS: Translation discipline: the French is *les Monades n'ont point de fenêtres*. "No windows" is a standard rendering, not a literal English original, so write "as it is usually rendered".

ANALYSIS: The immediate consequence is that the mind-body problem cannot be solved by *any* form of interaction - which is what Session 11's pre-established harmony exists to handle.

5. The identity of indiscernibles

FACT: **No two monads are exactly alike.** If two substances were qualitatively identical, God would have had no sufficient reason to create both rather than one; and since nothing happens without a sufficient reason, perfect duplicates are impossible.

FACT: Two things follow that matter for the exam:

- Individuality is **guaranteed**, not merely permitted. This is precisely what Spinoza's system cannot deliver, and it is Leibniz's principal motive.
- Each monad differs by the *degree of distinctness* of its perceptions and by its unique point of view on the same universe - which is why there is one world, represented infinitely many times.

6. Bodies as well-founded phenomena

FACT: An organism is coordinated by a **dominant monad** together with an organic aggregate of subordinate monads. This is coordination, not causal control through exchanged signals.

FACT: Extended bodies are **well-founded phenomena (phaenomena bene fundata)**: they are grounded in ordered monadic aggregates. ANALYSIS: They are therefore *not* ultimate substances, but neither are they arbitrary private illusions - the phrase "well-founded" is doing real work and must not be dropped.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Leibniz's monadology is generated by a refusal of extended substance rather than by any independent enthusiasm for souls, and its point is to secure individuality that Spinoza's monism cannot. **Named evidence.** *Monadology* Section 1-3 argue that composites presuppose simples and that simples, being partless, can have neither shape nor divisibility; Section 7 states that monads have no windows through which anything could enter or leave; Section 14-15 introduce perception and appetite; Section 19-29 grade bare monads, animal souls with memory and rational spirits capable of necessary truths; the identity of indiscernibles is defended in the correspondence with Clarke on the ground that God would have no sufficient reason to create indistinguishable duplicates. **Analysis.** Each doctrine is forced by the preceding one: partlessness removes every geometrical property, so only representational states remain; windowlessness follows because nothing partless can receive an influx; and since qualitative duplication would leave God's choice unmotivated, the units must be individuated intrinsically rather than by position. **Qualification.** The gain is real but expensive. Individuality is secured, yet ordinary bodies are demoted to well-founded phenomena and the correspondence between a mind's perceptions and its body's states can no longer be explained by any interaction - which is exactly the debt pre-established harmony is introduced to discharge, and which critics regard as buying agreement in advance rather than explaining it.

Exam link

- **2020 Q1(b), 10 marks** - "Leibniz's conception of monads" is Section 1 to Section 5, and the bearing on determinism and freedom is completed in Session 11.
- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks** - Leibniz is the third term: simplicity added to independence produces infinitely many substances.
- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks** - windowlessness is why Leibniz cannot answer the mind-body question by interaction, and therefore why he needs harmony.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
"Monads interact with one another"	They are windowless; there is no causal influx at all
"Every monad is conscious"	Every monad perceives ; only some apperceive
Treating monads as physical atoms	Atoms are extended and divisible in principle; monads are partless and non-spatial
Saying bodies are illusions	They are <i>well-founded</i> phenomena, grounded in ordered aggregates
Calling God "the supreme Monad" without qualification	God is uncreated and necessary, not the top of the created series
Ignoring minute perceptions	Without them, the roar of the sea and unconscious mental life cannot be explained

Revision notes

- Argument to simples: extension -> divisible -> composite -> aggregates need simples.
- Monad: simple, unextended, indestructible; states = perception + appetite.
- *Petites perceptions* below awareness; apperception only in rational spirits.
- Hierarchy: bare entelechies -> animal souls (memory) -> rational spirits (necessary truths).
- *Monadology* Section 7: "monads have no windows", as usually rendered.
- Identity of indiscernibles: no sufficient reason for duplicates -> individuality guaranteed.
- Dominant monad + organic aggregate; bodies = well-founded phenomena.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - LEIBNIZ I: MONADS

EXTENSION IS DIVISIBLE -> COMPOSITE -> AGGREGATES PRESUPPOSE SIMPLES
|
v
SIMPLE SUBSTANCE = MONAD: partless, unextended, indestructible
| a partless thing can have no shape, size or position
v
ONLY INNER STATES REMAIN: PERCEPTION (many represented in one) and
APPETITION (the internal passage from perception to perception)
|
+--> petites perceptions below awareness (the roar of the sea)
+--> APPERCEPTION only in rational spirits - NOT in every monad
v
HIERARCHY: bare entelechies -> animal souls (memory) -> rational spirits
(apperception, necessary truths, moral community with God)
GOD: the unique UNCREATED necessary simple substance, not the top of the series
|
v
NO WINDOWS (Monadology Sec.7): no influx in or out; all change is internal
IDENTITY OF INDISCERNIBLES: duplicates would leave God without a sufficient
reason -> individuality is GUARANTEED
|
v
DOMINANT MONAD + ORGANIC AGGREGATE -> BODIES ARE WELL-FOUNDED PHENOMENA
(grounded, therefore not illusions; not ultimate, therefore not substances)
|
v
CONSEQUENCE: interaction is impossible in principle -> harmony must do the work
TRAP: monads are not atoms | perception is not consciousness
ANSWER LINE: monads are what is left when divisibility and influx are both denied

SESSION 11 - LEIBNIZ II: SUFFICIENT REASON, TWO KINDS OF TRUTH, POSSIBLE WORLDS, PRE-ESTABLISHED HARMONY AND FREEDOM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Since nothing happens without a reason, there must be a being outside the chain of contingent things who explains it; that being chose this world from infinitely many possible ones because it is the best; and he set every monad going so that they all keep perfect time with each other without ever touching.

Technical definition: The Principle of Sufficient Reason holds that nothing is without a reason why it is so rather than otherwise; truths of reason are necessary and their opposite implies a contradiction, while truths of fact are contingent and their complete analysis is infinite; God, as the necessary being demanded by the Principle, actualises the best of all compossible worlds; and pre-established harmony coordinates the internally unfolding states of all monads, yielding a compatibilist freedom composed of spontaneity, intelligence and contingency.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Pre-established harmony denies causal interaction but not agency: a monad's states unfold from its own internal principle, so the very doctrine that removes external influence is what guarantees that action is *self-expression* - which is why Leibniz can claim, without contradiction, that a world in which nothing pushes anything is a world in which freedom is safest.

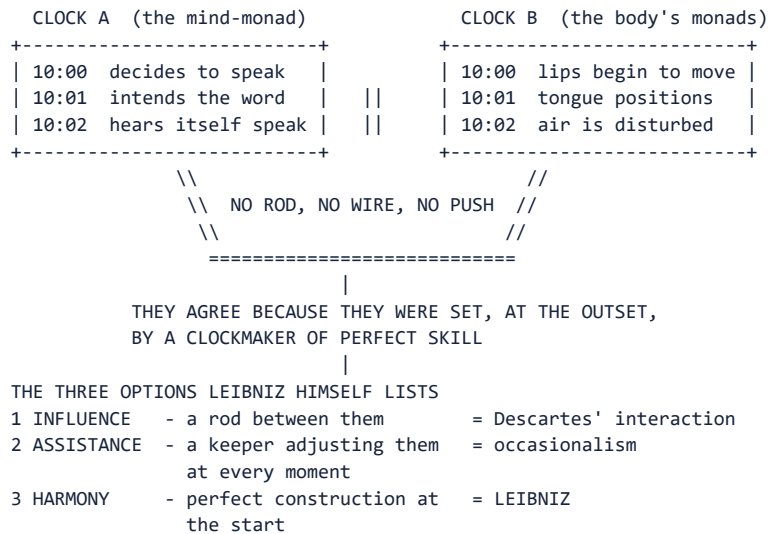
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Principle of Sufficient Reason (PSR) - nothing without a reason
- truths of reason and truths of fact
- complete individual concept
- possible worlds; compossibility; the best of all possible worlds (*le meilleur des mondes possibles*)
- pre-established harmony; the two synchronised clocks
- spontaneity, intelligence and contingency
- "incline without necessitating" (*incliner sans necessiter*)

- **hypothetical or moral necessity versus absolute or logical necessity**

How to use them: PSR first, because it generates God, indiscernibles and the two kinds of truth alike; then harmony; then the three conditions of freedom; then the necessity distinction, which is where the marks are.

Plain-language visual - two clocks that were never connected

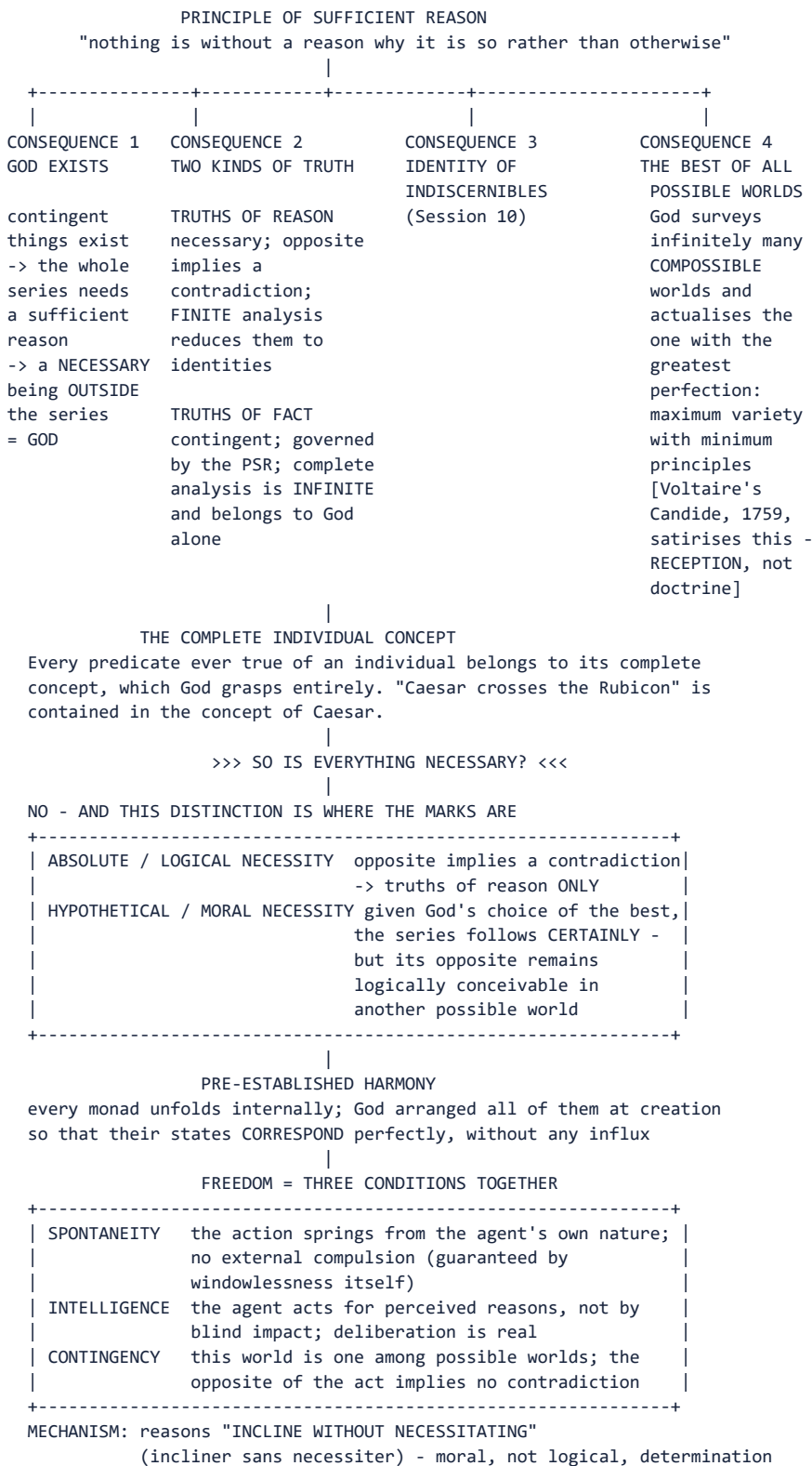


In simple words: the second option - a keeper constantly correcting the clocks - is occasionalism, and Leibniz rejects it as unworthy of a perfect craftsman: a clockmaker who must keep intervening is a poor clockmaker. Naming all three options and rejecting two is what turns a picture into an argument.

Remember first	Meaning
PSR	nothing is so rather than otherwise without a reason
Truth of reason	opposite implies a contradiction; necessary
Truth of fact	opposite is conceivable; contingent, though certain
Compossible	able to exist together in one world
Incline without necessitating	reasons make a choice certain, not logically compelled

One-line memory: harmony is set **once, at the start** - not maintained by repeated divine repairs.

VISUAL: VISUAL - one principle, four consequences



ANALYSIS: **Caption.** The two-line necessity box is the highest-value content in the whole Leibniz half of this topic. Both 2018 Q1(b) and 2020 Q1(b) are won or lost there.

1. The Principle of Sufficient Reason, and the proof of God

FACT: **PSR:** nothing is without a reason why it is so rather than otherwise.

FACT: **The argument to God** is a cosmological argument in PSR form:

1. Contingent things exist, and each has its reason in a prior contingent thing.
2. The whole *series* of contingent things is itself contingent, and so requires a sufficient reason.
3. That reason cannot lie within the series, since every member is contingent.

4. □ There must be a **necessary being** outside the series, whose reason for existing lies in its own nature. That is God.

FACT: Leibniz also accepts an **ontological** route, but characteristically adds a repair: one must first show that the concept of a supremely perfect being is **possible** - that its perfections are compatible - before inferring existence from it.

2. Truths of reason and truths of fact

	Truths of reason	Truths of fact
Example	"a triangle has three sides"; the truths of mathematics and logic	"Caesar crossed the Rubicon"; "this world contains India"
Opposite	implies a contradiction	is conceivable ; implies no contradiction
Modality	necessary	contingent , though certain
Governed by	the principle of contradiction	the Principle of Sufficient Reason
Analysis	finite : can in principle be reduced to identities	infinite : completed only by God

ANALYSIS: This distinction is Leibniz's own answer to the charge that his complete-concept doctrine makes everything necessary, and it is the pivot of the freedom answer in Section 5.

3. Possible worlds, compossibility and the best world

FACT: God's understanding contains infinitely many **possible** individuals and worlds. Not all possibles are **compossible** - capable of existing together - so possible worlds are maximal compossible sets.

FACT: God, being perfectly good and wise, actualises the world with the **greatest perfection**. Leibniz's own gloss on "best" is **the greatest variety of phenomena governed by the simplest laws** - maximum richness with minimum means.

WRONG: "Best" does **not** mean maximum human comfort or the absence of suffering. This is the standard misreading, and it is the misreading Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) satirises.

ANALYSIS: **Reception versus doctrine**. *Candide* is a literary reaction, not a philosophical refutation, and citing it as though it stated Leibniz's position is a clear error. Cite it, correctly labelled, as the reason the phrase acquired its ironic sense.

FACT: **Theodicy in one line, as far as this topic owns it**: evil is permitted because a world containing it is, overall, the most perfect compossible whole; the perfection is a property of the *whole system*, not of each part taken alone.

4. Pre-established harmony

FACT: Since monads are windowless, mind and body do not really interact. God arranged all monads **at creation** so that the perceptions of the mind-monad and the states of the body's monads correspond perfectly.

FACT: **The two-clocks image**. Two perfectly made clocks keep the same time without any connection between them. Leibniz explicitly contrasts three possibilities - **influence** (a rod between them: Descartes), **assistance** (a keeper constantly adjusting them: occasionalism), and **harmony** (perfect construction at the outset: his own view) - and rejects the first as unintelligible and the second as unworthy of a perfect craftsman.

ANALYSIS: **The standing objection**: harmony is *ad hoc* and unfalsifiable; it preserves the *appearance* of interaction while denying its reality, and it explains any correspondence whatever equally well. **Leibniz's reply**: it is the only account that avoids both unintelligible cross-substance causation and the loss of a genuine plurality of substances; and unlike occasionalism it does not require continuous miracles.

5. Freedom - the answer to the 2018 and 2020 questions

FACT: Leibniz rejects **both** Spinozan necessitarianism **and** Cartesian libertarian indifference. His compatibilism requires three conditions **together**:

1. **Spontaneity**. The action springs from the agent's own nature; there is no external compulsion. Windowlessness *guarantees* this - nothing outside the monad can push it.

2. **Intelligence.** The agent deliberates and acts for perceived reasons, not by blind impact. This is what distinguishes a rational spirit from a bare monad.
3. **Contingency.** The actual world is one of infinitely many possible worlds; the opposite of the act implies no contradiction and is realised in some other possible world.

FACT: "Reasons incline without necessitating" (incliner sans necessiter). The strongest motive prevails and the outcome is certain, but the determination is **moral**, not **logical**: it remains conceivable that the agent act otherwise, in the sense that no contradiction follows from supposing it.

CAUTION: The residual difficulty, which must be stated. If every predicate of an individual is already contained in its complete concept, and God has actualised this world, then *this* agent could not now act otherwise. The availability of alternatives in other possible worlds may not satisfy a libertarian who demands that *this* agent, in *these* circumstances, could have done otherwise. Leibniz's contingency can therefore look merely epistemic from the creature's standpoint.

ANALYSIS: The examiner-safe verdict: pre-established harmony leaves a defensible place for responsible self-expression, but not for libertarian alternative possibilities. It yields coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. Pre-established harmony makes room for freedom rather than abolishing it, because it converts every action into an unfolding of the agent's own nature. **Named evidence.** *Monadology* Section 7 denies all causal influx, so a monad's states arise from its internal principle of appetite alone; the *Discourse on Metaphysics* holds that every predicate ever true of an individual is contained in its complete concept; the *Theodicy* and the correspondence with Clarke supply the possible-worlds framework and the formula that reasons incline without necessitating (*incliner sans necessiter*). **Analysis.** Freedom then requires three conditions jointly - spontaneity, which windowlessness itself guarantees; intelligence, which distinguishes rational spirits from bare monads; and contingency, which survives because "Caesar crosses the Rubicon" is certain in the world God chose but implies no contradiction and is denied in other possible worlds. The determination is therefore moral rather than logical. **Qualification.** The concession worth making is precise: since the complete concept of the actual agent is fixed and this world is the one actualised, alternatives are available across worlds rather than within this one, so a libertarian who insists that *this* agent could now have done otherwise will regard Leibnizian contingency as epistemic rather than real.

Exam link

- **2018 Q1(b), 10 marks** - "any place for freedom ... pre-established harmony" is Section 4 and Section 5 exactly.
- **2020 Q1(b), 10 marks** - the same material, but the directive "with your own comments" requires an explicit signposted personal verdict in the final quarter.
- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks** - Leibniz is the defended winner, on the compatibilist criterion.
- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks** - Section 1 supplies why Leibniz's method differs: PSR, not doubt and not geometrical demonstration.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
Calling Leibniz a libertarian	He is a compatibilist; he rejects indifference explicitly
Calling Leibniz a fatalist or necessitarian	He distinguishes hypothetical from absolute necessity precisely to avoid this
Treating harmony as continuous divine intervention	That is occasionalism , which Leibniz rejects; harmony is set once at creation
Reading "best of all possible worlds" as maximum comfort	It means greatest variety under simplest laws
Citing <i>Candide</i> as Leibniz's view	It is Voltaire's 1759 satire - reception, not doctrine
Giving only spontaneity as Leibniz's account of freedom	All three conditions are required together

Revision notes

- PSR: nothing without a reason; grounds God, indiscernibles and truths of fact.
- Cosmological route: contingent series needs a necessary being outside it.
- Truths of reason: opposite contradictory, finite analysis. Truths of fact: opposite conceivable, infinite analysis, God alone completes it.
- Complete individual concept contains every predicate.
- Possible worlds; compossibility; best = greatest variety under simplest laws.
- Harmony: influence / assistance / harmony - the third is Leibniz's; set once at creation; two clocks.
- Freedom = spontaneity + intelligence + contingency; "incline without necessitating".
- Hypothetical or moral necessity $\neq$ absolute or logical necessity.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - LEIBNIZ II: HARMONY AND FREEDOM

PRINCIPLE OF SUFFICIENT REASON: nothing so rather than otherwise without a reason
|
+--> contingent series needs a NECESSARY BEING outside it -> GOD
+--> TRUTHS OF REASON: opposite contradictory | finite analysis
+--> TRUTHS OF FACT: opposite conceivable | INFINITE analysis, God alone
+--> IDENTITY OF INDISCERNIBLES (Session 10)
+--> BEST OF ALL POSSIBLE WORLDS: maximum variety, simplest laws
[Candide 1759 = reception, NOT doctrine]
v
COMPLETE INDIVIDUAL CONCEPT contains every predicate ever true of the individual
|
v
IS EVERYTHING THEREFORE NECESSARY? NO:
ABSOLUTE / LOGICAL necessity -> only truths of reason
HYPOTHETICAL / MORAL necessity -> certain given God's choice, opposite still
conceivable in another possible world
|
v
PRE-ESTABLISHED HARMONY: three options - INFLUENCE (Descartes) | ASSISTANCE
(occasionalism) | HARMONY (Leibniz, set once at creation) -> TWO CLOCKS
|
v
FREEDOM = SPONTANEITY (windowlessness guarantees it)
+ INTELLIGENCE (acts for perceived reasons)
+ CONTINGENCY (other possible worlds)
reasons INCLINE WITHOUT NECESSITATING (incliner sans necessiter)
|
v
CONCEDE: alternatives lie ACROSS worlds, not WITHIN this one
VERDICT: coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom
TRAP: not occasionalism | not fatalism | not libertarianism | Candide is satire
ANSWER LINE: the doctrine that removes external influence is the same doctrine
that makes action self-expression

SESSION 12 - COMPARISON, CRITICISMS AND REPLIES, ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVES AND PROVENANCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: This session puts the three systems side by side on the same questions, collects the standard objections and the best replies, and then turns all of it into a method for writing the answer the examiner actually asked for.

Technical definition: A comparative and metacognitive session: matched-axis comparison of substance, God, mind-body and freedom; a criticism-reply-residual ledger for each thinker; directive decoding for the command words used in UPSC Philosophy Paper I; graded verdicts at 10, 15 and 20 marks; and translation, quotation and provenance discipline.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The three rationalists are best read not as three answers to one question but as three verdicts on whether the question was well formed: Descartes accepts the mind-body problem and cannot answer it, Spinoza dissolves it by denying the two-substance premise, and Leibniz dissolves it by denying causation between substances altogether - and the fact that no single criterion selects among them is itself the strongest evidence that what Descartes bequeathed was a pseudo-problem rather than a problem.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **matched axes** - compare on the *same* question, or the comparison is decorative
- **state the criterion before ranking**
- **explanatory economy versus fidelity to experience versus systematic consistency**
- **directive fidelity** - discuss, critically discuss, comment, explain, substantiate
- **structural citation** - *Ethics* I, Def. 7; II, P7; Meditation III; *Monadology* Section 7
- **provenance caution** - Letter 50; Ryle's coinage; *Candide*

How to use them: In any comparative question, name the axis, run all three, state the criterion, deliver a ranked verdict. Never present three descriptions and stop.

Plain-language visual - the same four questions, asked three times

HOW MANY SUBSTANCES?	DESCARTES three (analogically)	SPINOZA one (strictly)	LEIBNIZ infinitely many (simple, active)
WHAT IS GOD FOR?	GUARANTEES knowledge	IS the system (immanent cause)	SELECTS and harmonises
MIND AND BODY?	INTERACT (pineal gland)	are ONE THING twice expressed	NEVER interact (harmony)
WHAT IS FREEDOM?	the will can affirm, deny or withhold	acting from one's own understood nature	spontaneity + intelligence + contingency

 READ DOWN a column = one system.
 READ ACROSS a row = one examination question.
 The examiner almost always asks you to read ACROSS.

In simple words: most weak scripts read down the columns - a paragraph on Descartes, a paragraph on Spinoza, a paragraph on Leibniz. Strong scripts read across the rows and then say which answer is better *by a stated standard*. That single habit is worth more than any additional fact.

Remember first	Meaning
Matched axis	all three answer the <i>same</i> question in the same terms
Criterion	the standard by which you will rank them
Verdict	a defended position, not a summary
Residual	what survives even after the best reply
Provenance	who actually said the words you are quoting

One-line memory: a comparison without a **criterion** is a **list**.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the seven-axis comparison and the criticism ledger

THE SEVEN AXES THAT COVER EVERY COMPARATIVE QUESTION IN THIS TOPIC

AXIS	DESCARTES	SPINOZA	LEIBNIZ
substance	3: God, mind, matter	1: God or Nature	infinitely many monads
God	personal, transcendent; veracity-guarantee	impersonal, immanent; IS all reality	necessary being; chose the best possible world
mind-body	interaction (pineal gland)	parallelism (double aspect)	pre-established harmony
freedom	libertarian free will	freedom = understanding necessity	compatibilism
method	doubt -> cogito -> reconstruction	geometrical demonstration (more geometrico)	sufficient reason + complete concepts
the individual	a thinking substance	a mode of God	a unique monad (a substance)
the physical world	res extensa, mechanistic	a mode of the attribute Extension	well-founded phenomenon

CRITICISM - REPLY - RESIDUAL LEDGER

TARGET	CRITICISM	REPLY	RESIDUAL
Descartes	the Circle (Arnauld, Fourth Objections)	attended intuition needs no guarantee; God secures memory and long chains	the divine proofs themselves use remembered premises
Descartes	interaction (Princess Elisabeth, 1643)	the union is a third PRIMITIVE NOTION	a location, not a mechanism
Descartes	"substance" is used inconsistently	it is ANALOGICAL: absolutely of God, relatively of created things	Spinoza will exploit exactly this concession
Spinoza	pantheism removes a personal God -> moral collapse?	morality rests on adequate knowledge, not divine command	providence, petition and worship are lost
Spinoza	acosmism (Hegel): if God is the only reality, the world is nothing	modes are real AS expressions, not as independent beings	dependent individuality remains thin
Spinoza	determinism destroys moral responsibility	responsibility is reinterpreted; the free person acts from understanding	alternative possibilities never return
Spinoza	"all determination is negation" makes the finite merely negative	finite things are positive MODES, limited by other modes	the formula is Hegel's universalisation of Letter 50
Leibniz	harmony is ad hoc / unfalsifiable	it is the only route avoiding both unintelligible influx and monism	it does buy agreement in advance
Leibniz	"best of all possible worlds" -> Voltaire's Candide	"best" = maximum variety under simplest laws, not maximum comfort	the criterion of perfection is not independently testable
Leibniz	freedom is illusory if every state is in the complete concept	contingency is preserved: the opposite implies no contradiction	alternatives are across worlds, not within this one

ANALYSIS: Caption. The residual column is what separates a good answer from a top answer. Reporting a criticism and a reply is exposition; saying what survives the reply is evaluation.

1. Ranking, and why the criterion must come first

ANALYSIS: Every comparative question in this topic is decided by the criterion you announce:

If freedom means ...	Then the winner is ...	And the price is ...
genuine alternative possibilities	Descartes	an interaction he cannot make intelligible
acting from an adequate understanding of one's own nature	Spinoza	libertarian free will disappears entirely
determined yet responsible agency	Leibniz	correspondence is bought from God in advance

FACT: The same discipline applies to the mind-body question: judged by **explanatory economy** Spinoza wins; judged by **fidelity to experience** Descartes wins; judged by **systematic consistency** Leibniz wins.

ANALYSIS: For the 2024 comparative question, the examiner-safe ruling is **Leibniz**, *provided the criterion is stated*: his is the only account that keeps both the determination the metaphysics requires and the responsibility ethics requires. A bare assertion that "Leibniz preserves freedom", without hypothetical necessity, internal spontaneity and possible worlds, earns very little.

2. Directive decoder - what each command word obliges you to do

Directive, as printed	What it demands	Structural obligation here	Fatal error
Discuss	exposition and assessment, both substantial	doctrine reconstructed as numbered steps, then a weighing paragraph; roughly 60:40	pure exposition with no evaluative sentence
Critically discuss / examine	assessment must dominate	reconstruct in three or four lines, then spend the bulk on objection -> reply -> adjudication; a verdict is compulsory	listing criticisms without ruling between them
Comment (2025 Q2b)	short, pointed, thesis-first	open by stating what the sentence means inside Spinoza's own system ; then one consequence for God, one for finite modes, one for knowledge; then a one-line judgement	treating "comment" as an invitation to a general essay on Spinoza
Explain (2019 Q2c; 2020 Q4b)	make the doctrine intelligible , showing why it follows	foreground the derivation - from Definition 7, P16, P29 - not from summary	restating the quotation in other words
Substantiate your view (2022 Q2c)	take a side and defend it with textual grounds	declare "yes, it entails pantheism, in the following precise sense...", then defend against the acosmism reading	sitting on the fence
Discuss with your own comments (2020 Q1b)	an explicit first-person evaluative paragraph is being marked	reserve the final quarter for a signposted personal adjudication	omitting the personal verdict
Whose account is compatible with ...? Critically discuss (2024 Q3c)	a comparative ranking with a defended winner	rank all three against a stated criterion of freedom, then defend the ranking	describing all three neutrally
What is the reason for the difference ...? (2018 Q2a)	explanatory , not descriptive	give the <i>mechanism</i> : one inherited definition, three different applications of the independence criterion	tabulating three views without explaining the divergence

3. Graded verdict bank - executable closing positions

ANALYSIS: Each of these is a **defensible position**, not a summary. Use or compress.

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict, with the concession	20-mark verdict: thesis + mechanism + cost
Cartesian method	The method of doubt is not scepticism but scepticism's instrument: it is used to destroy itself, and it succeeds only because the <i>cogito</i> is performatively, not inferentially, certain.	... Its success is local: the <i>cogito</i> secures the existence of a thinker but not the substantiality of the thinker, and Hume and Kant both exploit exactly this gap.	Descartes' method delivers a genuine indubitable, but the reconstruction built on it is only as strong as the divine guarantee - so the <i>Meditations</i> stand or fall on Meditation III, not Meditation II, and the Circle is the system's load-bearing joint rather than a peripheral blemish.
The wax argument	The wax proves not that bodies exist but that, if known, they are known by intellect - and that self-knowledge is epistemically prior.	... It succeeds against naive empiricism because no sensory item registers <i>identity through change</i> ; it fails to establish apriority, since the empiricist can call extension an abstraction.	Meditation II already installs extension as body's essence, so Meditation VI's dualism is partly presupposed rather than proved; the wax is the hinge on which Cartesian dualism silently turns.
Substance across the trio	The three differ not because they disagree about the <i>definition</i> of substance but because they differ over how strictly to apply it.	... Descartes applies it loosely, admitting dependent created substances; Spinoza strictly, so that only the wholly independent qualifies; Leibniz adds simplicity, so that only the partless qualifies.	The trio is one argument unfolding: Spinoza's monism is the consistent Descartes and Leibniz's pluralism is the consistent rejection of extension as an essence - so "substance" is not a discovery but a criterion, and the metaphysics you get is the criterion you enforce.
God	For Descartes God is a guarantee, for Spinoza God is the system, for Leibniz God is a selector.	... Only Spinoza's God does no explanatory work <i>outside</i> the system, which is why his alone does not stand or fall with the ontological proof.	Kant's objection that existence is not a real predicate bears directly on Descartes' and Leibniz's God but leaves Spinoza's largely untouched, because Spinoza does not infer God's existence from a concept of perfection - he identifies God with substance itself.
Mind and body	The three solutions are not three answers to one question but three verdicts on whether the question is well formed.	... Descartes accepts the question and cannot answer it; Spinoza dissolves it by denying the two-substance premise; Leibniz dissolves it by denying causation between substances.	Judged by explanatory economy Spinoza wins, by fidelity to experience Descartes wins, by systematic consistency Leibniz wins - and that no single criterion selects one answer is itself the strongest evidence that Descartes bequeathed a pseudo-problem.
Freedom and determinism	Spinoza does not abolish freedom, he relocates it - from the will's indifference to the intellect's adequacy.	... Whether that is freedom or determinism renamed depends on whether "could have done otherwise" is essential to freedom; Spinoza denies it, and denies it consistently.	Against a stated criterion: if freedom requires alternative possibilities only Descartes qualifies, at the price of an unintelligible interaction; if it requires self-determination Spinoza qualifies best; if it requires reconciling determination with responsibility, Leibniz's spontaneity, intelligence and contingency is the most workable - and that is the examiner-safe ruling.
The three kinds of knowledge	Spinoza's three kinds are three ontological positions of the knower, not three degrees of confidence.	... This makes epistemology and ethics one subject, his most original move; but because intuitive knowledge is self-certifying (<i>verum index sui</i>), it is also his most vulnerable.	The tripartite scheme is what converts necessitarianism from a fatalism into an ethics: because knowing adequately <i>is</i> acting from one's own nature, the discovery that all is necessary is itself the act by which one becomes free - at the price that no external criterion distinguishes the third kind from confident imagination.

4. Translation, quotation and provenance discipline

FACT: **Rule of this topic:** quote verbatim only where a standard English edition is being followed and named; elsewhere paraphrase and mark it as paraphrase. Never present a reconstructed sentence in quotation marks.

Text	Standard editions	Safe practice
Descartes, <i>Meditations on First Philosophy</i> (Latin 1641; French 1647)	Cottingham-Stoothoff-Murdoch, <i>The Philosophical Writings of Descartes</i> (CUP, 1984) - the scholarly default; the older Haldane-Ross (1911) is still common in Indian editions	Wording differs between editions: <i>inspectio mentis</i> is "purely mental scrutiny" in Cottingham-Stoothoff-Murdoch but "inspection of the mind" in Haldane-Ross. Either name the edition or paraphrase
<i>Cogito, ergo sum</i>	The French <i>je pense, donc je suis</i> is in the <i>Discourse</i> (1637); the Latin tag is in <i>Principles</i> I.7; the <i>Meditations</i> has the first-person "I am, I exist" formulation	FACT: Safe to quote the Latin tag. WRONG: Do not attribute " <i>cogito, ergo sum</i> " to the <i>Meditations</i>
Spinoza, <i>Ethics</i> (<i>Ethica</i> , posthumous 1677)	Curley, <i>The Collected Works of Spinoza</i> Vol. I (Princeton, 1985) is the current standard; Elwes (1883) and White-Stirling are the older public-domain versions widely reprinted in India	Cite by structural reference - I, Def. 7; I, P15; I, P16; I, P18; I, P29; II, P7; II, P40 Sch. 2; V, P32 Cor. Structural references are translation-invariant; page numbers are not
<i>Omnis determinatio est negatio</i>	ANALYSIS: Provenance caution. The exact Latin formula is not in the <i>Ethics</i> . Spinoza writes <i>determinatio negatio est</i> in Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles, 2 June 1674 . The universalised slogan is Hegel's rendering	Write: "Spinoza's dictum, in Letter 50, that determination is negation - universalised by Hegel as <i>omnis determinatio est negatio</i> ." This answers 2025 Q2(b) and earns a provenance mark
<i>Deus sive Natura</i>	<i>Ethics</i> IV, Preface, and IV, P4 Demonstration	FACT: Safe verbatim
Leibniz, <i>Monadology</i> (written 1714; printed posthumously)	Latta (1898); Ariew-Garber, <i>Philosophical Essays</i> (Hackett, 1989)	"Monads have no windows" is a standard rendering of Section 7 (<i>Les Monades n'ont point de fenêtres</i>), not a literal English original. FACT: Safe if you say "as it is usually rendered"
"The best of all possible worlds"	<i>Theodicy</i> (1710); <i>Monadology</i> Section Section 53-55	FACT: Safe. Note that it is Leibniz's own French, <i>le meilleur des mondes possibles</i> , and that Voltaire's <i>Candide</i> (1759) satirises it
"Incline without necessitating"	<i>Theodicy</i> ; also the Leibniz-Clarke correspondence	FACT: Standard rendering of <i>incliner sans nécessiter</i>

WRONG: **Never write:** "Descartes says the mind is a ghost in the machine." That is **Gilbert Ryle's** hostile coinage (*The Concept of Mind*, 1949). Attribute it correctly and the same sentence becomes a mark-earner.

5. Answer spines

10 MARKS - D-R-A-E about 150 to 200 words
Define -> Reconstruct -> Apply one named text or example -> Evaluate

15 MARKS - D-R-D-E-V about 250 to 300 words
Define -> Reconstruct -> Debate (objection and reply) -> Evaluate -> Verdict

20 MARKS - C-M-C about 340 to 400 words
Common premise -> Mechanism of divergence -> Comparative costs and conclusion

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim. The rationalist disagreement about mind and body is best understood as a disagreement about whether Descartes' question was well formed, and any ranking of the three answers is only as good as the criterion it declares. **Named evidence.** Descartes' real distinction in Meditation VI generates the problem and the correspondence with Princess Elisabeth exposes it; *Ethics* II, P7 removes it by making the two orders one; *Monadology* Section 7 removes it by denying influx and replacing it with pre-established harmony. **Analysis.** Because each successor rejects a different premise - Spinoza the plurality of substances, Leibniz the possibility of transeunt causation - the three positions are not rivals on a level field: they answer differently because they are answering differently framed questions, which is why "who is right?" must be replaced by "right by what standard?". **Qualification.** On explanatory economy Spinoza wins, on fidelity to lived experience Descartes wins, and on systematic consistency Leibniz wins; that no single criterion selects a unique answer is itself evidence that the original problem was generated by a metaphysical decision rather than discovered in experience.

Exam link

- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks** - Section 1 is the whole method of the answer, and Section 3's mind-body row supplies the verdict.
- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks** - the mechanism in Section 1 of Session 1, executed with Section 3's substance row.
- **2025 Q2(b), 15 marks** - Section 4's provenance line should be the opening sentence.
- Every question in the topic - Section 2's directive decoder determines the shape before a word is written.

UPSC traps

Trap	Correction
Comparing without a criterion	A comparison with no announced standard is a list, not an argument
Reading down the columns	Examiners ask you to read across the rows
Reporting criticism and reply without the residual	The residual column is where evaluation happens
Quoting the <i>Ethics</i> for "all determination is negation"	Letter 50, universalised by Hegel
Using Ryle's "ghost in the machine" as Descartes' own	It is a 1949 coinage by a hostile critic
Ignoring the directive	"Comment", "explain" and "critically discuss" demand three different shapes

Revision notes

- Seven axes: substance, God, mind-body, freedom, method, the individual, the physical world.
- Criticism-reply-**residual**: always finish the third column.
- State the criterion, then rank; 2024 safe answer is Leibniz on the compatibilist criterion.
- Directives: discuss (60:40), critically discuss (evaluation dominates), comment (thesis-first), explain (derivation), substantiate (take a side), own comments (first-person quarter).
- Spines: 10 D-R-A-E; 15 D-R-D-E-V; 20 C-M-C.
- Provenance: Letter 50; Ryle 1949; *Candide* 1759; edition differences in Descartes.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - COMPARISON AND ANSWER CRAFT

SEVEN AXES: substance | God | mind-body | freedom | method | individual | world
| READ ACROSS the rows, not down the columns
v
CRITICISM -> REPLY -> RESIDUAL (the third column is where marks are earned)
Descartes: Circle | interaction | analogical substance
Spinoza: personality lost | acosmism | responsibility | negation
Leibniz: ad hoc harmony | "best world" | fixed complete concepts
v
STATE THE CRITERION, THEN RANK
alternatives possible -> DESCARTES (cost: unintelligible interaction)
self-determination -> SPINOZA (cost: no free will at all)
responsible under determination -> LEIBNIZ (cost: harmony bought in advance)
v
DIRECTIVE DECODER: discuss | critically discuss | comment | explain |
substantiate | with your own comments | rank-and-defend
v
SPINES: 10 D-R-A-E | 15 D-R-D-E-V | 20 C-M-C
v
PROVENANCE: Letter 50 (not the Ethics) | Ryle 1949 (not Descartes) |
Candide 1759 (satire, not doctrine) | cite Spinoza structurally
ANSWER LINE: three verdicts on whether the question was well formed - and no
neutral criterion selects among them

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed independently, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - Rationalism in Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz; Cartesian Method and Certain Knowledge; Substance; God; Mind-Body Dualism; Determinism and Freedom - together with the three kinds of ideas, the wax argument, the Cartesian Circle, the proof of the external world, the three kinds of knowledge, striving (*conatus*), monadic perception and hierarchy, the identity of indiscernibles, the two kinds of truth, possible worlds and pre-established harmony. The eight remedial drills attack the specific confusions that cost marks every year.

MCQ 1. What the rationalist thesis actually asserts

Consider the following statements about early-modern rationalism.

1. It denies that sense-experience can by itself supply the warrant for necessity and universality.
2. It holds that the structure of reality is accessible to reason, and explains that structure through substance, attribute and mode.
3. It maintains that sensory beliefs are uniformly false and that the physical world is an illusion.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
B. 2 and 3 only
C. 1 and 2 only
D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it couples the sound thesis about warrant with a caricature; Descartes devotes the whole of Meditation VI to *restoring* the material world rather than abolishing it.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 2 is accurate but statement 3 attributes to the school a position Spinoza expressly rejects when he classes sense-based imagination as a genuine, if inadequate, kind of knowledge.

- **C:** Correct: the two load-bearing commitments are the claim about warrant and the claim that an intelligible reality is to be articulated through a metaphysics of substance, attribute and mode.
- **D:** Incorrect: accepting all three converts a thesis about justification into a thesis about illusion, which no member of the trio holds.

Examiner trap 1: Defining rationalism as hostility to the senses is the commonest opening error in this topic. Define it by the **source of warrant** for necessary truth, and the rest of the answer stays on the syllabus.

MCQ 2. Which rule of method does the destructive work

In the *Discourse on the Method*, Part II, Descartes states four rules. The rule that generates the wholesale demolition of Meditation I is the rule requiring him to

- A. divide every difficulty under examination into as many parts as its solution requires
- B. conduct his thoughts in order, beginning with the simplest and easiest objects
- C. accept nothing as true which he does not clearly and evidently know to be so
- D. make his enumerations so complete and his reviews so general that nothing is omitted

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: analysis is a rule of problem-management inherited from mathematical practice; by itself it removes no belief whatever.
- **B:** Incorrect: proceeding from simple to complex organises an inquiry that is already under way and cannot license the suspension of whole classes of belief.
- **C:** Correct: once assent is withheld from whatever is not evident, and a single counterexample renders a whole class non-evident, the senses, the world and even mathematics can be suspended in turn.
- **D:** Incorrect: complete enumeration is a rule of review that guards against omission at the end of an inquiry, not a principle of demolition at its beginning.

Examiner trap 2: Listing the four rules without saying which of them does the work turns a philosophical method into a memorised quartet. Name rule one as the engine of the *Meditations*.

MCQ 3. The order of the three doubts

Match each stage of Cartesian doubt with what it is designed to remove.

1. Sense-deception - 2. The dream argument - 3. The evil genius (*genius malignus*)
- I. Even the simple truths of arithmetic and geometry. II. The reliability of particular perceptual judgements about how things appear. III. The immediate perceptual situation, and with it the whole external world.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1-II, 2-III, 3-I
- B. 1-III, 2-I, 3-II
- C. 1-I, 2-II, 3-III
- D. 1-II, 2-I, 3-III

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the stages are cumulative - sense-deception unsettles particular perceptual judgements, the dream argument removes the situation and the world, and only the deceiver hypothesis reaches mathematics.
- **B:** Incorrect: it makes the weakest doubt do the strongest work and leaves the deceiver hypothesis attacking what the first stage had already unsettled.
- **C:** Incorrect: it exactly inverts the sequence, so that mathematics falls first and the world falls last, destroying the argumentative escalation.

- **D:** Incorrect: it correctly places sense-deception but then reverses the two later stages, which removes the reason Descartes needs the deceiver at all.

Examiner trap 3: The order is itself an argument, because each stage attacks precisely what the previous stage left standing. Reporting the three doubts as an unordered list forfeits the structure the examiner is testing.

MCQ 4. The logical status of "I am, I exist"

Descartes' claim that he exists whenever he thinks is best characterised as

- A. an inductive generalisation drawn from many observed instances of his own thinking activity
- B. a deduction from the suppressed major premise that whatever thinks must exist
- C. an empirical report of an inner sensation whose occurrence he happens to notice
- D. an immediate intuition whose certainty is performative and confined to the present moment

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: an induction would yield only a probable generalisation, whereas Descartes needs a proposition that resists a supremely powerful deceiver.
- **B:** Incorrect: Descartes explicitly denies that the *cogito* is a syllogism concealing a general premise, and says instead that it is recognised by a simple intuition of the mind.
- **C:** Incorrect: treating it as an inner observation makes it one more piece of evidence that the deceiver hypothesis could in principle contaminate.
- **D:** Correct: the certainty is generated by the act of thinking itself and holds whenever the proposition is put forward or conceived, which is exactly why deception cannot touch it.

Examiner trap 4: Writing "*cogito, ergo sum*" and adding "therefore it is an inference" contradicts Descartes in the same sentence. The "therefore" belongs to the Latin tag of the *Discourse* and the *Principles*, not to the logic of the *Meditations*.

MCQ 5. The limits of what the thinking self establishes

Consider the following statements about what the *cogito* by itself establishes.

1. That thinking is occurring, and that the thinker exists while thinking.
2. That the thinker is an enduring immaterial substance numerically identical over time.
3. That there is at least one proposition immune to the hypothesis of a powerful deceiver.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 2 imports the substantial soul, which Descartes reaches only through the further work of Meditation II and the real distinction of Meditation VI.
- **B:** Correct: present thinking existence and immunity to the deceiver are precisely what the argument delivers, and nothing more.
- **C:** Incorrect: it pairs a genuine result with the unearned claim about diachronic identity, which is the gap Lichtenberg and Hume later exploit.
- **D:** Incorrect: accepting all three collapses the distinction between the certainty of the act and the metaphysics of its subject.

Examiner trap 5: Candidates routinely let the *cogito* prove the immortality of the soul in one line. Concede the narrowness of the result and then show how Descartes argues for more; the concession is worth more marks than the overreach.

MCQ 6. Sorting the three kinds of ideas

Match each class of idea with its correct description.

1. Adventitious (*adventitiae*) - 2. Factitious (*factitiae*) - 3. Innate (*innatae*)

I. Native to the mind's own rational nature and elicited on an appropriate occasion. II. Received as though from outside, arriving involuntarily through a passive faculty. III. Constructed voluntarily by the mind out of ideas it already possesses.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1-II, 2-III, 3-I

B. 1-I, 2-II, 3-III

C. 1-III, 2-I, 3-II

D. 1-II, 2-I, 3-III

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: adventitious ideas arrive involuntarily, factitious ideas are built by the mind at will, and innate ideas belong to the intellect's constitution.
- **B:** Incorrect: it makes the involuntary class native and the native class constructed, which destroys the causal argument of Meditation III.
- **C:** Incorrect: it treats made-up ideas as involuntary arrivals, so the golden mountain would need an external cause of its own.
- **D:** Incorrect: it correctly identifies the first class but exchanges the other two, so voluntary construction becomes native endowment.

Examiner trap 6: The classification is not decorative. It exists so that the idea of God can be placed in the third class and its content argued to exceed what a finite mind could manufacture.

MCQ 7. What Descartes means by an innate idea

The strongest formulation of Cartesian innateness - the one that Locke's appeal to the absence of universal assent does not reach - is that an innate idea is

A. a proposition consciously affirmed by every human being from the earliest moment of life

B. a sensory impression so frequently repeated that it has become impossible to doubt

C. an image stored in the memory before birth and later recovered by a distinct act of recollection

D. a native disposition of the intellect which produces the idea on an appropriate occasion

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the occurrent version of the doctrine, and it is exactly the version Locke destroys by pointing to children who affirm no such principles.
- **B:** Incorrect: grounding the idea in repeated sensation concedes the empiricist's central claim and abandons the rationalist thesis about warrant.
- **C:** Incorrect: pre-natal storage and recollection belong to the Platonic tradition; Descartes speaks of seeds of knowledge in the mind's constitution, not of retrieved images.
- **D:** Correct: innateness is dispositional - the mind is so constituted that, given an occasion, it produces the idea from its own resources.

Examiner trap 7: A 2023-style answer that presents the occurrent version and then reports Locke's refutation has staged a contest in which one side never got up. Always state the dispositional version first.

MCQ 8. Locke's grounds of refutation

Consider the following as grounds on which Locke rejects innate principles in the *Essay concerning Human Understanding*, Book I.

1. Alleged innate principles command no universal assent, since children and others do not affirm them.
2. Nothing can be said to be in the mind and yet unknown to it, on pain of making every knowable truth innate.
3. The idea of infinity is demonstrably richer than anything the mind could ever construct from finite materials.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 3 is a Cartesian premise for innateness, not a Lockean objection to it; Locke argues the opposite, that infinity is reached by repetition and negation.
- **B:** Correct: the absence of universal assent and the transparency of mental content are Locke's two principal tests, supported by his positive derivation of ideas from sensation and reflection.
- **C:** Incorrect: it pairs a genuine Lockean test with a claim that belongs to the side Locke is attacking.
- **D:** Incorrect: including statement 3 makes Locke argue for the doctrine he devotes Book I to dismantling.

Examiner trap 8: Omitting **reflection** misstates Locke. His two sources of ideas are sensation *and* the mind's observation of its own operations, and a script that mentions only sensation invites an easy correction.

MCQ 9. What the wax argument establishes

The conclusion the wax argument of Meditation II is designed to secure is that

- A. the wax has no real properties at all once its sensible qualities have been destroyed by heat
- B. bodily identity through qualitative change is grasped by the intellect rather than by sense
- C. the senses are wholly inoperative and contribute nothing whatever to any human judgement
- D. the existence of external material bodies follows directly from the persistence of the wax

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the wax retains extension, flexibility and changeability; the argument removes the sensible catalogue, not the object.
- **B:** Correct: every item in the sensible catalogue is replaced while the same wax is still judged to remain, so the vehicle of that judgement cannot be sense.
- **C:** Incorrect: Descartes' point is that what passes for seeing is judging, not that seeing has ceased; the "hats and coats" case makes exactly this distinction.
- **D:** Incorrect: existence is restored only in Meditation VI through divine veracity, and confusing the two is among the most heavily penalised errors in this topic.

Examiner trap 9: The wax proves *how* body would be known, never *that* body exists. Saying so explicitly, and in one sentence, is itself worth a mark in the 2019-style question.

MCQ 10. Why imagination cannot do the work

In the wax argument, the reason Descartes rejects imagination as the faculty by which the wax is grasped is that

- A. imagination is always accompanied by a sensory impression and so inherits every sensory defect
- B. imagination belongs to the body and is therefore extinguished whenever the body is altered
- C. heat can give the wax indefinitely many shapes, which no finite run of images could ever exhaust
- D. imagination operates only on objects that are absent, whereas the wax is present to him

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the argument does not turn on imagination inheriting sensory defects; it turns on a mismatch between an indefinite range and a finite capacity.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing in the passage makes imagination cease when the wax is heated, and the claim would prove far more than Descartes needs.
- **C:** Correct: this is the force of "flexible and changeable" (*flexibile et mutabile*) - the possible shapes are indefinite in number and cannot be run through in images.
- **D:** Incorrect: the presence or absence of the object is irrelevant, since the argument concerns the range of possible forms rather than their availability to sense.

Examiner trap 10: Answers that jump from "not sense" straight to "therefore intellect" skip the step that does the real work. Imagination must be eliminated separately, and by the indefiniteness of the possible shapes.

MCQ 11. Matching the proofs of God to their strategy

Match each Cartesian proof of God with its distinctive argumentative move.

1. Trademark or causal - 2. Conservation - 3. Ontological

I. Existence is contained in the concept of a supremely perfect being, so its denial is a contradiction. II. I cannot sustain my own existence from one moment to the next, so a continuing cause is required. III. The content of my idea of an infinite being exceeds anything a finite mind could have produced.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1-III, 2-II, 3-I
- B. 1-I, 2-III, 3-II
- C. 1-II, 2-I, 3-III
- D. 1-III, 2-I, 3-II

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the causal proof works from the objective reality of the idea, the conservation proof from my momentary dependence, and the ontological proof from the concept alone.
- **B:** Incorrect: it makes the trademark proof conceptual and the ontological proof causal, reversing the very feature that distinguishes them.
- **C:** Incorrect: it assigns momentary dependence to the trademark proof and conceptual necessity to conservation, so no proof retains its own premise.
- **D:** Incorrect: it opens correctly but then swaps conservation with the ontological route, losing the division of labour among the three arguments.

Examiner trap 11: Naming the division of labour among the three proofs earns more than reciting all three at length. Each answers a different question - where the idea came from, what sustains me, and what the concept contains.

MCQ 12. The Cartesian Circle and the reply

Arnauld's objection in the Fourth Objections, and Descartes' reply to it, are best stated as follows:

- A. the objection is that God cannot be proved at all, and the reply is that the idea of God is innate rather than voluntarily made
- B. the objection is that the *cogito* is really a syllogism, and the reply is that it is an immediate intuition
- C. the objection is that the senses cannot ever be trusted, and the reply is that a perfect God would never deceive
- D. the objection is that the criterion proves God who certifies it, and the reply separates attended from remembered perception

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: innateness answers a question about the origin of the idea, not the charge that the proof presupposes what it establishes.
- **B:** Incorrect: this correctly describes a different exchange about the logical form of the *cogito*, which Arnauld's circularity charge does not concern.
- **C:** Incorrect: divine veracity is the conclusion under attack, so citing it as the reply simply restates the position Arnauld is challenging.
- **D:** Correct: the charge is circularity between criterion and guarantee, and Descartes replies that a perception actually before the mind compels assent while God secures memory and extended reasoning.

Examiner trap 12: The reply must be followed by its residual weakness: the proofs of God are themselves extended arguments whose earlier premises are remembered rather than attended, so the circle is softened rather than removed.

MCQ 13. The proof of the external world

Consider the following steps in Descartes' Meditation VI argument for material things.

1. Sensory ideas arrive involuntarily, so I possess a passive faculty of receiving them.
2. I have a great natural inclination to refer these ideas to bodies, and no faculty by which the inclination could be corrected.
3. The wax argument has already demonstrated that at least one extended body exists outside me.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 3 misassigns to the wax argument an existential conclusion it expressly does not reach.
- **B:** Incorrect: it retains the correct claim about natural inclination but again treats the wax as an existence proof.
- **C:** Correct: involuntariness establishes a passive faculty needing an active cause, and the uncorrectable inclination makes any alternative attribution a divine deception.
- **D:** Incorrect: including statement 3 imports a conclusion from Meditation II that Meditation VI is written precisely to supply.

Examiner trap 13: Compressing this into "God guarantees the world" throws away the whole question. The 2019 examiner is marking a five-step causal argument, not a slogan.

MCQ 14. The argument for the real distinction

The reasoning by which Descartes concludes that mind and body are really distinct proceeds by holding that

- A. whatever can be clearly and distinctly conceived apart can by God's power exist apart, and so is distinct
- B. whatever is observed to behave independently in the course of ordinary experience must be a separate substance
- C. whatever has a different location in the body must belong to a different kind of created thing
- D. whatever survives the hypothesis of the evil genius is thereby shown to be immaterial in nature

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the inference runs from clear and distinct separate conception, through divine omnipotence, to real separability and hence real distinction.
- **B:** Incorrect: observed independence is precisely the sort of empirical premise the *Meditations* has already suspended, and it could not yield a metaphysical conclusion.
- **C:** Incorrect: location is a property of extended things alone, so an argument from location cannot establish that anything unextended exists.
- **D:** Incorrect: surviving the deceiver shows that the *cogito* is indubitable, not that its subject is immaterial; that further claim needs the separability argument.

Examiner trap 14: Dualism is a **conclusion** of the Cartesian system, drawn from the criterion of truth and divine omnipotence. Presenting it as an unargued starting assumption misrepresents the architecture and loses the link to Session 5.

MCQ 15. The interaction problem and the pineal gland

Descartes' appeal to the pineal gland, and Princess Elisabeth's objection to his position, are best understood as follows:

- A. the gland is the seat of the soul, a claim Elisabeth accepts while denying that any such soul can be immortal
- B. the gland gives interaction a location, while Elisabeth asks how the unextended could move the extended
- C. the gland is the organ of imagination, which Elisabeth argues should instead be assigned to the intellect
- D. the gland dissolves the problem entirely, and Elisabeth's objection concerns only the physiology of the nerves

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: immortality is not the issue in the 1643 correspondence, which turns on the intelligibility of causal commerce between the two substances.
- **B:** Correct: Descartes offers a site, chosen because the gland is unpaired and central, whereas Elisabeth's question is about a mechanism, which no site can supply.
- **C:** Incorrect: the dispute is not about which faculty is housed where, but about how any causal influence across the real distinction is possible.
- **D:** Incorrect: Descartes himself does not claim that the gland dissolves the difficulty; his considered reply is that the union is a primitive notion.

Examiner trap 15: Treating the pineal gland as Descartes' answer misses his real answer. The philosophical reply is that the mind-body union is a third **primitive notion**, known through ordinary living rather than through pure intellect.

MCQ 16. Error and the grades of freedom in Meditation IV

According to Descartes' account of error and freedom, error arises because the will is

- A. finite while the intellect is infinite, so that understanding constantly outruns what may be affirmed
- B. determined by bodily motions, so that assent is compelled by mechanical causes outside the mind
- C. most free when it is wholly indifferent, since indifference alone leaves alternatives genuinely open
- D. infinite in scope while the intellect is finite, so that assent may be given beyond clear perception

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it exactly reverses the two faculties, and on that reversal error could never occur, since nothing would be affirmed beyond what is understood.
- **B:** Incorrect: making assent mechanically compelled would remove the responsibility for error that Meditation IV is written to establish.
- **C:** Incorrect: Descartes ranks indifference as the *lowest* grade of freedom, since the will is most free when moved by clearly perceived truth.
- **D:** Correct: the infinite will can affirm or deny anything, the finite intellect perceives clearly only within limits, and error is assent given outside those limits.

Examiner trap 16: The claim that indifference is the highest freedom is the reverse of Descartes' text. Getting the ranking right also strengthens the later contrast with Spinoza, for whom freedom likewise increases with adequate understanding.

MCQ 17. Spinoza's argument for one substance

The demonstration by which Spinoza reaches a single substance turns essentially on the premise that

- A. two substances cannot share an attribute, so nothing whatever could distinguish them as substances
- B. God is defined at the outset as the only being whose essence involves its own existence
- C. extension is divisible and therefore cannot belong to what is ultimately real in nature
- D. thought and extension are known to us, while infinitely many further attributes remain unknown

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: from the impossibility of shared attributes it follows that a finite substance would need limiting by one of the same nature, so substance must be infinite and unique.
- **B:** Incorrect: self-causation is established in the course of the argument rather than stipulated, and stipulating it would make the demonstration circular.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is Leibniz's objection to extended substance, and Spinoza retains Extension as an attribute expressing the whole divine essence.
- **D:** Incorrect: the limitation of human knowledge to two attributes is a consequence of the system, not a premise from which uniqueness could be derived.

Examiner trap 17: Asserting monism without the no-shared-attribute step reduces a demonstration to a slogan. The 2022 and 2024 questions both reward the derivation rather than the conclusion.

MCQ 18. Attributes, modes and the contrast with Descartes

For Spinoza, thought and extension are best described as

- A. two finite modes which together exhaust the content of the one infinite substance
- B. two created substances which depend for their existence on the infinite substance
- C. two attributes, each expressing the whole eternal essence of the one substance
- D. two aspects of human perception which do not correspond to anything in substance

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: modes are affections existing in another and conceived through another, whereas an attribute is what the intellect perceives as constituting substance's essence.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is precisely the Cartesian position Spinoza rejects, and importing it collapses the whole point of difference between the two systems.
- **C:** Correct: each attribute expresses the whole essence, not a portion of it, and substance possesses infinitely many of which we know these two.
- **D:** Incorrect: reducing attributes to features of human perception makes them subjective, whereas Spinoza needs them to be real expressions of substance.

Examiner trap 18: Confusing Spinoza's **attributes** with Descartes' **substances** is the single most damaging error in comparative questions, because it destroys the explanation of why parallelism replaces interaction.

MCQ 19. "Whatever is, is in God"

In *Ethics* I, P15 and P18 together, the claim that whatever is, is in God, is best understood as asserting that

- A. finite things are spatially contained within a divine body that extends throughout the whole universe
- B. finite things exist as modes of the one substance, whose immanent and not transitive cause is God
- C. finite things were produced by an act of will at a moment in time and are conserved by divine choice
- D. finite things are appearances with no reality of their own, since only the infinite is genuinely real

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the containment is ontological rather than spatial, and a spatial reading would make God a very large extended object among others.
- **B:** Correct: modes exist in and are conceived through substance, and P18's immanent causation means the cause remains in the effect rather than producing something outside itself.
- **C:** Incorrect: Spinoza denies deliberation and temporal creation; modes follow from what substance is, not from a discretionary decree.
- **D:** Incorrect: this states Hegel's acosmism charge rather than Spinoza's doctrine, which grants modes a dependent but genuine reality.

Examiner trap 19: The preposition carries the doctrine. Reading "in God" spatially converts an argument about ontological dependence into an image, and the 2024 question is marked on the argument.

MCQ 20. Pantheism, panentheism and acosmism

Consider the following statements about the standard labels applied to Spinoza's God.

1. Pantheism, in the qualified sense that nothing exists outside God and all things are modes within the one immanent substance.
2. Acosmism, the charge associated with Hegel that if only substance is real then the finite world dissolves into nothing.
3. Panentheism, the reading on which all things are in God while God exceeds the finite modes and the two attributes we know.

Which of the statements given above correctly describe positions taken in the interpretive debate?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: omitting the panentheist reading removes the very option that best captures why substance is not exhausted by the world we perceive.
- **B:** Incorrect: dropping the qualified pantheist reading leaves out the position most commentators regard as the primary description of the system.
- **C:** Incorrect: omitting acosmism removes the strongest objection in the debate, which is that Spinoza denies rather than deifies the world.
- **D:** Correct: all three are genuine positions in the dispute, and a defensible answer states the qualified pantheism, answers the acosmism charge and notes the panentheist alternative.

Examiner trap 20: Pantheism and acosmism are **opposite** accusations - one that the world is made divine, the other that it is made nothing. Treating them as the same objection makes the 2022 answer incoherent.

MCQ 21. Necessity in Ethics I

Consider the following statements about Spinoza's necessitarianism.

1. P16 holds that infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from the necessity of the divine nature.
2. P29 holds that nothing in nature is contingent, apparent contingency recording only ignorance of causes.
3. The derivation is ontological rather than temporal, so it is not a story in which God first exists and later produces a world.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: leaving out the ontological character of the derivation permits the common misreading of P16 as a narrative of creation.
- **B:** Incorrect: omitting P16 removes the proposition the 2020 question actually quotes, and with it the source of the infinity claim.
- **C:** Incorrect: dropping P29 loses the explicit denial of contingency on which the whole account of freedom subsequently rests.

- **D:** Correct: the three statements together give the content, the consequence and the modality of Spinoza's necessity.

Examiner trap 21: Necessity here is logical and ontological, not an external compulsion pushing things about. Describing it as fate imports an agent that Spinoza's system does not contain.

MCQ 22. Parallelism as a solution to the mind-body problem

Spinoza's doctrine that the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things has the consequence that

- A. a mental event and a bodily event are one and the same single mode expressed under two attributes
- B. mental events cause bodily events, but only through the mediation of the infinite intellect
- C. bodily events cause mental events, since the mind is the idea of an already existing body
- D. mental and bodily events belong to two substances whose sequences God continually adjusts

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: because the two orders are the same order, a decision and a movement are not two items in causal commerce but one mode twice expressed.
- **B:** Incorrect: any mediation across attributes would reinstate the cross-attribute causation the doctrine exists to exclude.
- **C:** Incorrect: although the mind is the idea of the body, the relation is one of expression rather than production, and causation remains within each attribute.
- **D:** Incorrect: continual divine adjustment is occasionalism, a rival seventeenth-century position that Spinoza's monism makes unnecessary.

Examiner trap 22: The two-parallel-trains image quietly restores two things running side by side. Spinoza's claim is stronger and simpler: there is one thing, described completely in two ways.

MCQ 23. The three kinds of knowledge and the fourth proportional

In Spinoza's example of finding the fourth proportional to 1, 2 and 3, the merchant who applies a remembered rule, the mathematician who demonstrates it from the common property of proportionals, and the person who sees at once that the answer is 6, exemplify respectively

- A. reason, imagination and intuitive knowledge, in that order of increasing adequacy
- B. imagination, intuitive knowledge and reason, since demonstration is the highest form
- C. imagination, reason and intuitive knowledge, in that order of increasing adequacy
- D. intuitive knowledge, reason and imagination, since immediacy is the least reliable

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it makes rule-following from signs the second kind, whereas learning a rule by hearsay is precisely the first kind's mode of operation.
- **B:** Incorrect: it ranks discursive demonstration above the single adequate act, reversing Spinoza's own ordering in *Ethics* V.
- **C:** Correct: the merchant knows only that, from signs and vague experience; the mathematician knows adequately but discursively; the third grasps the ratio in the essences themselves, in one act.
- **D:** Incorrect: it treats immediacy as a defect, whereas for Spinoza the immediacy of intuitive knowledge is what makes it the highest kind.

Examiner trap 23: The three kinds are three **ontological positions of the knower**, not three degrees of confidence. That formulation is what converts an epistemology answer into an answer about freedom.

MCQ 24. Definition 7 and the meaning of Spinozist freedom

Ethics I, Definition 7 states that a thing is free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature and is determined to action by itself alone. This definition contrasts freedom with

- A. causation as such, so that a free act must be an event without any determining cause whatever
- B. external compulsion, so that a thing is free as far as it acts from its own understood nature
- C. rational deliberation, so that freedom belongs to spontaneous impulse rather than to understanding
- D. divine necessity, so that human freedom consists in an exemption from the general order of nature

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: an uncaused event is exactly what Spinoza denies is possible, and the definition speaks of self-determination rather than of the absence of determination.
- **B:** Correct: freedom is opposed to being determined by causes external to one's nature, which is why adequate ideas increase freedom rather than diminishing it.
- **C:** Incorrect: it inverts the doctrine, since for Spinoza it is precisely understanding that converts passive impulse into free action.
- **D:** Incorrect: no exemption from the causal order is available in Spinoza's system, and only God is free in the absolute sense the definition describes.

Examiner trap 24: The word to circle in Definition 7 is "alone". Freedom is opposed to **compulsion**, never to **causation**, and every strong answer on the 2023 quotation says so in its first two lines.

MCQ 25 (remedial). The provenance of "all determination is negation"

Which of the following statements about the formula *omnis determinatio est negatio* is correct?

- A. It is a proposition of *Ethics* I, demonstrated immediately after the definition of substance itself
- B. It is a phrase of Descartes, later applied to Spinoza by nineteenth-century commentators
- C. It universalises a remark in Spinoza's Letter 50 and entered the textbooks through Hegel
- D. It is a formulation of Leibniz, used to explain why no two monads can be exactly alike

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the exact Latin formula does not appear in the *Ethics* at all, and citing it there is a verifiable factual error.
- **B:** Incorrect: the remark is Spinoza's own, made in correspondence, and has no Cartesian source.
- **C:** Correct: Spinoza writes *determinatio negatio est* in Letter 50 of 2 June 1674, and the universalised slogan is Hegel's rendering, which is how it entered the tradition.
- **D:** Incorrect: the identity of indiscernibles is a distinct Leibnizian doctrine grounded in the Principle of Sufficient Reason.

Examiner trap 25: Getting the provenance right is worth a mark on its own in the 2025 question. Write "Spinoza's dictum, in Letter 50, that determination is negation - universalised by Hegel", and the sentence does two jobs at once.

MCQ 26 (remedial). Perception is not consciousness

Which of the following correctly states Leibniz's position on the mental life of monads?

- A. Every monad has perception, but only some have the reflexive awareness called apperception
- B. Every monad has apperception, since a perception without any awareness would be a contradiction
- C. Only rational spirits have perception, while lower monads possess appetite alone
- D. Only God has perception, and created monads merely reflect it without possessing it

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: perception is the representation of the manifold in the simple and need not be conscious; minute perceptions (*petites perceptions*) fall below the threshold of awareness.
- **B:** Incorrect: this collapses the distinction on which Leibniz's whole hierarchy rests and makes the roar of the sea inexplicable.
- **C:** Incorrect: appetite is the transition *between* perceptions, so a monad with appetite and no perception would have nothing to pass between.
- **D:** Incorrect: created monads genuinely perceive; each is described as a perpetual living mirror of the universe from its own point of view.

Examiner trap 26: Writing that monads are conscious points of force makes the hierarchy of bare monads, animal souls and rational spirits unintelligible. Perception is universal; apperception is not.

MCQ 27 (remedial). Individuality and the status of bodies

Consider the following statements about Leibniz's account of individuality and of extended bodies.

1. No two monads are exactly alike, since God would have no sufficient reason to create indistinguishable duplicates.
2. An organism is coordinated by a dominant monad together with an aggregate of subordinate monads.
3. Extended bodies are well-founded phenomena, grounded in ordered monadic aggregates rather than being arbitrary illusions.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: omitting the status of bodies leaves the system open to the false charge that Leibniz simply denies the physical world.
- **B:** Incorrect: dropping the identity of indiscernibles removes the doctrine that guarantees individuality, which is Leibniz's principal motive against Spinoza.
- **C:** Incorrect: leaving out the dominant monad removes Leibniz's account of what makes an organism one thing rather than a heap.
- **D:** Correct: the three doctrines together secure unique individuals, organic unity and an objective though non-ultimate status for bodies.

Examiner trap 27: The adjective in "well-founded phenomena" is doing the work. Dropping it turns Leibniz into a subjective idealist, which he is not, and forfeits the contrast with both Descartes and Spinoza.

MCQ 28 (remedial). Harmony, influence and assistance

Leibniz distinguishes his own solution to the mind-body question from two rivals. His position is that the correspondence between mental and bodily series is secured by

- A. a continuous divine adjustment of both series at every moment, as occasionalism maintains
- B. a single arrangement made at creation, so that each series unfolds internally and they agree
- C. a direct causal link between the two series, located in a central and unpaired organ of the brain
- D. an identity between the two series, since they are one and the same thing described in two ways

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the "assistance" option, which Leibniz rejects as unworthy of a perfect craftsman who would not need to keep correcting his own work.
- **B:** Correct: harmony is established once, at creation, so that windowless monads unfold internally and yet correspond perfectly, as two perfectly made clocks keep the same time.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is the "influence" option, that is, Descartes' interactionism, which windowlessness rules out in principle.
- **D:** Incorrect: identity of the two series is Spinoza's parallelism, which Leibniz rejects because it sacrifices the plurality of substances.

Examiner trap 28: Describing harmony as continuous divine intervention converts Leibniz into an occasionalist. Naming all three options - influence, assistance, harmony - and rejecting two is what turns an image into an argument.

MCQ 29 (remedial). Two kinds of truth and two kinds of necessity

Which of the following correctly distinguishes Leibniz's two kinds of truth and the modal claim he derives from them?

- A. Truths of reason are contingent and analysable only infinitely, whereas truths of fact are necessary and can be analysed finitely
- B. Both kinds are necessary, and the only difference lies in whether human beings are able to complete the analysis
- C. Truths of reason are necessary with finite analysis; truths of fact are contingent, and their necessity is only hypothetical
- D. Both kinds are contingent, since God could have chosen a world in which the truths of mathematics were different

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses both halves of the distinction, so that mathematics becomes contingent and historical events become necessary.
- **B:** Incorrect: making both kinds necessary is exactly the necessitarian conclusion Leibniz constructs the distinction to avoid.
- **C:** Correct: the opposite of a truth of reason implies a contradiction, while the opposite of a truth of fact remains conceivable and is realised in another possible world.
- **D:** Incorrect: Leibniz holds that truths of reason are governed by the principle of contradiction and hold in every possible world, so no divine choice could alter them.

Examiner trap 29: Absolute necessity and hypothetical necessity are the hinge of the freedom answer. Without that distinction, the complete individual concept makes every act necessary and Leibniz collapses into the necessitarianism he opposes.

MCQ 30 (remedial). What Leibnizian freedom requires

Leibniz's account of human freedom requires which of the following conditions to hold together?

- A. Indifference of the will, absence of divine foreknowledge, and the reality of chance in nature
- B. Spontaneity alone, since any action arising from the agent's own inner nature is by that very fact free
- C. Intelligence and contingency alone, spontaneity being ruled out by the windowlessness of monads
- D. Spontaneity, intelligence and contingency, with reasons inclining the will without necessitating it

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Leibniz rejects indifference explicitly, affirms complete divine foreknowledge, and denies that anything happens without a sufficient reason.
- **B:** Incorrect: spontaneity by itself would make a falling stone free, which is why deliberation for perceived reasons must be added.
- **C:** Incorrect: windowlessness does not remove spontaneity but guarantees it, since nothing external can compel a monad's states.
- **D:** Correct: the three conditions are jointly necessary, and the formula that reasons incline without necessitating (*incliner sans necessiter*) states the kind of determination involved.

Examiner trap 30: Answering the 2018 or 2020 question with spontaneity alone leaves out two thirds of the doctrine. All three conditions must appear, and the necessity distinction must be stated alongside them.

MCQ 31 (remedial). Attribution and provenance in answer-writing

Which of the following attributions is correct?

- A. "The ghost in the machine" is Gilbert Ryle's hostile description of Cartesian dualism, coined in 1949
- B. "The ghost in the machine" is Descartes' own summary of the union of mind and body
- C. "The best of all possible worlds" is Voltaire's doctrine, which Leibniz satirised in his *Theodicy*
- D. "The order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things" is from the *Monadology*

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the phrase is Ryle's coinage in *The Concept of Mind* (1949), and attributing it correctly turns a common error into a mark-earning observation.
- **B:** Incorrect: Descartes never uses the phrase, and it is designed by a hostile critic to make his position sound absurd.
- **C:** Incorrect: the direction of influence is reversed - the doctrine is Leibniz's, and Voltaire's *Candide* of 1759 is the satire of it.
- **D:** Incorrect: the sentence is Spinoza's *Ethics* II, P7, and misplacing it in Leibniz confuses parallelism with pre-established harmony.

Examiner trap 31: Provenance errors are cheap to avoid and expensive to make. Three recur constantly in this topic: Ryle's phrase, Voltaire's satire, and the Letter 50 formula.

MCQ 32 (remedial). What a comparative answer must contain

In answering a question that asks whose account of the mind-body problem is compatible with human freedom, the feature that most distinguishes a high-scoring script is that it

- A. narrates all three systems in sequence, giving each an equal number of lines and no conclusion
- B. announces the criterion of freedom being used, ranks all three against it, and defends the ranking
- C. selects one philosopher at the outset and expounds him at length without discussing the others
- D. lists the standard criticisms of each position and leaves the reader to adjudicate between the three

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: equal narration without adjudication answers the topic rather than the question, and the directive "critically discuss" makes a verdict compulsory.
- **B:** Correct: because compatibility depends entirely on what freedom is taken to require, the criterion must be declared before any ranking can be defended.
- **C:** Incorrect: the question is explicitly comparative, so an exposition of one thinker leaves two thirds of the demand unaddressed.
- **D:** Incorrect: collecting criticisms without ruling between them is exactly the failure the "critically" in the directive is designed to detect.

Examiner trap 32: A comparison without an announced criterion is a list. State the standard, rank against it, defend the ranking, and concede what the winner costs - that sequence is the difference between a describing script and a deciding one.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers; the 2019, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I texts were read directly from the official question papers held in books\philosophy_optional\, and the 2018 and 2020 parts follow the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger because those two Paper I question papers are not present locally. Doctrinal claims are attributed to their Meditation, *Ethics* proposition or *Monadology* section, and interpretive disputes - whether the memory reply defeats the Cartesian Circle, whether "pantheism" or "panentheism" is the better label, whether Leibnizian contingency is more than epistemic - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands are **10 marks - about 150 to 200 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 300 words**, and **20 marks - about 340 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage: fourteen directly owned Rationalism PYQs from 2018 to 2025 - every part the ledger routes to this syllabus item, in every year of the corpus except 2021, which contains no primary-owned part - and six original solved Mains models, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks.

Citation discipline used in every answer. Spinoza is cited by structural reference (*Ethics* I, Def. 7; I, P15; I, P16; I, P18; I, P29; II, P7; II, P13; II, P40 Sch. 2; V, P32 Cor.), because those references are identical in every translation; Descartes is cited by Meditation, and by *Principles* or *Discourse* part where relevant; Leibniz is cited by *Monadology* section or by work. Renderings such as "monads have no windows" are marked as standard renderings rather than presented as literal originals.

2018 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: Is there any place for freedom in Leibniz's philosophy, when he speaks of 'pre-established harmony'? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Is there any place ...? Discuss" - a yes/no thesis is required, followed by exposition and assessment
Core issue	Whether denying causal interaction destroys agency or, on the contrary, secures it
Scope boundary	Ten marks: harmony, the three conditions of freedom, one necessity distinction, one verdict - no full monadology
Ideal thesis	Yes, but only compatibilist freedom: harmony <i>guarantees</i> spontaneity, and contingency survives through possible worlds
Non-negotiables	<i>Monadology</i> Section 7 windowlessness; spontaneity, intelligence and contingency; complete individual concept; hypothetical versus absolute necessity; "incline without necessitating"

Independent model answer

Pre-established harmony denies causal interaction among monads, but it does not reduce agency to external compulsion. Because monads have no windows, as *Monadology* Section 7 is usually rendered, each unfolds its states from its own internal principle of perception and appetite - so the very doctrine that removes outside influence is what **guarantees spontaneity**, the first condition of freedom.

Freedom additionally requires **intelligence** and **contingency**. A rational spirit acts for perceived reasons, not by blind impact. And although every predicate belongs to the individual's complete concept, Leibniz distinguishes certainty from absolute necessity: "Caesar crosses the Rubicon" is certain in the world God actualised, yet its opposite implies no contradiction and is realised in another possible world. God's selection under the Principle of Sufficient Reason makes the series **hypothetically**, not logically, necessary.

The difficulty is real. An act already contained in the complete concept seems unable to be otherwise *in this world*. Leibniz's answer is compatibilist: reasons "incline without necessitating" (*incliner sans necessiter*), and an action is free when it flows intelligently from the agent rather than from coercion.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Harmony leaves a defensible place for responsible self-expression, but not for libertarian alternative possibilities.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2018 Q1(b): the question contains the word "any", so it must be answered directly before it is discussed. A script that expounds pre-established harmony and never says whether freedom survives has answered a different question.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: harmony and spontaneity in three lines; intelligence and contingency in four; the objection and the compatibilist reply in three; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the three conditions -> the strongest objection -> a graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** windowlessness, appetite, complete concept, possible worlds, moral necessity.
- **Evidence:** *Monadology* Section 7; the Rubicon case; *incliner sans necessiter* from the *Theodicy*.
- **Distinction:** hypothetical necessity versus absolute necessity - without it the answer collapses into fatalism.
- **Criticism:** concede that alternatives lie across worlds rather than within this one.

2018 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: What is the reason for the difference in the definitions and classifications of substances made by Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz in spite of the fact that they all belonged to the rationalist school of thought? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"What is the reason ...?" - explanatory , not descriptive; the answer is a mechanism
Core issue	One inherited definition, three degrees of strictness in enforcing it
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the shared definition, the three revisions with their criteria, costs, and a conceptual conclusion
Ideal thesis	Rationalism supplies the deductive ambition but not the substance count; the count is produced by how strictly "needing nothing else" is read
Non-negotiables	The shared definition; <i>Principles</i> I.51; no-shared-attribute and no-finite-substance steps; simplicity; well-founded phenomena; the dialectical sequence

Independent model answer

The difference arises not from abandoning rationalism but from successively tightening what counts as ontologically basic. All three inherit one definition - substance is what exists in itself and is conceived through itself, needing nothing else in order to exist - and they disagree only over how strictly to enforce it.

Descartes begins from clear and distinct **real distinction**. Thought and extension are mutually exclusive principal attributes, so mind and matter are created substances while God is infinite substance. Yet *Principles* I.51 concedes that only God needs nothing whatever; created things need God. "Substance" is therefore used **analogically**, and that concession is the hinge of the whole story.

Spinoza refuses the softening. In *Ethics* I, two substances cannot share an attribute, since nothing would then distinguish them as substances; and a finite substance would require limitation by another of the same nature. Hence exactly one infinite substance, God or Nature, exists, and minds and bodies become modes under Thought and Extension. The gain is unity and the dissolution of interaction; the cost is that finite individuality and alternative possibilities both weaken.

Leibniz rejects both extended Cartesian substance and Spinozist absorption. Extension is divisible and therefore composite, so it cannot be ultimate; true substances are simple centres of perception and appetite - infinitely many monads. The identity of indiscernibles differentiates them and pre-established harmony explains their correspondence without influx, while bodies become well-founded phenomena.

Revision	Criterion enforced	Result	Price
Descartes	real distinction by principal attribute	dualist created substances under God	equivocation, and an unintelligible interaction
Spinoza	absolute independence	one infinite substance	individuality and contingency weaken
Leibniz	simplicity plus internal activity	infinitely many monads	correspondence must be bought from God

Verdict. ANALYSIS: "Substance" is not a discovery but a **criterion**, and the metaphysics you obtain is the criterion you enforce. The sequence is therefore dialectical: Spinoza is the consistent Descartes, and Leibniz is the consistent rejection of extension as an essence. Each revision solves its predecessor's problem and immediately generates a new one, which is why no fourth position is available inside the same vocabulary and why the argument ends only when the vocabulary itself is attacked. The trio demonstrates rationalism's internal development rather than its incoherence.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2018 Q2(a): the examiner asks for a *reason*, so a table of three views is not an answer. The mechanism - one definition, three degrees of strictness - must be visible in the opening paragraph.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: shared definition in three lines; each thinker in a compact paragraph naming his criterion, his result and his cost; a comparative grid; a conceptual verdict.

- **Structure:** common premise -> mechanism of divergence -> comparative costs -> conclusion at the conceptual level.

- **Doctrine:** real distinction; no shared attribute; no finite substance; simplicity; indiscernibles; well-founded phenomena.
- **Evidence:** *Principles* I.51 as the concession Spinoza exploits.
- **Distinction:** analogical versus univocal use of "substance".
- **Criticism:** each revision solves the predecessor's problem and generates its own.

2019 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: How does Descartes prove the existence of things other than himself and God? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he prove ...? Discuss" - reconstruct the argument, then assess it
Core issue	The Meditation VI causal argument, and its dependence on divine veracity
Scope boundary	Ten marks: five steps and one evaluation - no general survey of the <i>Meditations</i>
Ideal thesis	The proof is theological in structure: what secures the world is not the vividness of experience but the impossibility of divine deception
Non-negotiables	Passive faculty; active cause; great natural inclination; no correcting faculty; extension secured more strongly than sensible qualities; the wax excluded

Independent model answer

After the thinking self and the proof of a non-deceiving God, Descartes argues in Meditation VI that material things cause his involuntary sensory ideas.

The argument runs in five steps. Sensory ideas arrive **involuntarily**, so he possesses a **passive faculty** of receiving them. A passive faculty requires an **active cause** containing that reality. The cause is not himself, since the ideas come unbidden. He has a **great natural inclination** to refer them to bodies, and no faculty by which that inclination could be corrected. Therefore, if no bodies existed, a perfect God would be permitting an uncorrectable systematic error - that is, deceiving. □ Material things exist as **extended** realities.

Two limits must be stated. The proof secures **extension and body** far more securely than the literal accuracy of any colour, size or distance; the senses are reliable for what benefits the mind-body union, and reason must correct them. And the wax argument, which showed that bodily identity is judged by intellect, proves nothing about existence.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Descartes proves an external material cause *within his system*, but the result is only as secure as divine veracity - and therefore inherits Arnauld's Circle.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2019 Q1(d): "how" is a demand for a reconstruction. Naming God without the five steps forfeits most of the marks available.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: placement in one line; five numbered steps in six; two limits in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** locate the proof in the arc -> reconstruct -> limit -> evaluate.
- **Doctrine:** passive faculty, active cause, natural inclination, divine veracity.
- **Evidence:** Meditation VI, with Meditation III supplying the non-deceiving God.
- **Distinction:** existence of body versus accuracy of sensible qualities.
- **Criticism:** the theological dependence, and the wax exclusion, both stated explicitly.

2019 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: What do you understand by Spinoza's statement that what is, cannot be other than what it is? Explain.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain" - foreground the derivation ; do not restate the sentence in other words
Core issue	Necessitarianism: modes follow from what substance <i>is</i> , not from a decree
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: derivation, three clarifying distinctions, the ethical consequence, one criticism with a reply
Ideal thesis	Necessity is logical-ontological rather than fatalistic, and it is the premise of Spinoza's ethics rather than its refutation
Non-negotiables	<i>Ethics</i> I, P16; I, P29; I, Def. 7; II, P7; contingency as ignorance of causes; <i>sub specie aeternitatis</i>

Independent model answer

The statement expresses Spinoza's **necessitarianism**. God, or Nature, is the one self-caused substance, and *Ethics* I, P16 holds that infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from the necessity of the divine nature. Modes are not products of choice; they follow from what substance is, as conclusions follow from adequate premises. The derivation is ontological, not a narrative in which God exists first and produces a world afterwards.

Three distinctions clarify the claim. First, God is **free** not because God could have chosen otherwise but because God is determined by nothing external - *Ethics* I, Def. 7. Second, **contingency** is a name for human ignorance of causes; I, P29 denies contingency in nature outright. Third, finite things are determined by **other finite modes** within the single causal order, so the necessity is immanent rather than imposed from outside.

This does not entail passive fatalism. Under Thought an adequate idea understands a cause; under Extension the same order is expressed bodily - II, P7. A person becomes relatively free by replacing inadequate passions with adequate activity and seeing things under the aspect of eternity (*sub specie aeternitatis*).

Critics reply that necessity erases responsibility and novelty. Spinoza answers that blame founded on an uncaused will was confused from the start, and that ethical improvement consists in increasing rational power. He can add that P29 removes contingency from nature rather than from deliberation, so practical reasoning keeps its place inside the necessary order instead of being abolished by it.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The reply preserves self-determination and abandons the ability to do otherwise; that trade is the doctrine, not an accident of it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2019 Q2(c): "explain" is marked on the derivation. The three distinctions in the middle paragraph are what convert a paraphrase into an explanation.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: derivation in five lines; three distinctions in five; the ethical consequence in four; criticism and reply in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** derive -> distinguish -> apply -> object -> rule.
- **Doctrine:** immanent necessity; contingency as ignorance; freedom as self-determination.
- **Evidence:** P16, P29, Definition 7, II P7 - all structural references.
- **Distinction:** necessity is not fatalism, because no external agent compels.
- **Criticism:** responsibility, answered by the redefinition of blame.

2020 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: How does Leibniz's conception of monads bear upon his views on determinism and freedom? Discuss with your own comments.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss with your own comments" - an explicit first-person evaluative paragraph is being marked
Core issue	How windowlessness produces both determination and self-expression
Scope boundary	Ten marks: monadic structure, the two consequences, and a signposted personal verdict
Ideal thesis	Monadology yields coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom
Non-negotiables	Perception and appetition; windowlessness; complete concept; harmony; the three conditions; a first-person paragraph

Independent model answer

Monads are simple, windowless substances whose states arise internally through **perception** and **appetition**. Consequently an agent is never mechanically pushed by other substances; conduct expresses the agent's own **complete individual concept**. This supports **determinism**, since the whole sequence is certain to God and coordinated by pre-established harmony.

Yet Leibniz treats internally sourced rational action as **free**. Freedom combines **spontaneity**, which windowlessness itself guarantees, **intelligence**, since a rational spirit acts for perceived reasons, and **contingency**, because other possible worlds contain alternative individuals and histories. Reasons incline the will without necessitating it in the way a contradiction necessitates a truth.

In my own assessment, the account succeeds in distinguishing coercion from self-expression and preserves responsibility better than Spinoza's strict necessitarianism, because the agent is genuinely the source of what it does. But the actual agent's complete concept is fixed, so the availability of alternatives *in other worlds* may not satisfy a libertarian who demands that *this* agent, now, could do otherwise.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Monadology yields coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2020 Q1(b): "with your own comments" is an instruction, not a courtesy. The paragraph must be signposted in the first person and must contain a judgement, not a summary.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: monadic structure and determination in four lines; the three conditions in four; the personal paragraph in four; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** structure -> determination -> freedom -> personal adjudication.
- **Doctrine:** perception, appetition, complete concept, harmony.
- **Evidence:** *Monadology* Section 7 and the possible-worlds framework of the *Theodicy*.
- **Distinction:** certainty for God versus logical necessity.
- **Criticism:** the libertarian's demand, conceded rather than dismissed.

2020 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: "From the necessity of the divine nature there must follow infinitely many things in infinitely many ways." Explain this statement by Spinoza along with some possible criticisms.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... along with some possible criticisms" - two limbs, both compulsory
Core issue	<i>Ethics</i> I, P16 and the doctrine of immanent causation
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: derivation, four consequences, three criticisms each with a reply
Ideal thesis	P16 buys extraordinary systematic unity at the price of personality, contingency and robust individuality
Non-negotiables	Infinite attributes; immanent versus transitive cause (P18); denial of contingency (P29); acosmism; good and evil as relational

Independent model answer

In *Ethics* I, P16 Spinoza derives the world from the essence of the one infinite substance. God has infinitely many attributes, each expressing eternal and infinite essence; therefore infinitely many modes follow in infinitely many ways. The relation is **immanent causation** - P18 makes God the immanent, not the transitive, cause - so modes are *in* God rather than external products of a transcendent artisan.

Four conclusions follow. God does not deliberate between worlds; divine action is necessary. Nothing is genuinely contingent, since P29 denies contingency and reduces it to ignorance of causes. Thought and Extension express the same order under different attributes. And finite beings possess reality as modes, not as independent substances. Because the causation is immanent, the world is not a product standing outside its maker but the determinate self-expression of what God already is.

Three criticisms follow, each with a reply. First, necessity threatens divine personality and worship: a God without choice resembles an impersonal order. Spinoza accepts the consequence and rejects anthropomorphism, but providence and petition are genuinely lost. Second, Hegel's **acosmism** objection holds that if only substance is real, the finite disappears. Spinoza replies that modes are real as *determinate expressions*, though not self-subsistent. Third, strict derivation seems to make evil and bondage divine necessities. Spinoza answers that good and evil are relational notions tied to human power, not properties of infinite substance - yet suffering still belongs, unredeemed, to the necessary order.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: P16 gives Spinoza unmatched systematic unity at the price of personality, contingency and robust individuality.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2020 Q4(b): the second limb is not optional. Three criticisms *with replies* is the shape that earns the evaluative marks.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: derivation in four lines; four consequences in four; three criticism-reply pairs in nine; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** derive P16 -> list consequences -> object, reply, residual -> rule.
- **Doctrine:** immanent causation, infinite attributes, denial of contingency.
- **Evidence:** P16, P18, P29 - structural references only.
- **Distinction:** immanent versus transitive cause, which is what makes the derivation non-temporal.
- **Criticism:** three distinct costs, each answered and each with a residue named.

2022 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Discuss the concept of substance according to Spinoza. Does his discussion on substance lead to pantheism? Substantiate your view.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Substantiate your view" - you must take a side and defend it with textual grounds
Core issue	Whether monism entails pantheism, and in what precise sense
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the four-step demonstration, attributes and modes, the verdict, and the acosmism defence
Ideal thesis	Yes - qualified pantheism: nothing exists outside God, but God is not exhausted by the visible world
Non-negotiables	No shared attribute; no finite substance; P15 and P18; <i>natura naturans</i> and <i>natura naturata</i> ; panentheism as an alternative label; Hegel's acosmism

Independent model answer

Spinoza defines substance as what is **in itself and conceived through itself**. In *Ethics* I, no two substances can share an attribute, since nothing would then distinguish them as substances; and substance cannot be finite, because limitation requires another of the same nature. Therefore exactly one absolutely infinite substance exists, possessing infinite attributes: **God, or Nature**.

Thought and Extension are the two attributes known to human beings; particular minds and bodies are **modes**. *Ethics* I, P15 states that whatever is, is in God, while P18 calls God the **immanent**, not the transitive, cause. God does not stand outside and create Nature; *natura naturans* names the free active cause and *natura naturata* the order of modes that follows.

My view is that this does lead to pantheism, in a precise sense: all reality is within and expressive of God, and nothing exists independently outside God. It is **not** the crude identification of God with an aggregate of finite objects, because substance possesses infinitely many attributes and is not exhausted by the two we know. ANALYSIS: The **panentheist** reading, on which all things are in God while God exceeds them, therefore qualifies the label without erasing it - and interpreters genuinely dispute which term is better.

Hegel's **acosmism** charge presses from the opposite direction: if only substance is real, the finite becomes unreal. Yet modes possess dependent reality as determinate expressions of substance, and dependence is not nullity.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Spinoza is best described as a philosophically **qualified pantheist**: divine immanence is undeniable, while divine infinity prevents reduction to the visible world alone.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2022 Q2(c): the directive forbids fence-sitting. The words "my view is" must appear, and the position must then be defended against the strongest counter-reading.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the demonstration in five lines; attributes and modes in four; the declared verdict in five; acosmism in three; final ruling in two.

- **Structure:** define -> demonstrate -> declare -> defend -> rule.
- **Doctrine:** attribute, mode, immanent cause, active and produced nature.
- **Evidence:** P15 and P18, with the no-shared-attribute step reconstructed.
- **Distinction:** pantheism, panentheism and acosmism kept apart.
- **Criticism:** the acosmism charge answered by dependent-but-real modal reality.

2022 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: How does Rene Descartes explain the notion of certainty with reference to knowledge of the self? Critically discuss the way it differs from the knowledge of the world.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss" - the assessment must dominate the second half
Core issue	The asymmetry between immediate self-knowledge and mediated world-knowledge
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: how certainty is reached, what the self is known as, how the world is known, and what the asymmetry costs
Ideal thesis	The epistemic priority of self over world survives, but the metaphysical dualism built on it does not follow without further argument
Non-negotiables	Methodic doubt; the <i>Meditations</i> formulation; <i>res cogitans</i> ; the wax; divine veracity; Lichtenberg and Hume; the Circle

Independent model answer

Descartes reaches certainty by methodically suspending every belief vulnerable to sense-error, dreaming or an evil genius. In Meditation II, "I am, I exist" is true whenever thought occurs, because deception itself requires a deceived thinker. Knowledge of the self is therefore **immediate, performative and independent of sensory mediation**.

The self is first known as a **thinking thing** (*res cogitans*): a thing that doubts, understands, affirms, denies, wills, imagines and seems to sense. Every item on that list is a mode of one attribute, thought, so the self is disclosed as a unity rather than as a bundle of separate faculties. The wax case strengthens the priority claim: even if the wax does not exist, the act of judging discloses the judging mind. Hence mind is *notior* - better known - in the strict sense of **more indubitable**.

Knowledge of the world is **mediate**. Sensory ideas represent objects but can mislead; an external world is restored only after God's existence and non-deceptiveness are established in Meditations III and V, through the involuntariness of sensory ideas and an uncorrectable natural inclination. Even then, intellect identifies body's essence as extension while reason corrects sensible appearances.

Critically, the *cogito* proves thinking existence, not automatically an enduring immaterial substance. Lichtenberg's later remark that Descartes was entitled only to "there is thinking", and Hume's bundle critique, both target that slide.

ANALYSIS: Moreover, the world-proof inherits Arnauld's Circle, since the divine guarantee is established by reasoning whose earlier premises are remembered rather than attended.

Verdict. The asymmetry in **certainty** stands, because self-presence survives the hypothesis under which world-presence is doubted; the **metaphysical** dualism built upon it needs the separate argument of Meditation VI.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2022 Q4(b): two limbs, and the second is where "critically" is marked. The criticism must attack the *inference from certainty to substance*, not merely list objections to Descartes generally.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: route to certainty in four lines; the self as *res cogitans* in four; mediated world-knowledge in five; criticism in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** how certainty is reached -> what is known -> how the world differs -> what the difference cannot support.
- **Doctrine:** performative certainty; *res cogitans*; divine veracity; extension as essence.
- **Evidence:** Meditations I, II, III and VI in their proper order.
- **Distinction:** epistemic priority versus metaphysical substantiality.
- **Criticism:** Lichtenberg and Hume on the subject; Arnauld on the bridge.

2023 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: "That thing is said to be free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature, and is determined to action by itself alone." Discuss Spinoza's views on freedom and determinism in the light of the above statement.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss ... in the light of the above statement" - the quotation must be interpreted , then used
Core issue	Freedom opposed to compulsion, not to causation
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the definition, the illusion of free will, God's absolute freedom, human relative freedom, one verdict
Ideal thesis	Freedom is a higher form of determination, not an exception to causation
Non-negotiables	<i>Ethics</i> I, Def. 7; the conscious-stone image; adequate versus inadequate ideas; only God absolutely free; the concession about alternatives

Independent model answer

The quotation is *Ethics* I, Definition 7, and its key word is "alone": freedom is contrasted with **external compulsion**, never with causation.

Spinoza therefore rejects freedom as uncaused choice. Every finite mode is determined within Nature's necessary order, and human beings imagine themselves free because they are **conscious of their desires** but **ignorant of the causes** that determine them - as a thrown stone would, if conscious, believe it chose to fly.

Only **God is absolutely free**, because only God exists and acts from the divine nature alone, without external determination. Human freedom is **relative** and achieved. When inadequate ideas and external affects determine us we are passive and in bondage (*servitus*); when adequate ideas make us the **adequate cause** of our action, we act from our own understood nature. Reason and intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*) therefore convert necessity into self-determination, culminating in the intellectual love of God.

ANALYSIS: The account is coherent but revisionary: it preserves rational agency and emotional liberation while denying alternative possibilities altogether.

Verdict. Spinoza reconciles freedom with determinism by making freedom a **higher form of determination**, not an exception to causation.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2023 Q1(c): the quotation is the whole frame. Opening by interpreting "by itself alone" immediately signals that the definition has been understood rather than copied.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: interpret the quotation in two lines; the illusion in three; God and human freedom in five; concession and verdict in three.

- **Structure:** interpret -> deny free will -> grade freedom -> concede -> rule.
- **Doctrine:** adequate versus partial causation; bondage and action.
- **Evidence:** Definition 7 and the conscious-stone image, both Spinoza's own.
- **Distinction:** compulsion versus causation - the single most important line in the answer.
- **Criticism:** alternatives never return, stated as a concession rather than concealed.

2023 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Discuss Descartes' theory of innate ideas and the grounds on which Locke refutes it.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Discuss ... and the grounds" - two limbs, and both must be given at full strength
Core issue	Whether Locke refutes the strongest Cartesian version or only the caricature
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the threefold classification, the argument from insufficiency, dispositional innateness, Locke's tests, adjudication
Ideal thesis	Locke defeats occurrent innatism decisively and dispositional innatism far less clearly
Non-negotiables	Adventitious, factitious, innate; objective reality of the idea of God; dispositional innateness; universal assent; transparency of mental content; sensation and reflection

Independent model answer

Descartes distinguishes **adventitious** ideas that seem to arrive from outside, **factitious** ideas voluntarily constructed, and **innate** ideas native to the mind's rational nature. Innate ideas are not necessarily explicit propositions present in an infant's consciousness; they are native capacities or contents, including God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical principles. In Meditation III the idea of an infinite perfect being grounds the causal or trademark argument, precisely because a finite mind cannot be its adequate total cause.

Locke attacks innate principles in the *Essay concerning Human Understanding*, Book I, on two principal grounds.

Universal assent is absent: children and persons without the relevant concepts do not affirm the alleged principles. And saying that principles are "in the mind" but unknown **empties innateness of meaning**, because by that standard every knowable truth would already be innate. He offers instead a mind that is white paper, furnished by **sensation and reflection**.

Descartes can reply that innateness means a **dispositional** power, not constant awareness; geometrical knowledge is elicited rather than copied from sensation, and no accumulation of measured figures yields necessity. **ANALYSIS:** Locke's argument therefore defeats **occurrent** innatism decisively, but defeats **dispositional** innatism far less clearly. The empiricist, in turn, must still explain necessity and universality without merely reporting repeated experience.

Verdict. Locke narrows the defensible Cartesian claim from preformed conscious truths to native cognitive structures; he refutes the caricature more securely than the strongest version, and the residual burden - a criterion distinguishing an innate disposition from a bare capacity to learn - falls on Descartes.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2023 Q2(c): both theories must be given at their strongest. A weak Descartes makes Locke's victory worthless and forfeits the adjudication marks.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: classification and the argument from insufficiency in five lines; Locke's two tests in five; the dispositional reply in four; verdict in three.

- **Structure:** classify -> argue -> object -> reply -> adjudicate.
- **Doctrine:** objective reality of ideas; dispositional innateness; sensation and reflection.
- **Evidence:** Meditation III; *Essay* Book I.
- **Distinction:** occurrent versus dispositional innatism - the hinge of the whole answer.
- **Criticism:** the residual burden is named and assigned, rather than left open.

2024 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: How does Spinoza establish that God alone is absolutely real with his statement - "Whatever is, is in God"? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss" - evaluation must dominate the closing half
Core issue	How P15 is <i>established</i> , and what "in" means
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the substance argument, the meaning of "in", P18, then three objections with replies
Ideal thesis	God alone is <i>absolutely</i> real; finite things are real <i>relationally</i> , which is monism without world-denial
Non-negotiables	The no-shared-attribute step; absolutely infinite substance; ontological not spatial "in"; P18 immanent cause; individuality, change, personality

Independent model answer

Spinoza's conclusion follows from his substance argument. Substance is what is in itself and is conceived through itself; no two substances can share an attribute; and an absolutely infinite substance must possess every attribute. Therefore God alone is substance, and *Ethics* I, P15 concludes that everything else exists **in** God as a mode.

"In God" is **ontological, not spatial**. A mind is a mode under the attribute of Thought and a body a mode under Extension; neither can be conceived independently of substance. The preposition therefore records dependence in conception as strictly as dependence in existence. P18 adds that God is the **immanent** cause of things - the cause remains in the effect rather than producing something outside itself. God is therefore absolutely real because divine existence and conception depend on nothing else, while finite reality is derivative.

The view avoids a creator-world dualism and explains parallelism elegantly. Yet it faces three objections. The **individuality** of modes appears weakened, since a mode is not conceivable apart from substance. **Modal change** is hard to reconcile with an eternal, immutable substance. And a **personal, providential** God disappears entirely.

ANALYSIS: Spinoza can reply that independent reality is not the only kind of reality; that temporal order belongs to the causal series of finite modes rather than to substance; and that personality would anthropomorphise infinity. Each reply is defensible, and each leaves a residue.

Verdict. God alone is absolutely real, but finite things are not nothing: they are real **relational expressions**. This makes Spinoza a monist and a qualified pantheist without committing him to simple world-denial.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2024 Q2(b): the question says "how does he establish". The demonstration must precede the interpretation, and the interpretation must fix the meaning of the preposition.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the argument in four lines; the meaning of "in" and P18 in five; three objections in four; replies and verdict in five.

- **Structure:** establish -> interpret -> object -> reply -> rule.
- **Doctrine:** absolutely infinite substance; mode; immanent causation.
- **Evidence:** P15 and P18, reached by reconstruction rather than assertion.
- **Distinction:** absolute reality versus modal, relational reality.
- **Criticism:** individuality, change and personality, each answered and each leaving a residue.

2024 · Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Among the rationalists, whose account of mind-body problem is compatible with the notion of human freedom and free will? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A comparative ranking with a defended winner; neutrality is a failure condition
Core issue	Compatibility depends entirely on the criterion of freedom adopted
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: all three accounts, an announced criterion, a defended ranking, and the winner's cost
Ideal thesis	Leibniz, on a compatibilist criterion - Descartes wins on a libertarian criterion but at an unpayable price
Non-negotiables	Interaction and Elisabeth's objection; <i>Ethics</i> II, P7 and necessitarianism; windowlessness and harmony; the three conditions; explicit criterion

Independent model answer

Compatibility depends on the criterion of freedom, so the criterion must be declared first.

Descartes' interactionism separates unextended mind from a mechanically determined body, permitting a libertarian will that can affirm, deny or withhold assent. But Princess Elisabeth's objection of 1643 remains unanswered: no intelligible account explains causal commerce between substances sharing no property, and the pineal gland supplies only a location. Descartes' own reply - that the union is a primitive notion - preserves the phenomenon and abandons the mechanism.

Spinoza dissolves interaction by making mind and body the same mode under Thought and Extension (*Ethics* II, P7). This is metaphysically economical, but it entails necessitarianism: freedom becomes adequate self-determination, and free will as alternative choice is expressly denied. It also abandons ordinary mental causation, since no idea moves a limb, so the economy is bought by revising the very experience the question begins from.

Leibniz denies interaction because windowless monads unfold internally, and pre-established harmony coordinates the mental and bodily series. Rational action remains **spontaneous, intelligent and contingent**, because the actual world is one possible world chosen by God, so truths about action are certain but not absolutely necessary.

ANALYSIS: If "free will" means the ability to do otherwise, Descartes wins - with an unintelligible causal theory. If it means responsible agency compatible with systematic determination, **Leibniz** offers the strongest account. Spinoza offers the deepest self-mastery but openly rejects free will.

Verdict. Leibniz is the best-qualified answer, because his mind-body theory preserves internal agency and moral responsibility without Cartesian interaction - though it remains compatibilist rather than libertarian, and buys correspondence from God in advance.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2024 Q3(c): the fatal error is describing all three neutrally. Announce the criterion in the first line, rank explicitly, and defend the ranking.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: criterion in one line; three accounts in twelve; the ranking in four; verdict with its cost in three.

- **Structure:** declare the criterion -> run all three -> rank -> defend -> concede the price.
- **Doctrine:** interaction, parallelism, harmony; the three conditions of Leibnizian freedom.
- **Evidence:** Elisabeth's 1643 objection; *Ethics* II, P7; *Monadology* Section 7.
- **Distinction:** libertarian versus compatibilist criteria, stated before any ranking.
- **Criticism:** the winner's cost is named, which is what makes the ruling look considered.

2025 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: What are the basic tenets of Rationalism? How does Descartes build a system of Philosophy in consonance with them? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two limbs, the second much larger; "discuss" requires assessment as well as exposition
Core issue	Mapping each tenet onto a stage of Descartes' system, not describing them separately
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: five tenets, seven stages, then a load-bearing critique
Ideal thesis	Descartes does not merely assert the tenets; he constructs a system that embodies them as its operating logic
Non-negotiables	The five tenets; four rules and hyperbolic doubt; the <i>cogito</i> ; innate ideas; the three proofs; divine veracity; substance metaphysics; will and intellect; the Circle

Independent model answer

Rationalism holds that reason can yield **necessary and universal** knowledge through innate or self-evident principles, deduction and an intelligible structure of reality. Its tenets are: innate cognitive resources; reason as the ground of necessity; intuition and deduction as method; the intelligibility of the real; and a metaphysics of substance, attribute and mode. Experience may occasion thought, but it cannot alone provide the certainty that mathematics models.

Descartes embodies these tenets as a system, stage by stage.

1. **Method over authority.** The four rules of the *Discourse*, Part II, and hyperbolic doubt reject inherited opinion and demand evident beginnings.
2. **A self-evident foundation.** The *cogito* is grasped by intellectual intuition and survives the evil genius; it is not inferred from sensory evidence.
3. **Innate content.** Ideas of God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical truths are native to rational cognition, elicited rather than copied from sensation.
4. **Deductive reconstruction.** From the thinking self Descartes argues to a perfect God by the trademark, conservation and ontological routes.
5. **Intelligibility and truth.** A non-deceiving God underwrites clear and distinct perception, restoring mathematics and, through involuntary sensory ideas and an uncorrectable natural inclination, the external world.
6. **Substance metaphysics.** Reality is ordered into infinite God and the created principal attributes of thought and extension.
7. **Mechanistic nature and rational freedom.** Extended nature is mathematically governed, while the infinite will can withhold assent; error occurs when it outruns the finite intellect.

The system is rationalist not merely because it praises reason but because **each stage seeks necessity independent of sensory contingency**. The wax argument even makes intellect, rather than sense, the judge of bodily identity.

ANALYSIS: Its vulnerabilities are equally systematic. The *cogito* may prove only occurring thought, not a Cartesian substance. The trademark and ontological arguments are disputed. Arnauld's Circle suggests that the divine guarantee presupposes the criterion it secures. Locke attacks innate principles, and Kant later denies that existence is a real predicate.

Verdict. Descartes constructs the paradigm rationalist system - foundational, innate, deductive and substance-based - but its success beyond the *cogito* depends on theological premises less indubitable than its own method demands.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2025 Q2(a): the first limb is the smaller one. Spending half the answer on the tenets and rushing the system inverts the marks.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: tenets in four lines; seven numbered stages in fourteen; the unifying observation in three; four vulnerabilities in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** define the school -> map every tenet onto a stage -> identify the unifying logic -> evaluate the load-bearing weaknesses.

- **Doctrine:** all five tenets instantiated, in order, with named Cartesian material at each stage.
- **Evidence:** *Discourse II*; *Meditations I-VI*; *Principles I.51*.
- **Distinction:** praising reason versus constructing a system whose operating logic *is* reason.
- **Criticism:** four independent lines of attack, each aimed at a named stage.

2025 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: "All determination is negation." Comment with reference to Spinoza.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Comment" - short, pointed, thesis-first ; not a general essay on Spinoza
Core issue	What the formula means <i>inside</i> Spinoza's monism, and where it actually comes from
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: provenance, meaning, one consequence each for God, modes and knowledge, then a judgement
Ideal thesis	The dictum illuminates dependence but becomes reductive if limitation is mistaken for unreality
Non-negotiables	Letter 50 provenance and Hegel's universalisation; infinite substance as pure affirmation; modes limited by modes; <i>sub specie aeternitatis</i> ; the acosmism exchange

Independent model answer

The formula is associated with Spinoza's **Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles of 2 June 1674** - "determination is negation" - and was universalised into the Latin slogan by Hegel, which is how it entered the textbook tradition. **ANALYSIS:** It is not a sentence of the *Ethics*, and saying so is itself part of a correct comment.

Its meaning is this. To determine a finite thing is to bound it as *this* rather than *that*; every limit excludes alternatives. Finitude therefore contains negation.

In Spinoza's metaphysics three consequences follow. **For God:** substance is absolutely infinite and determined by nothing external, so God involves no negation whatever and is pure positive self-expression through infinite attributes. **For finite modes:** each is limited by other modes of the same nature - a body occupies this region and excludes others, a particular idea expresses only a bounded causal perspective - so their determination marks dependence and limitation. **For knowledge and freedom:** inadequate knowledge treats a finite thing in isolation, whereas adequate knowledge understands it through the affirmative whole of Nature, and the free person sees limitation and necessity under the aspect of eternity (*sub specie aeternitatis*) rather than imagining an independent will.

Hegel's criticism is that Spinoza's infinite may swallow all finite determination, turning the world into negation - the **acosmism** charge. **ANALYSIS:** Spinoza can answer that what is negated is *independent self-subsistence*, not every form of reality: modes positively express divine power in determinate ways.

Verdict. The dictum illuminates why finite beings are dependent, but it becomes reductive if limitation is mistaken for unreality. Spinoza needs **both** the negation of independence and the affirmation of modal expression.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2025 Q2(b): "comment" is a demand for a pointed thesis, not an essay. The provenance line earns a mark on its own and should open the answer.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: provenance in three lines; meaning in two; three consequences in eight; the acosmism exchange in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** correct the provenance -> state the meaning -> three consequences -> adjudicate the objection.
- **Doctrine:** infinite substance as pure affirmation; mutual limitation of finite modes.
- **Evidence:** Letter 50; the Hegelian reception; *sub specie aeternitatis*.
- **Distinction:** negation of independence versus negation of reality.
- **Criticism:** acosmism raised at full strength and answered without evasion.

Six original questions in the examined format - two at 10 marks, two at 15 and two at 20 - with complete model solutions. These are practice questions written for this package; they are not previous-year questions and are not official keys.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why the wax argument remains necessary to Descartes' rationalist project even after the *cogito* has been established. Discuss.

Independent model answer

The *cogito* establishes only that thinking existence is indubitable whenever thought occurs. The wax argument of Meditation II extends the result by showing **how bodily identity is cognised at all**.

A fresh piece of wax loses taste, scent, shape, hardness and sound near the fire, yet is judged without hesitation to be the same wax. Neither a fixed sensory catalogue nor imagination - which cannot run through the indefinitely many shapes that "flexible and changeable" (*flexibile et mutabile*) requires - explains that judgement. Only mental scrutiny (*inspectio mentis*) does.

The case therefore supports two rationalist claims. First, the **intellect contributes** the concept of an extended, flexible, changeable thing. Second, every judgement about the wax more certainly reveals the **judging mind**, even if the object should not exist. The "hats and coats" example makes the same point about ordinary seeing, which is in fact judging.

ANALYSIS: Two limits must be conceded. The argument presupposes extension as body's essence, and an empiricist may call that essence an abstraction. It proves intellectual structuring more clearly than innate knowledge.

Verdict. The wax converts the *cogito* from a bare existential certainty into an **epistemological priority claim**: mind is the condition under which body can be known at all.

Why this earns marks

- Answers "why necessary" directly rather than retelling the example.
- Reconstructs the argument, including the elimination of imagination.
- Names a second Cartesian example in one line.
- States a precise limitation instead of closing with praise.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Spinoza's God does no explanatory work outside the system." Examine this claim by comparing the role of God in Descartes and Spinoza.

Independent model answer

For **Descartes**, God is a **bridge**. The *cogito* yields one certainty; divine veracity converts a rule read off that single case into a general licence to trust clear and distinct perception, and then licenses belief in an external world. Remove God and the system contracts to isolated intuitions.

For **Spinoza**, God is not an added cause but the **system itself**. God, or Nature, is the one substance; Thought and Extension are its attributes; minds and bodies are its modes. *Ethics* I, P18 makes God the immanent, not the transitive, cause, so nothing is produced outside God and nothing needs to be certified from outside.

The claim is therefore largely correct. Descartes' God performs an **external epistemic function** and can fail - exactly what Arnauld's Circle alleges. Spinoza's God performs no such function, because no gap between knower and known requires bridging: the order of ideas simply *is* the order of things (*Ethics* II, P7).

ANALYSIS: One qualification is needed. Spinoza's God does other work: it grounds the necessity and intelligibility of everything that follows.

Verdict. Descartes' God is a **guarantor** and can be attacked; Spinoza's God is a **structure** and can only be rejected wholesale.

Why this earns marks

- Uses a single comparative axis - the explanatory role of God - rather than describing two theologies.
- Cites P18 and II, P7 structurally.
- Concedes a qualification instead of over-claiming.
- Ends with a distinction that could be reused in any comparative question.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Is Spinoza's freedom merely determinism under a more attractive name? Critically examine.

Independent model answer

Spinoza is a strict **necessitarian**: *Ethics* I, P29 denies contingency in nature, and every finite mode is causally determined by other finite modes. If freedom requires the ability to do otherwise under identical conditions, his theory is indeed determinism renamed, and he would not dispute the description.

Yet *Ethics* I, Definition 7 distinguishes **external** determination from action flowing from one's own nature. Human bondage (*servitus*) consists in inadequate ideas and passive affects produced by partial causal understanding; through common notions, reason and intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*), a person becomes the **adequate cause** of what follows from their own ideas. The conscious-stone analogy attacks ignorance of causes, not agency as such.

This is more than rhetorical relabelling for three reasons. The distinction between being an adequate and a partial cause is a real difference in the causal structure of an event. Understanding an affect changes one's relation to it and increases the power of acting, so the doctrine has practical consequences. And *Ethics* III, P6-P7 make striving (*conatus*) the actual essence of a thing, so acting from one's nature is not a fiction but the exercise of what one is.

ANALYSIS: Two concessions are unavoidable. Every achievement of understanding is itself necessitated, so nobody could have failed to become free who does. And alternative possibilities never return at any stage.

Verdict. Spinoza offers a substantive **compatibilist ideal of self-mastery**, not free will in the libertarian sense. Whether that counts as freedom depends on whether freedom is defined by **authorship** or by **alternatives** - and the disagreement is best left openly at that point rather than disguised.

Why this earns marks

- States both criteria of freedom before ruling.
- Gives three independent reasons why the position is substantive.
- Uses *conatus* only as far as it supports the argument.
- Concedes precisely, and locates the residual disagreement in a definition.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Examine the claim that Descartes' interaction problem is not a defect of his system but a direct consequence of his own criterion of truth.

Independent model answer

The claim is substantially correct, and stating why is the whole answer.

Descartes' criterion is that whatever is perceived **clearly and distinctly** is true. Applied to mind and body, it yields the real distinction of Meditation VI: I conceive myself clearly as a thinking, unextended thing, and body clearly as an extended, unthinking thing; whatever can be clearly conceived apart, God can create apart; therefore they are really distinct substances.

But the same criterion fixes their essences as **mutually exclusive**. Thought is defined so as to exclude extension, and extension so as to exclude thought. Causal influence, however, appears to require some community between cause and effect. The two substances share nothing whatever, so there is no property through which influence could pass. ANALYSIS: The interaction problem is therefore not an oversight but the **direct consequence** of the very clarity that produced the dualism.

Descartes' responses confirm the diagnosis. The pineal gland supplies a **location**, not a mechanism. His considered reply to Princess Elisabeth in 1643 - that the mind-body union is a **third primitive notion**, known through ordinary living rather than pure intellect - concedes that the union cannot be conceived by the faculty that established the distinction.

One qualification is fair. Descartes never claimed that everything real must be transparent to pure intellect; the union is presented as a datum of experience rather than a deduction.

Verdict. The problem is generated by the system's own success. Clarity buys the distinction and pays for it with unintelligibility - which is why Spinoza and Leibniz do not repair Cartesian interaction but **replace** the premise that produced it.

Why this earns marks

- Converts a familiar objection into an internal diagnosis.
- Traces the problem to the criterion rather than to an isolated mistake.
- Uses Elisabeth's objection and the primitive-notion reply as evidence, not decoration.
- Concedes a fair qualification and still delivers a ruling.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "The history of rationalist substance is a movement from dualism through monism to pluralism." Analyse the logic and the cost of this movement.

Independent model answer

The sequence three, one, infinitely many captures a real dialectic, but its logic lies in **changing criteria** rather than in a preference for numbers. All three thinkers seek self-explanatory reality accessible to reason; they differ over what makes something ontologically basic.

Descartes uses principal attributes and real distinction. God is infinite substance; mind and body are created substances whose essences are thought and extension. The gain is a clear basis both for a mathematical physics and for personal consciousness. The cost is a definitional equivocation, conceded in *Principles* I.51, and an interaction problem that his own criterion generates.

Spinoza applies independence consistently. If substance is conceived through itself, dependent created substances cannot qualify; and substances sharing an attribute cannot be distinguished. God, or Nature, alone remains, while minds and bodies become modes under Thought and Extension. The gain is unity and the dissolution of interaction, since the order of ideas is the order of things. The cost is necessitarianism and the threat of acosmism.

Leibniz accepts that extended composites are not ultimate but refuses to sacrifice individuals. Simplicity, perception and appetite define infinitely many monads; the identity of indiscernibles guarantees their uniqueness. The gain is active plurality and internal agency. The cost is that bodies become well-founded phenomena and that correspondence requires pre-established harmony and a divine selector.

Movement	Problem solved	New problem generated
Descartes -> Spinoza	dependence and interaction between created substances	finite individuality and contingency weaken
Spinoza -> Leibniz	restores genuine individual centres of activity	harmony and complete concepts strain explanation

ANALYSIS: The movement is therefore neither linear progress nor arbitrary disagreement. Each successor enforces one rationalist demand more strictly and pays elsewhere, because coherence, individuality and experiential plausibility cannot all be maximised at once.

Verdict. Rationalist substance evolves through **internal criticism**, and the lesson is conceptual rather than historical: the definition of the basic unit already contains a theory of causation, of individuality and of freedom, so choosing a criterion of substance is choosing a metaphysics. That is also why the movement terminates only when Locke and Hume attack the innate resources which made the vocabulary of substance available in the first place.

Why this earns marks

- Analyses a movement rather than describing three positions.

- Attaches a named gain and a named cost to each stage.
- Uses a compact grid to make the dialectic visible.
- Concludes at the conceptual level, which is what "analyse" demands.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the roles assigned to God in the systems of Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz, and assess which system depends on God most heavily. Critically discuss.

Independent model answer

The three systems assign God three different jobs, and the depth of dependence is not the same in each.

Descartes: God guarantees. The *cogito* yields one certainty. Divine veracity, established by the trademark and conservation proofs of Meditation III and the ontological proof of Meditation V, converts a criterion read off that single case into a general licence, and then underwrites memory, extended reasoning and the inference from involuntary sensory ideas to an external world.

Spinoza: God is the system. God, or Nature, is the one absolutely infinite substance; Thought and Extension are attributes expressing its whole essence; minds and bodies are modes. *Ethics* I, P15 makes everything exist in God, and P18 makes God the immanent, not the transitive, cause. Nothing is produced outside God, so nothing needs to be certified from outside.

Leibniz: God selects and harmonises. The Principle of Sufficient Reason demands a necessary being outside the contingent series; God surveys infinitely many compossible worlds and actualises the most perfect - the greatest variety under the simplest laws - and arranges all monads at creation so that their internally unfolding states correspond.

ANALYSIS: The assessment. Dependence must be measured by what collapses if the divine premise fails. Remove Descartes' God and the system contracts to the momentary *cogito*: mathematics, memory and the world all go. Remove Leibniz's God and there is no reason why *this* compossible set is actual and no source of the harmony, so the correspondence between mind and body becomes a brute coincidence. Remove Spinoza's God and there is no system left to have lost anything - but that is because God is not a premise within the system, it is the system.

The paradox is instructive. Spinoza's God is the most **pervasive** and the least **vulnerable**, because it is not inferred from a concept of perfection; this is why Kant's objection that existence is not a real predicate bears directly on Descartes and Leibniz and leaves Spinoza largely untouched.

Verdict. Judged by fragility, **Descartes** depends on God most heavily, since a single contested proof carries his entire epistemology; judged by pervasiveness, Spinoza does, since God is not a support but the substance of everything asserted. Naming which sense of "depends" is in use is what turns this comparison into an argument.

Why this earns marks

- Uses one matched axis - the job God performs - across all three systems.
- Applies a genuine test: what collapses if the divine premise is removed.
- Distinguishes two senses of "depends" and rules on both.
- Adds Kant only as a one-line rider, respecting the ownership boundary.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Prerequisite check before using this block

Nothing below is needed to write a complete answer to any of the fourteen routed questions. Use it only after the twelve Basic sessions, the thirty-two diagnostics and the solved practice are secure, and then only as a single evaluative rider inside a fifteen- or twenty-mark answer. Every item here is a **live scholarly dispute** and is marked CAUTION: accordingly; presenting any of these readings as settled doctrine would be a mistake in the opposite direction from omitting them.

A1. The Cartesian-circle literature CAUTION:

- **The issue:** does Descartes need divine veracity *before* he may trust clear and distinct perception at all, or only to secure it across memory and extended reasoning?
- **Competing readings:** the vicious-circle reading in Arnauld's line; the **memory-guarantee** reading, on which God certifies only perceptions no longer attended to; and a stronger anti-circle reading on which the *cogito* and certain simple intuitions are self-certifying while being attended to.
- **The further objection and the counter-reply:** even the proofs of God appear to rely on premises whose reliability is in question. The counter-reply is that present clear intuition compels assent immediately, while God guarantees its lasting trustworthiness once it is no longer before the mind.
- **Safe use ANALYSIS::** one evaluative line after the standard presentation of method and God. It sharpens the evaluation; it must not replace the rebuilding sequence.
- **Do not over-study:** the full apparatus of the Objections and Replies is not marks-essential here.

A2. Spinoza's attributes problem CAUTION:

- **The issue:** if substance has infinitely many attributes but human beings know only Thought and Extension, what exactly *is* an attribute, and how is our knowledge of it limited?
- **Competing readings:** the **epistemic-limitation** reading, on which we grasp two of infinitely many genuinely real attributes; the **expressive** reading, on which attributes are distinct ways in which one substance is intelligible; and a stricter conceptual reading that resists treating attributes as quasi-parts of God.
- **The further objection and the counter-reply:** unknown infinite attributes can look ornamental, since the working system runs on two. The counter-reply is that their infinity blocks anthropomorphic reduction and secures the claim that substance is absolutely self-caused and not exhausted by human cognition.
- **Safe use ANALYSIS::** one line in a Spinoza substance or God answer, to show why Thought and Extension are not Cartesian substances in disguise.

A3. Leibniz on contingency by infinite analysis CAUTION:

- **The issue:** if the complete individual concept contains all of a subject's predicates, how can contingent truth and freedom survive?
- **Competing readings:** the **compatibilist** reading, on which truths are certain for God yet contingent because their opposite is possible in another world; a **near-necessitarian** reading; and a modal reading that ties contingency to God's free choice of the best world.
- **The technical device:** necessary truths terminate in identities through a **finite** analysis; contingent truths require an **infinite** analysis that only God completes. This lets Leibniz say that a contingent predicate is contained in a complete concept without being logically necessary.
- **The residual difficulty:** contingency can look **merely epistemic** from the creature's standpoint - real for God's infinite analysis, unavailable to the agent.
- **Safe use ANALYSIS::** an evaluative rider in a freedom or determinism answer, after pre-established harmony has already been explained clearly.

A4. Pantheism, panentheism and the labelling dispute CAUTION:

- **The issue:** is "pantheist" or "panentheist" the more accurate description of Spinoza's God?
- **The case for pantheism:** nothing exists outside God; all things are modes within one immanent substance; *Deus sive Natura* identifies the two terms.
- **The case for panentheism:** substance possesses infinitely many attributes and is not exhausted by the two humans know, so God exceeds the finite modes even while containing them.
- **The third position:** Hegel's **acosmism** charge, which is not a label for Spinoza's theism at all but an accusation that the finite world disappears.
- **Safe use ANALYSIS::** in the 2022 answer, declare the qualified-pantheist verdict and note the panentheist alternative in one clause. Do not spend a paragraph on nomenclature.

A5. The analogical predication of "substance" in Descartes CAUTION:

- **The issue:** is Descartes' use of "substance" for God and for created things an equivocation that undermines the system, or a controlled analogy?
- **The charitable reading:** the *Principles* I.51 distinction is deliberate. "Substance" applies absolutely to God and relatively to created things, in the way scholastic analogical predication permits.
- **The hostile reading:** the definition is then doing no work, since anything that depends on only one thing may be called independent.
- **Why it matters:** the answer determines whether Spinoza is Descartes' **corrector** or his **opponent**, which changes the tone of every 2018-style answer.
- **Safe use ANALYSIS::** one sentence, and only in a twenty-mark substance question.

A6. Is pre-established harmony unfalsifiable? CAUTION:

- **The issue:** harmony explains any observed correspondence equally well, so critics argue it is not an explanation at all.
- **Leibniz's defence:** it is the only account that avoids both unintelligible cross-substance causation and the collapse of plurality into one substance, and unlike occasionalism it requires no continuous miracle.
- **The residual:** the defence is comparative, not positive - it shows harmony is preferable to two rivals, not that it is independently confirmable.
- **Safe use ANALYSIS::** as the residual column of the criticism ledger, never as the main criticism.

Conceptual links - not current-affairs items

Static early-modern philosophy does not require a manufactured contemporary anchor, and none has been forced here. The genuine conceptual links, usable as a closing sentence when a question invites breadth, are: the substance question running forward into Locke, Hume and Kant; the mind-body problem as the ancestor of contemporary debates about mental causation; and the identity of indiscernibles as a live principle in later logic and metaphysics. Each belongs to a **later owner** and should be named in a clause, not developed.

Source trail for this block

Descartes, *Meditations* and the Fourth Objections and Replies; *Principles of Philosophy* I.51; the 1643 correspondence with Princess Elisabeth of Bohemia. Spinoza, *Ethics* I-II and V; Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles. Leibniz, *Discourse on Metaphysics*, *Monadology*, *Theodicy* and the Leibniz-Clarke correspondence. The interpretive positions summarised above follow the repository's advanced Western Philosophy dossier, which names Arnauld, Curley, Della Rocca, Adams and Jolley as the standard modern discussants.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Compressed revision notes for the complete topic, arranged by examinable structure rather than by a fixed template. Read these last, and read them fast. Parts A to L cover every Basic session; the optional advanced material is deliberately excluded, because none of it is required for a core answer.

A. Rationalist operating logic - the five tenets

- **Warrant, not hostility to the senses.** Experience may occasion thought; only intellect certifies necessity and universality.
- Five tenets: **innate cognitive resources** (dispositional, not preformed propositions) · **reason grounds necessity** · **intuition and deduction** (Descartes intuition and order; Spinoza geometrical demonstration; Leibniz identities and sufficient reasons) · **the real is the rational** · **substance metaphysics**.
- One inherited definition: substance = **in itself, conceived through itself, needing nothing else**.
- The dial: **loose** -> 3 · **strict** -> 1 · **strict plus simplicity** -> ∞.
- Memory chain: **attribute separates** -> **independence unifies** -> **simplicity multiplies**.

- Whole-topic line: *method shared; substance criterion diverges; God, mind-body and freedom follow the substance choice.*

B. Cartesian demolition and reconstruction spine

four rules -> methodic doubt -> cogito -> clear and distinct rule ->
God -> divine veracity -> mathematics + external world -> dualism

- Four rules (*Discourse II*): evidence · analysis · order · complete enumeration. Rule 1 does the damage.
- Doubt in three cumulative stages: **sense-deception** -> **dream argument** -> **evil genius** (*genius malignus*).
- *Meditations* wording: "**I am, I exist, is necessarily true whenever it is put forward by me or conceived in my mind.**" The Latin tag *cogito, ergo sum* is from the *Discourse* and *Principles* I.7.
- Status: **immediate intuition**, performative, present-tense; **not** a syllogism.
- Limit: thinking existence, **not** enduring substance or diachronic identity. Lichtenberg and Hume attack exactly here.
- The **Archimedean point**: one fixed place from which everything else is moved.

C. Ideas, innateness and the Locke exchange

- Three kinds: **adventitious** (involuntary, seemingly from outside) · **factitious** (voluntarily constructed) · **innate** (native to rational nature).
- Criterion of truth: **clear** = present to an attentive mind; **distinct** = containing nothing unclear. Derived from the *cogito*, not assumed.
- Argument from insufficiency: **infinity** · **substance** · **mathematical necessity** cannot be copied from finite sensation. Objective reality of an idea needs a cause with adequate formal reality.
- Innateness is **dispositional** - seeds of knowledge; a constitution, not a content.
- Locke, *Essay I*: (i) no **universal assent**; (ii) nothing unknown can be **in the mind**; (iii) **sensation and reflection** suffice.
- Adjudication: occurrent innatism **falls**; dispositional innatism **stands but owes a criterion** distinguishing it from a bare capacity to learn.

D. The wax argument and certain knowledge

- Catalogue destroyed by fire: taste · scent · colour · shape · size · hardness · coldness · sound.
- Same wax still judged to remain => not any sensible item; not **imagination**, since the possible shapes are indefinite - *flexibile et mutabile*.
- □ grasped by **mental scrutiny** (*inspectio mentis*) as an **extended, flexible, changeable** thing.
- Paired case: "**hats and coats**" - what passes for seeing is judging.
- Result: bodies known by understanding; **mind is notior**, *in the strict sense of* more indubitable*.
- Presuppositions: bearer metaphysics (P1) · sense exhausted by the catalogue (P2) · imagination image-bound (P3) · perception self-intimating (P4).
- WRONG: The wax **does not prove that bodies exist**.

E. God in Descartes - three proofs, one objection, one world

Proof	Meditation	Move
Trademark / causal	III	objective reality of the idea of the infinite needs an adequate formal cause
Conservation	III	I cannot sustain myself from moment to moment
Ontological	V	existence belongs to the concept of a supremely perfect being

- Divine veracity => **general reliability** of clear and distinct perception.
- **Cartesian Circle** (Arnauld, Fourth Objections): criterion proves God; God certifies criterion. **Reply**: attended intuition compels; God secures **memory** and **long chains**. **Residual**: the proofs themselves use remembered premises.

- External world (Meditation VI): involuntary ideas -> **passive faculty** -> needs an **active cause** -> **great natural inclination** to bodies -> **no correcting faculty** -> a non-deceiver could not permit it -> **bodies exist, as extended**.
- Secured: body and extension. **Not** secured: exact colours, sizes and distances.
- Verdict line: *the Meditations stand or fall on Meditation III, not Meditation II.*

F. Substance - one criterion, three enforcements

	Descartes	Spinoza	Leibniz
Count	3: God + mind + matter	1: God, or Nature	∞ monads
Criterion enforced	real distinction by principal attribute	absolute independence	simplicity + internal activity
Definition applied	analogically (<i>Principles</i> I.51)	rigorously	rigorously, plus partlessness
The individual	a thinking substance, or a mode of extension	a mode of God	a substance - each monad unique
The physical world	<i>res extensa</i> , mechanistic	a mode of the attribute Extension	well-founded phenomenon
Cost	equivocation; interaction problem	individuality and contingency weaken	correspondence bought from God

- Best twenty-mark thesis: **the common definition does not force a common classification; the enforcement does.**

G. Spinoza as one integrated system

- **I, Def. 7** - free = exists from the necessity of its own nature, determined to action by itself alone.
- **I, P15** - whatever is, is in God (ontological "in", not spatial).
- **I, P16** - infinitely many things in infinitely many ways follow from divine necessity.
- **I, P18** - God is the **immanent**, not the transitive, cause.
- **I, P29** - nothing in nature is contingent.
- **I, P33** - things could have been produced in no other way or order.
- **II, P7** - the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things.
- **II, P13** - the human mind is the **idea of** the human body.
- **II, P40 Sch. 2** - three kinds of knowledge; **II, P41** - the first kind is the only cause of falsity; **II, P43** - *verum index sui*.
- **III, P6-P7** - striving (*conatus*) is the actual essence of a thing.
- **V, P25** - intuitive knowledge is the mind's highest endeavour; **V, P32 Cor.** - the intellectual love of God.
- Knowledge ladder: **imagination** (*experientia vaga, ex signis*) -> **reason** (common notions) -> **intuitive knowledge**. Example: **merchant** · **mathematician** · **seer**; the fourth proportional is **6**.
- Vocabulary: *causa sui* · *Deus sive Natura* (IV, Preface) · *natura naturans* / *natura naturata* · *sub specie aeternitatis* · *amor Dei intellectualis* · *beatitudo*.
- "**Determination is negation**" - **Letter 50 to Jarig Jelles, 2 June 1674**; universalised by **Hegel**. Not a sentence of the *Ethics*.
- Traps: not an atheist · attributes are not substances · God does not choose · pantheism ≠ acosmism.

H. Leibniz - plurality without interaction

- Argument to simples: extension -> divisible -> composite -> aggregates presuppose **partless units**.
- Monad: simple · unextended · indestructible · **perception** (many represented in one) + **appetition** (internal transition).
- **Minute perceptions** (*petites perceptions*) below awareness - the roar of the sea. **Apperception** only in rational spirits.
- Hierarchy: **bare entelechies** -> **animal souls** (memory) -> **rational spirits** (apperception, necessary truths, moral community with God). **God** is the unique **uncreated** necessary simple substance, not the top of the created series.
- **Monadology Section 7** - "monads have no windows", as it is usually rendered (*les monades n'ont point de fenêtres*).
- **Identity of indiscernibles** - duplicates would leave God without a sufficient reason.
- **Dominant monad** + organic aggregate; bodies are **well-founded phenomena** (*phaenomena bene fundata*).
- **Principle of Sufficient Reason** - grounds God, indiscernibles and truths of fact alike.
- **Truths of reason**: opposite contradictory, **finite** analysis. **Truths of fact**: opposite conceivable, **infinite** analysis, completed only by God.
- **Complete individual concept** contains every predicate ever true of the individual.
- **Possible worlds** and **compossibility**; the **best** world = greatest variety under the simplest laws - *not* maximum comfort. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) is **satire, not doctrine**.
- **Pre-established harmony**: three options - **influence** (Descartes) · **assistance** (occasionalism) · **harmony** (Leibniz, set once at creation). The **two clocks**.
- Freedom = **spontaneity + intelligence + contingency**; reasons "**incline without necessitating**" (*incliner sans nécessiter*).
- **Hypothetical or moral necessity** ≠ **absolute or logical necessity** - the single most valuable distinction in the Leibniz half of this topic.

I. God across the trio

Descartes	Spinoza	Leibniz
guarantees knowledge	is the system	selects and harmonises
personal, transcendent creator	impersonal, immanent substance	necessary being, rational chooser
trademark + conservation + ontological	a priori, from the definition of substance	cosmological via the Principle of Sufficient Reason, plus a repaired ontological route
created freely; gave the will its scope	acts from the necessity of the divine nature; no will	chose freely among possibles, though determined by what is best

- Mnemonic **G-I-S**: Guarantees · Is · Selects.
- Evaluative rider: Kant's objection that existence is not a real predicate bears on Descartes and Leibniz; it leaves Spinoza largely untouched, because he does not infer God from a concept of perfection.

J. Mind-body and freedom - the ranking rail

	Descartes	Spinoza	Leibniz
Mind-body	interaction (pineal gland)	parallelism (one thing, two attributes)	pre-established harmony
Mechanism	direct causal link	identity of the two orders	divine synchronisation at creation
Strength	matches lived experience	no interaction needed; economical	preserves plurality and internal agency
Weakness	unintelligible cross-substance causation	ordinary mental causation disappears	<i>ad hoc</i> ; correspondence bought in advance
Freedom	libertarian: affirm, deny, withhold	acting from one's own understood nature	spontaneity + intelligence + contingency

- **State the criterion, then rank.** Alternatives possible -> Descartes. Self-determination -> Spinoza. Responsible under determination -> **Leibniz** (the examiner-safe 2024 verdict).
- Economy -> Spinoza; fidelity to experience -> Descartes; systematic consistency -> Leibniz.

K. Criticism -> reply -> residual matrix

Target	Criticism	Reply	Residual
Descartes	the Circle	attended intuition vs remembered certainty	the proofs use extended reasoning
Descartes	interaction gap (Elisabeth, 1643)	the union is a primitive notion	a location, not a mechanism
Descartes	"substance" is equivocal	analogical: absolute of God, relative of creatures	Spinoza exploits exactly this
Spinoza	pantheism removes a personal God	morality rests on adequate knowledge, not command	providence and petition are lost
Spinoza	acosmism (Hegel)	modes are real as expressions	dependent individuality remains thin
Spinoza	determinism ends responsibility	freedom is adequate causation	alternatives never return
Spinoza	"determination is negation" makes the finite merely negative	finite things are positive modes, limited by other modes	the slogan is Hegel's universalisation of Letter 50
Leibniz	harmony is <i>ad hoc</i> and unfalsifiable	the only route avoiding both influx and monism	the defence is comparative, not positive
Leibniz	"best possible world" - Voltaire	"best" = maximum variety, simplest laws	the perfection criterion is not independently testable
Leibniz	fixed complete concepts erase freedom	the opposite implies no contradiction	alternatives lie across worlds, not within this one

L. Exam craft - PYQ routes, directives, provenance and the final trap sheet

Exact PYQ route map, 2018-2025 - fourteen primary-owned parts.

Year · part · marks	Route
2018 Q1(b) · 10	harmony -> windowlessness -> spontaneity + intelligence + contingency -> hypothetical necessity -> verdict
2018 Q2(a) · 20	shared definition -> three enforcements -> costs -> "criterion, not discovery"
2019 Q1(d) · 10	five-step Meditation VI causal argument -> limits -> theological dependence
2019 Q2(c) · 15	P16 -> three distinctions -> ethical consequence -> responsibility objection
2020 Q1(b) · 10	monadic structure -> determination -> three conditions -> first-person paragraph
2020 Q4(b) · 15	P16 + P18 -> four consequences -> three criticisms with replies
2022 Q2(c) · 15	four-step monism -> attributes and modes -> declared pantheism verdict -> acosmism
2022 Q4(b) · 15	doubt -> <i>cogito</i> -> <i>res cogitans</i> -> mediated world -> certainty vs substantiality
2023 Q1(c) · 10	interpret Def. 7 -> stone analogy -> adequate causation -> concession
2023 Q2(c) · 15	three kinds of ideas -> insufficiency -> dispositional innateness -> Locke's two tests -> adjudication
2024 Q2(b) · 15	substance argument -> ontological "in" -> P18 -> three objections and replies
2024 Q3(c) · 15	announce criterion -> all three accounts -> ranked verdict -> the winner's cost
2025 Q2(a) · 20	five tenets -> seven Cartesian stages -> unifying logic -> four vulnerabilities
2025 Q2(b) · 15	Letter 50 provenance -> meaning -> God, modes, knowledge -> acosmism -> ruling

Directive decoder. Discuss = exposition + assessment, roughly 60:40. Critically discuss = assessment dominates; a verdict is compulsory. Comment = short, thesis-first, inside the author's own system. Explain = foreground the derivation. Substantiate your view = take a side. With your own comments = a signposted first-person quarter. "Whose account ...?" = rank and defend. "What is the reason ...?" = give a mechanism.

Answer spines. 10 marks **D-R-A-E** - Define, Reconstruct, Apply a named text, Evaluate. 15 marks **D-R-D-E-V** - Define, Reconstruct, Debate, Evaluate, Verdict. 20 marks **C-M-C** - Common premise, Mechanism of divergence, Comparative costs and conclusion.

Provenance discipline. Cite Spinoza structurally, never by page. "Determination is negation" = **Letter 50**, universalised by Hegel. "Ghost in the machine" = **Ryle, 1949**, not Descartes. *Candide* (1759) = **Voltaire's satire**, not Leibniz's doctrine. "Monads have no windows" and "incline without necessitating" are **standard renderings** - say so. *Cogito, ergo sum* is from the *Discourse* and *Principles* I.7, not the *Meditations*.

Final trap sheet - ten lines.

1. The *cogito* is not a syllogism, and it does not by itself prove a substantial soul.
2. The wax argument does not prove that bodies exist.
3. Descartes' "substance" is **analogical**; he concedes it in *Principles* I.51.
4. Thought and Extension are Spinozist **attributes**, not substances.
5. Spinoza's freedom is not indeterminism, and Spinoza is not an atheist.
6. Pantheism and acosmism are **opposite** charges.
7. Monads never causally interact, and not every monad apperceives.
8. Pre-established harmony is set **once at creation** - continuous adjustment is occasionalism.
9. Leibnizian certainty is **not** absolute necessity.
10. A comparative answer without an announced **criterion** remains descriptive.

Memory chain - say it in fifteen seconds. One definition of substance, three degrees of strictness: three, one, infinitely many. God guarantees, is, selects. Mind and body interact, are one, are harmonised. Freedom is the will's assent, the intellect's adequacy, and spontaneity with intelligence and contingency. Every comparison needs a criterion.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/43: Central question and the 3-1-infinity route

```

=====
CENTRAL QUESTION: WHAT CAN REASON KNOW WITH NECESSITY, AND WHAT IS THERE TO KNOW
|
+--> WARRANT, not hostility to the senses: experience may OCCASION a
|   thought; only intellect certifies NECESSITY and UNIVERSALITY
+--> NECESSARY = could not be otherwise | UNIVERSAL = all cases, not
|   all observed cases | A PRIORI = justified independently of any
|   particular experience
|
v
THE TEST ALL THREE INHERIT - WHAT IS A SUBSTANCE?
"that which is in itself and is conceived through itself,
needing nothing else in order to exist"
|
HOW STRICTLY IS "NEEDING NOTHING ELSE" ENFORCED?
|
+-----+-----+-----+
| DESCARTES | SPINOZA | LEIBNIZ |
| loosely/analogically | strictly | strictly + SIMPLICITY |
| THREE substances | ONE substance | INFINITELY MANY monads |
| God + res cogitans | God, or Nature | simple, unextended, |
| + res extensa | (Deus sive Natura) | perceiving, striving |
| DUALISM | MONISM / PANTHEISM | PLURALISM |
| INTERACTION (pineal) | PARALLELISM | PRE-ESTABLISHED HARMONY |
| God GUARANTEES | God IS the system | God SELECTS+HARMONISES |
| libertarian will | adequate self- | spontaneity+intelligence |
| | determination | +contingency |
+-----+-----+-----+
|
+--> COST TO DESCARTES: interaction is unintelligible
+--> COST TO SPINOZA: individuality and alternatives are lost
+--> COST TO LEIBNIZ: correspondence must be bought from God in advance
|
v
MNEMONICS: substance "3 -> 1 -> infinity" | mind-body "I-P-H" (Interaction,
Parallelism, Harmony) | God "G-I-S" (Guarantees, Is, Selects)
SYLLABUS (verbatim): "Rationalism (Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz); Cartesian
Method and Certain Knowledge; Substance; God; Mind-Body Dualism;
Determinism and Freedom." Paper I, Section A, item 2.
CORPUS SIGNAL: 14 primary-owned parts of 112 Western parts, 2018-2025;
joint-highest in Western Philosophy; 2021 is the only year with none.

```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/43: Chronology and textual map that prevents anachronism

```

=====
1596-1650 RENE DESCARTES
1637 Discourse on the Method (French) -> four rules; je pense, donc je suis
1641 Meditations on First Philosophy (Latin; French 1647)
|   I -> senses, dream argument, evil genius (genius malignus)
|   II -> "I am, I exist"; the wax; mind better known than body
|   III -> trademark/causal proof; conservation proof; kinds of idea
|   IV -> error: the infinite will outruns the finite intellect
|   V -> the ontological proof
|   VI -> the real distinction; the external world
1641 Objections and Replies -> ARNAULD states the Circle (Fourth Objections)
1643 Correspondence with PRINCESS ELISABETH OF BOHEMIA -> interaction gap
1644 Principles of Philosophy -> I.7 cogito ergo sum; I.51 "substance" is
|   conceded to be ANALOGICAL
1649 Passions of the Soul -> pineal gland; the mind-body union
|
1632-1677 BENEDICT DE SPINOZA (reads Descartes; refuses the softening)
1656 excommunicated from the Amsterdam Jewish community (heterodoxy)
1663 Descartes' Principles of Philosophy, set out geometrically
1670 Theological-Political Treatise (anonymous)
1674 LETTER 50 to Jarig Jelles, 2 June -> "determination is negation"
1677 Ethics (posthumous), demonstrated more geometrico
|   I -> substance, God or Nature, necessity, immanent cause
|   II -> attributes, modes, parallelism, three kinds of knowledge
|   III -> striving (conatus) and the affects
|   IV -> human bondage; Deus sive Natura in the Preface

```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/43: Chronology and textual map that prevents anachronism (continued)

```
=====
      V  -> freedom, intuitive knowledge, intellectual love of God
      |
1646-1716 GOTTFRIED WILHELM LEIBNIZ (reads both; refuses one substance)
1686 Discourse on Metaphysics -> the complete individual concept
1704 New Essays on Human Understanding (against Locke; published 1765)
1710 Theodicy -> le meilleur des mondes possibles
1714 Monadology (French; printed 1720/1840) -> Sec.7 "no windows"
1715-16 Leibniz-Clarke correspondence -> sufficient reason; indiscernibles
      |
1759 VOLTAIRE, Candide -> satirises "the best of all possible worlds"
      CAUTION: reception, NOT doctrine. Never cite Candide as Leibniz's view.
```

CONSEQUENCE: the order is CAUSAL, not merely chronological. Spinoza's monism corrects an equivocation Descartes CONCEDES in Principles I.51; Leibniz's pluralism corrects Spinoza's absorption of individuals.

CAUTION 1: the Ethics appeared only after Spinoza's death, so seventeenth-century reaction to "Spinozism" often ran ahead of the text.

CAUTION 2: Leibniz's system must be assembled from the Discourse, the Theodicy, the Monadology and the correspondence together - which matters whenever an examiner quotes a single work.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/43: Five tenets and the definition that splits the school

```
=====
THE FIVE TENETS THAT DEFINE THE SCHOOL [2025 Q2(a), first limb]
+-----+-----+-----+-----+
| 1 | INNATE COGNITIVE | native CAPACITIES or structures of | |
|   | RESOURCES       | intellect, NOT copies taken from sense |
|   |                 | -> say "dispositional", never "known at |
|   |                 | birth", or Locke wins immediately |
| 2 | REASON GROUNDS NECESSITY | experience OCCASIONS; intellect WARRANTS |
| 3 | INTUITION AND DEDUCTION | Descartes: clear intuition + ordered |
|   |                 | deduction | Spinoza: geometrical order |
|   |                 | (more geometrico) | Leibniz: identities, |
|   |                 | sufficient reasons, complete concepts |
| 4 | THE REAL IS THE RATIONAL | reality has an intelligible structure |
| 5 | SUBSTANCE METAPHYSICS   | explain by substance, attribute, mode |
+-----+-----+-----+-----+
NOT THE CLAIM: that sensory beliefs are uniformly false, that the senses are
useless, or that every truth is consciously present at birth.
      |
      v
TENET 5 CARRIES THE INHERITED DEFINITION, AND THE DEFINITION HAS A DIAL
      |
DESCARTES turns it DOWN      only God needs NOTHING WHATEVER; mind and
(Principles I.51)            matter need only God -> "created substances"
SPINOZA turns it to MAXIMUM  conceived through itself = depends on nothing
                             at all -> only the infinite qualifies -> ONE
LEIBNIZ keeps plurality,    extended = divisible = composite = not
ADDS SIMPLICITY             ultimate -> partless units -> INFINITELY MANY
      |
      v
MEMORY CHAIN: ATTRIBUTE SEPARATES -> INDEPENDENCE UNIFIES -> SIMPLICITY
MULTIPLIES.
MECHANISM FOR 2018 Q2(a): a method fixes HOW to argue; it does not fix WHICH
criterion of "ontologically basic" to enforce, nor how strictly. The
divergence is rationalism operating CONSISTENTLY, not one of them lapsing.
HONEST LIMIT: the school supplies deductive ambition and vocabulary but no
neutral procedure for choosing among the three criteria.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/43: Descartes: the four rules and the three-stage doubt

```
=====
THE FOUR RULES (Discourse on the Method, Part II, 1637)
 1 EVIDENCE      accept nothing as true which is not clearly and evidently
                  known to be so; avoid haste and prejudice
 2 ANALYSIS      divide each difficulty into as many parts as its solution
                  requires
 3 ORDER          conduct thoughts in order, from the simplest and easiest
                  upward to the more complex
 4 ENUMERATION    make enumerations so complete and reviews so general that
                  nothing is omitted
                  | RULE 1 IS THE ENGINE. Rules 2-4 are intellectual hygiene borrowed
                  | from mathematical practice and by themselves remove no belief.
                  v
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/43: Descartes: the four rules and the three-stage doubt (continued)

```
=====
CLASS-BY-CLASS DEMOLITION (Meditation I) - CUMULATIVE, IN THIS ORDER
+-----+-----+-----+
| STAGE          | ARGUMENT                                | WHAT SURVIVES IT |
+-----+-----+-----+
| 1 SENSE-DECEPTION | the senses have deceived               | apparently my immediate
|                   | before - a bent stick in              | situation: this hand,
|                   | water, a distant tower -              | this paper
|                   | and what deceives once                |
|                   | is imprudent to trust                |
| 2 DREAM ARGUMENT  | there is no certain mark              | the simple and
|                   | distinguishing waking                 | universal: extension,
|                   | from sleep -> the whole                | shape, quantity,
|                   | external world may be                 | number; MATHEMATICS
|                   | absent                                |
| 3 EVIL GENIUS     | suppose a supremely                   | only what cannot be
| (genius)          | powerful malicious                    | false WHILE I AM
| (malignus)        | deceiver bends all his                | THINKING IT
|                   | effort to deceiving me -              |
|                   | even about 2 + 3 = 5                  |
+-----+-----+-----+
|
| v
THE LADDER BREAKS UNDER ITS OWN WEIGHT: TO BE DECEIVED, I MUST EXIST
TO BE DECEIVED.
CHARACTER OF THE DOUBT: METHODIC (adopted as a procedure) · HYPERBOLIC
(pushes further than ordinary life warrants) · PROVISIONAL (Descartes does
not believe the world is absent).
TRAP: reporting the three doubts unordered destroys the escalation, which is
itself the argument.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/43: The thinking self: wording, status and limits

```
=====
THE TWO FORMULATIONS - DO NOT CONFUSE THEM
  Discourse (1637, French)      je pense, donc je suis
  Principles I.7 (1644, Latin) cogito, ergo sum
  MEDITATIONS II (1641)        "I am, I exist, is necessarily true whenever
                                it is put forward by me or conceived in my
                                mind"
  TRAP: do NOT attribute "cogito, ergo sum" to the Meditations.
    |
    v
STATUS
+--> IMMEDIATE INTUITION of the mind, NOT a syllogism. Descartes expressly
    | denies a suppressed major premise such as "whatever thinks exists".
+--> PERFORMATIVE and PRESENT-TENSE: the act of entertaining the doubt
    | certifies the doubter at that moment.
+--> DEFEATS THE DECEIVER BY USING HIM: let him deceive as much as he can,
    | he can never make me nothing so long as I think I am something.
+--> THE ARCHIMEDEAN POINT: one firm and immovable point sufficient to
    | move the earth.
    |
    v
WHAT IT ESTABLISHES      | WHAT IT DOES NOT YET ESTABLISH
  thinking is occurring  | an enduring immaterial substance
  the thinker exists     | diachronic personal identity
  WHILE thinking         | that the thinker is ONLY a thinking thing
  one proposition immune | (the real distinction is argued in
  to the evil genius     | Meditation VI, not here)
    |
    v
DESCARTES THEN DEVELOPS THE THINKING THING (res cogitans) THROUGH THE REST
  OF MEDITATION II: "a thing that doubts, understands, affirms, denies, is
  willing, is unwilling, and also imagines and has sensory perceptions".
  LATER PRESSURE: Lichtenberg - Descartes was entitled only to "there is
  thinking"; Hume - the self is a bundle, not a substance.
  WHY THIS IS A RATIONALIST FOUNDATION: reached with NO sensory premise;
  grasped by INTELLECTUAL INTUITION; and it supplies the MODEL from which
  the criterion of truth is read off.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/43: Clear and distinct perception; three kinds of ideas

=====

STEP 1 READ THE CRITERION OFF THE MODEL - IT IS DERIVED, NOT ASSUMED

Why was "I am, I exist" certain? Because it was perceived CLEARLY and DISTINCTLY. RULE: whatever I perceive very clearly and distinctly is true.

CLEAR = present and open to an attentive mind

DISTINCT = so sharply separated from everything else that it contains within itself only what is clear

NOTE FOR PANEL 12: the rule is extracted from ONE instance. Turning it into a GENERAL licence for perceptions no longer attended to is exactly the work God is later asked to do - which is where the Circle strikes.

|
v

STEP 2 SORT THE CONTENTS OF THE MIND (Meditation III)

KIND	LATIN	HOW IT ARISES	EXAMPLES
ADVENTITIOUS	adventitiae	seem to come from outside, INVOLUNTARILY; passive	heat, colour, the sound of a passing cart
FACTITIOUS	factitiae	constructed BY ME from other ideas; voluntary	a golden mountain, a siren, a unicorn
INNATE	innatae	NATIVE to the mind's rational nature; ELICITED, not copied	thought, God, infinity, substance, the axioms of maths

|
v

TECHNICAL VOCABULARY REQUIRED FOR PANEL 11

OBJECTIVE REALITY of an idea = how much reality it REPRESENTS

FORMAL REALITY of a thing = how much reality it HAS

CAUSAL ADEQUACY PRINCIPLE = the cause of an idea must have at least as much formal reality as the idea has objective reality

PURPOSE OF THE CLASSIFICATION: it exists so that the idea of GOD can be placed in the third class and its content argued to exceed anything a finite mind could have manufactured.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/43: Innate ideas: the argument from insufficiency

=====

THE ARGUMENT FROM INSUFFICIENCY - PRESENT INNATENESS AS A CONCLUSION,
NEVER AS AN ASSERTION

- 1 Some ideas have a content - an OBJECTIVE REALITY - that no finite, changing sensation could supply.
- 2 THE INFINITE is the clearest case: it cannot be built by extending or negating the finite, because I recognise myself as finite only BY CONTRAST with an already-possessed idea of the infinite.
- 3 SUBSTANCE - a bearer persisting through changing qualities - is delivered by no sense-organ (the wax argument, Panels 9-10, shows this directly).
- 4 MATHEMATICAL NECESSITY cannot be read off any number of measured figures, because measurement yields "so far" and never "must".
- 5 THEREFORE these ideas are native to the intellect's own constitution.

|

v

INNATENESS, STATED AT ITS STRONGEST [this is the 2023 Q2(c) hinge]

NOT: an explicitly entertained proposition present in an infant's consciousness <- the OCCURRENT version; Locke destroys it

BUT: a DISPOSITION or native capacity, activated on an appropriate occasion - the mind carries "SEEDS OF KNOWLEDGE" which experience may prompt but does not create

DESCARTES' OWN ANALOGY (Comments on a Certain Broadsheet): we say a family has an inherited disposition to a disease, not because the infant suffers it in the womb, but because the constitution is such that the condition will develop.

|

v

INNATENESS IS A CONSTITUTION, NOT A CONTENT.

WHERE EACH INNATE IDEA IS USED LATER

- idea of GOD -> the trademark proof (Panel 11)
- idea of EXTENSION -> the wax argument (Panels 9-10)
- idea of SUBSTANCE -> the whole substance metaphysics (Panel 14)

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/43: Locke's grounds, the replies and the adjudication

LOCKE, ESSAY CONCERNING HUMAN UNDERSTANDING, BOOK I

The mind is "white paper, void of all characters", furnished from SENSATION and REFLECTION.

TRAP: omitting REFLECTION misstates Locke. His two sources are sense AND the mind's observation of its own operations.

LOCKE'S OBJECTION	CARTESIAN REPLY	WHAT STILL STANDS
NO UNIVERSAL ASSENT children and those lacking the concepts do not affirm the alleged principles	innateness is DISPOSITIONAL, not continuous conscious assent; universal assent was never the claim	a disposition must be specified so narrowly that not EVERY learnable truth counts as innate <- sharpest
NOTHING UNKNOWN CAN BE "IN THE MIND" if mental content is transparent, every knowable truth is "innate"	native capacities operate before reflective recognition; structure is not the same as occurrent content	the reply risks shifting from INNATE IDEAS to an uncontroversial CAPACITY TO LEARN, which is no rationalist thesis
SENSATION AND REFLECTION SUFFICE all materials of ideas trace to experience	finite experience cannot by itself yield the POSITIVE idea of infinity or the WARRANT for mathematical necessity	Locke reconstructs infinity by repetition and negation, necessity by abstraction

↓
v

ADJUDICATION THAT EARNS THE MARK

Locke DECISIVELY refutes OCCURRENT innatism - the doctrine that the mind is born consciously holding propositions.

He does NOT as clearly refute DISPOSITIONAL innatism.

But the burden then shifts to the rationalist to say what makes a disposition specifically INNATE rather than a general capacity to learn - and at that point the debate is genuinely unresolved.

ANSWER RULE: never defend the caricature. State the dispositional version FIRST, then let Locke attack, then rule.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/43: The wax argument: the eight numbered steps

```
=====
1 TAKE THE CLEAREST POSSIBLE CASE OF A BODY - wax fresh from the honeycomb
  SENSIBLE CATALOGUE: taste of honey | scent of flowers | a colour |
  a shape | a size | hardness | coldness | a sound when rapped
  |
2 MOVE IT TO THE FIRE -> EVERY item in that catalogue is destroyed or
  replaced: taste and scent vanish, colour alters, shape and size are lost,
  it becomes liquid and hot, and it no longer sounds
  |
3 YET I JUDGE, WITHOUT THE LEAST HESITATION, THAT THE SAME WAX REMAINS
  |
4 THEREFORE what I take the wax to BE is not identical with any item at
  step 1, since all of them were replaced while the wax persisted
  |
5 NOR IS IT DELIVERED BY IMAGINATION: heat can give the wax an INDEFINITE
  number of shapes and sizes, and I cannot run through indefinitely many
  images. THIS IS THE FORCE OF flexibile et mutabile ("flexible and
  changeable").
  |
6 THEREFORE the wax is grasped as an EXTENDED, FLEXIBLE, CHANGEABLE thing by
  the INTELLECT ALONE - by inspectio mentis, rendered "purely mental
  scrutiny" in the Cottingham-Stoothoff-Murdoch translation and "inspection
  of the mind" in Haldane-Ross
  |
7 FURTHER: at every stage - judging the wax present, doubting it, being
  deceived about it - I perceive MYSELF judging. Each perception of a body is
  ipso facto a perception of the mind that perceives, and a MORE CERTAIN one,
  because it survives even if the body does not exist
  |
8 THEREFORE (a) BODIES ARE KNOWN BY UNDERSTANDING, NOT BY SENSE
  (b) THE MIND IS notior - MORE EVIDENTLY KNOWN - THAN ANY BODY

PAIRED CASE IN THE SAME MEDITATION: "HATS AND COATS". From a window I say I
  SEE men crossing the square; strictly I see only hats and coats and JUDGE
  that men are underneath. What passes for seeing is in fact judging.
PRINTED SUB-TITLE OF MEDITATION II: "The nature of the human mind, and how it
  is better known than the body."
EXACT SUBTERMS TO USE: cera | inspectio mentis | sensus vs imaginatio vs
  intellectus | flexibile et mutabile | res extensa.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/43: The wax: presuppositions, objections and verdict

```
=====
WHAT THE ARGUMENT ASSUMES - STATE THESE; THE 15/20-MARK MARKS ARE HERE
P1 SUBSTANCE/ATTRIBUTE METAPHYSICS IS ALREADY IN PLACE. Identity through
  TOTAL qualitative replacement requires a BEARER distinct from the
  qualities. Step 3 therefore uses the very metaphysics the Meditations
  claim to derive.
P2 SENSE IS EXHAUSTED BY THE CATALOGUE. If sense could deliver a
  structural or relational item - not just colour, taste, sound - then
  step 4 fails.
P3 IMAGINATION IS IMAGE-BOUND and therefore finite in range, while
  intellect is not.
P4 PERCEPTION IS SELF-INTIMATING. I cannot perceive without perceiving
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/43: The wax: presuppositions, objections and verdict (continued)

=====		
THAT I perceive. Step 7 depends wholly on this.		
v		
OBJECTION	SOURCE	REPLY / RESIDUAL
what survives melting is just "extended stuff", an ABSTRACTION built from repeated sense-experience	GASSENDI, Fifth Objections; the empiricist line	the abstraction must still be OF something identical across the change, and no sensory item registers IDENTITY. RESIDUAL: the CONCEPT is not an image; the KNOWLEDGE is not thereby shown a priori
strip away every sensible quality and nothing remains; extension without sensible qualities is unintelligible	BERKELEY, Principles Sec.9-11	extension is not a further quality but the MODE OF BEING of every sensible quality. RESIDUAL: the reply presupposes exactly what Berkeley denies
step 7 confuses CERTAINTY with CONTENT	analytic reconstruction	Descartes needs only EPISTEMIC priority for the order of the Meditations. RESIDUAL: fair - "better known" must be read strictly as MORE INDUBITABLE
=====		
v		
WHAT IS AND IS NOT ESTABLISHED		
YES: bodily identity through change is grasped by intellect		
YES: the essence of body is extension (WITHIN this Meditation)		
YES: the mind is better known, in the sense of more indubitable		
NO : that bodies EXIST - that is Meditation VI, by divine veracity		
OPEN: whether knowledge of body is a priori		
VERDICT: Meditation II already installs EXTENSION as body's essence, so the dualism "proved" in Meditation VI is in part PRESUPPOSED in Meditation II.		
The Meditations must be read as ONE deductive arc, not six exercises.		

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/43: The three proofs of God and their division of labour

=====		
PROOF 1 - TRADEMARK / CAUSAL (Meditation III)		
1 I have an idea of God: an infinite, perfect being.		
2 The cause of an idea must have at least as much FORMAL reality as the idea has OBJECTIVE reality.		
3 I, finite and imperfect, cannot be the adequate cause of an idea of an infinite perfect being.		
4 THEREFORE God exists as its cause - He "stamped" the idea on my mind as a craftsman stamps his mark on his work.		
ANSWERS: where could this idea have come from?		
PROOF 2 - CONSERVATION / COSMOLOGICAL VARIANT (Meditation III)		
I exist now; nothing in me gives me the power to sustain myself from one moment to the next; the cause of my continued existence must therefore ultimately be God.		
ANSWERS: what keeps me in existence?		

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/43: The three proofs of God and their division of labour (continued)

PROOF 3 - ONTOLOGICAL (Meditation V)

- 1 The concept of God = the concept of a supremely perfect being.
- 2 Existence is a perfection.
- 3 A supremely perfect being lacking existence would lack a perfection - a contradiction, like a triangle without three angles or a mountain without a valley.
- 4 THEREFORE God necessarily exists.

ANSWERS: what does the concept itself contain?

RIDER (one line only; Kant is Topic 04's owner): Kant objects that existence is not a real predicate.

|
v

DIVINE VERACITY: A PERFECT BEING IS NO DECEIVER

WHAT GOD SUPPLIES	WHAT COLLAPSES WITHOUT IT
general reliability of clear and distinct perception	nothing beyond the momentary thinking self survives
trustworthiness of memory and long chains of reasoning	the system contracts to isolated intuitions; mathematics goes
the guarantee behind natural inclination	the external world remains unproved
continuous conservation of finite substances	"created substance" loses its ground

VERDICT LINE: the Meditations stand or fall on MEDITATION III, not Meditation II.

NAMING THE DIVISION OF LABOUR IS WORTH MORE THAN RECITING ALL THREE AT LENGTH.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/43: The Cartesian Circle: objection, reply and residual

THE OBJECTION (ARNAULD, FOURTH OBJECTIONS)

Descartes uses CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION to prove that GOD exists; he then uses GOD'S VERACITY to guarantee that CLEAR AND DISTINCT PERCEPTION is reliable. The guarantee therefore presupposes what it is meant to establish.

```

criterion ----- proves -----> God
      ^                               |
      |                               |
+----- certifies -----+
  
```

THE PICTURE IN ONE LINE: Descartes builds a bridge out of God, and the planks were cut from the far island he has not yet reached.

THE REPLY - TWO SITUATIONS MUST BE DISTINGUISHED

- (i) A clear and distinct perception ACTUALLY BEFORE THE MIND compels assent and needs no external certificate. Some planks are solid enough to stand on while you are looking at them.
- (ii) What needs certifying is the perception merely REMEMBERED as having been clear, and any EXTENDED CHAIN of reasoning whose earlier steps are no longer in view.

GOD SECURES CLASS (ii), NOT CLASS (i).

THE RESIDUAL - SAY THIS, OR THE ANSWER IS INCOMPLETE

The proofs of God are NOT single-flash intuitions. They are arguments with premises, and by the time the conclusion is reached the earlier premises are being REMEMBERED rather than attended to. So the memory reply SOFTENS the objection without eliminating it.

COMPETING READINGS (optional depth, one clause at most)

vicious-circle reading (Arnauld's line) | memory-guarantee reading |
stronger anti-circle reading on which the cogito and simple intuitions are self-certifying while attended to.

CONSEQUENCE FOR EVERY LATER PANEL: whatever divine veracity underwrites - mathematics, memory, the external world, the conservation of created substances - inherits this vulnerability.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/43: The external world: Meditation VI in five steps

```

=====
THE ARGUMENT [2019 Q1(d) is marked on these five steps]
  1 SENSORY IDEAS ARRIVE INVOLUNTARILY. I cannot decide not to feel heat when
    near the fire. So I possess a PASSIVE FACULTY of receiving them.
  2 A PASSIVE FACULTY REQUIRES AN ACTIVE CAUSE containing that reality
    formally or eminently.
  3 THE CANDIDATES ARE: myself, God directly, or bodies. It is not myself,
    because the ideas arrive without my willing them.
  4 I HAVE A GREAT NATURAL INCLINATION to refer them to bodies, and NO
    FACULTY by which God could have given me the means to correct it.
    If no bodies existed, God would be permitting an uncorrectable systematic
    error - that is, DECEIVING.
  5 THEREFORE MATERIAL THINGS EXIST AS EXTENDED REALITIES.
    |
    v
WHAT THE PROOF SECURES          | WHAT IT DOES NOT SECURE
the existence of body           | the literal accuracy of any particular
the reality of EXTENSION       | colour, size, distance or sensible quality
                               | -> the senses are reliable for what is
                               | useful to the MIND-BODY UNION, not for
                               | metaphysics; INTELLECT must correct them
    |
    v
EXCLUSION THAT IS ITSELF WORTH A MARK
THE WAX ARGUMENT DOES NOT DO THIS WORK. It shows HOW bodies would be known;
it says nothing about whether any EXIST. Saying so explicitly separates a
controlled answer from a confused one.

STRUCTURE OF THE PROOF: THEOLOGICAL, NOT PERCEPTUAL. What does the work is not
the vividness of experience but the IMPOSSIBILITY OF DIVINE DECEPTION.

INHERITED VULNERABILITY: the whole bridge carries Arnauld's Circle (Panel 12).
The external world is only as secure as the divine proofs on which it rests.

ORDER TO MEMORISE: THINKING SELF -> GOD -> WORLD.
TRAP: "Descartes proved the external world first, then God" inverts the
entire architecture.

```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/43: Descartes on substance and the real distinction

```

=====
                GOD - INFINITE SUBSTANCE
            absolutely independent: needs NOTHING WHATEVER
                |
            creates and CONTINUOUSLY CONSERVES
                |
        +-----+-----+
        |               |
    RES COGITANS      RES EXTENSA
    principal attribute: THOUGHT
    unextended, INDIVISIBLE
    not in space
    MODES: ideas, volitions, doubting,
    willing, imagining, seeming to
    sense
        |               |
        +-----+-----+
                |
VOCABULARY: each substance has exactly ONE PRINCIPAL ATTRIBUTE constituting
its essence; everything else is a MODE, a determinate way of being that
attribute. SPINOZA KEEPS THESE WORDS AND CHANGES WHAT THEY ATTACH TO.
                |
THE TENSION DESCARTES HIMSELF CONCEDES - PRINCIPLES I.51
By the strict definition only GOD needs nothing else. Mind and matter need
God. So "SUBSTANCE" IS USED ANALOGICALLY, not univocally.

```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/43: Descartes on substance and the real distinction (continued)

```
=====
>>> THIS SINGLE CONCESSION IS THE HINGE OF 2018 Q2(a), AND IT IS WHAT
    SPINOZA EXPLOITS. <<<
    |
THE ARGUMENT FOR REAL DISTINCTION (Meditation VI)
1 I clearly and distinctly conceive myself as a thinking, non-extended
  thing, and body as an extended, non-thinking thing.
2 Whatever I can clearly and distinctly conceive as separate, God is able
  to create as separate.
3 THEREFORE mind can exist without body, and body without mind.
4 THEREFORE they are REALLY DISTINCT - two substances, not two aspects.

CRITICAL NOTE: the whole argument rests on the CRITERION of Panel 6 and
  therefore on the DIVINE GUARANTEE of Panels 11-12. Dualism is a CONCLUSION
  of the system, never its starting assumption.
KNOWLEDGE ASYMMETRY [2022 Q4(b)]: the self is known IMMEDIATELY through the
  thinking act; the world only MEDIATELY, through ideas whose reliability
  depends on God's veracity being established first.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/43: Interaction, the union, error and Cartesian freedom

```
=====
THE PROBLEM
RES COGITANS and RES EXTENSA SHARE NOTHING WHATEVER.
And yet, in a human being: a decision to raise the arm -> the arm rises;
a pin in the foot -> a FELT pain, not an observed injury.
    |
PRINCESS ELISABETH OF BOHEMIA, correspondence of 1643:
HOW can a thing whose entire nature is THOUGHT determine the animal spirits
to move the body, when causation of motion seems to require contact and
extension? Causation appears to require some COMMUNITY between cause and
effect; thought and extension have NONE.
    |
DESCARTES' TWO ANSWERS - KEEP THEM APART
PHYSIOLOGICAL: the PINEAL GLAND (Passions of the Soul), chosen because it
  is a single UNPAIRED structure at the centre of the brain, whereas most
  brain structures are duplicated.
  >>> THIS IS A LOCATION, NOT A MECHANISM. <<<
PHILOSOPHICAL: the mind-body UNION is a THIRD PRIMITIVE NOTION, alongside
  thought and extension, grasped through ORDINARY LIVING rather than
  through pure intellect. Trying to conceive it by intellect alone is
  precisely what makes it seem impossible.
    |
VERDICT: the reply PRESERVES THE PHENOMENON and ABANDONS THE MECHANISM.
THIS VACANCY IS WHAT SPINOZA AND LEIBNIZ COMPETE TO FILL.
The union is intimate, NOT a pilot in a ship - which is why we FEEL pain.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/43: Interaction, the union, error and Cartesian freedom (continued)

```
=====
ERROR AND FREEDOM (MEDITATION IV)
  THE WILL is INFINITE in scope: I can affirm or deny anything whatever.
  THE INTELLECT is FINITE: I perceive clearly only within limits.
  ERROR = the will affirming BEYOND what the intellect clearly perceives.
    -> error is not caused by God but by my misuse of a perfect faculty
  FREEDOM includes the power to AFFIRM, DENY or WITHHOLD ASSENT, and is not
    reducible to bodily mechanism.
  GRADES: MERE INDIFFERENCE IS THE LOWEST GRADE OF FREEDOM. When the
    intellect clearly perceives truth, the will assents MORE freely, because
    it is moved by evident reason rather than by ignorance or compulsion.
  TRAP: the claim that indifference is the highest freedom REVERSES the
    text.
  OPEN QUESTION: Descartes is usually classed a libertarian, but the relation
    between alternative possibilities, clear intellectual determination and
    divine preordination is contested and underexplained.
  TRAP: "the ghost in the machine" is GILBERT RYLE'S hostile coinage, The
    Concept of Mind, 1949 - NEVER Descartes' own phrase.
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/43: Spinoza: one substance and its architecture

```
=====
THE ARGUMENT FOR MONISM (Ethics I, more geometrico)
  1 DEFINITION. Substance = what is IN ITSELF and is CONCEIVED THROUGH
    ITSELF; its concept requires no other concept.
  2 NO SHARING. Two substances cannot share an attribute - if they did there
    would be nothing left by which to tell them apart QUA SUBSTANCE.
  3 NO FINITUDE. A finite substance would have to be limited by another OF
    THE SAME NATURE - which step 2 forbids. So substance is necessarily
    INFINITE.
  4 CONCLUSION. There can be only ONE substance, and it must possess ALL
    attributes: ABSOLUTELY INFINITE. This is God.
  COROLLARY: being in itself and conceived through itself, substance is
    SELF-CAUSED (causa sui): its essence involves existence.
    |
    v
+-----+
| ONE ABSOLUTELY INFINITE, SELF-CAUSED SUBSTANCE = DEUS SIVE NATURA |
+-----+
    |
    INFINITELY MANY ATTRIBUTES, each expressing the WHOLE eternal and infinite
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 23/43: Spinoza: one substance and its architecture (continued)

```
=====
essence of substance - NOT a portion of it, NOT a part, NOT a substance
    |
+-----+-----+-----+
| THOUGHT (known to us) | EXTENSION (known) | infinitely many |
| INFINITE MODES        | INFINITE MODES        | further attributes |
| the infinite          | motion-and-rest        | unknown to us      |
| intellect              |                          |                     |
| FINITE MODES          | FINITE MODES          |                     |
| my mind, your mind    | my body, this stone    |                     |
+-----+-----+-----+
    |
    THE SAME ORDER, TWICE OVER (Ethics II, P7) - see Panel 20
    |
    v
MODE = an affection of substance; that which is IN ANOTHER and is CONCEIVED
  THROUGH ANOTHER. Ethics I, P15: "WHATEVER IS, IS IN GOD, and nothing can
  be or be conceived without God." The "IN" is ONTOLOGICAL, NOT SPATIAL.
TWO GRADES OF MODE: INFINITE modes follow immediately or mediately from the
  absolute nature of an attribute; FINITE modes are determined by other
  finite modes in an endless series.
TRAP: confusing Spinoza's ATTRIBUTES with Descartes' SUBSTANCES destroys every
  comparative answer, because it removes the reason parallelism replaces
  interaction.
```


ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 24/43: Spinoza's God: immanence and the three labels

=====

WHAT THIS GOD IS

NOT a person; does NOT choose; does NOT deliberate; has NO purpose and NO providence. God acts from the NECESSITY OF THE DIVINE NATURE.

Ethics I, P18: GOD IS THE IMMANENT, NOT THE TRANSITIVE, CAUSE OF ALL THINGS

TRANSITIVE cause produces something OUTSIDE itself - a carpenter and a table

IMMANENT cause REMAINS IN ITS EFFECT - the sea and the wave

NATURA NATURANS = substance and its attributes as FREE ACTIVE CAUSE

NATURA NATURATA = the totality of MODES that follows from that necessity

DEUS SIVE NATURA = "God, or Nature" - Ethics IV, Preface, and IV, P4 Dem.

Safe to quote verbatim in Latin.

NOT AN ATHEIST: excommunicated in 1656 for HETERODOXY, not atheism; the position is unorthodox theism or pantheism in which God is INDISPENSABLE.

|

v

DOES THE DOCTRINE OF SUBSTANCE LEAD TO PANTHEISM? [2022 Q2(c) - TAKE A SIDE]

WHAT IS ESTABLISHED	nothing exists outside God; all finite things are modes existing in and conceived through God; God is the immanent cause -> IN THAT PRECISE SENSE, YES
WHAT IS NOT ESTABLISHED	it does NOT follow that any finite thing, or the visible aggregate, is numerically identical with the whole infinite divine essence; substance EXCEEDS the two attributes we know
THE RIVAL LABEL	PANENTHEISM - all things are IN God while God exceeds them; interpreters genuinely dispute which label is more accurate
THE OPPOSITE CHARGE	ACOSMISM (Hegel): if only substance is real, the finite world DISSOLVES INTO NOTHING - Spinoza is accused not of deifying the world but of DENYING it
THE REPLY	modes are real AS EXPRESSIONS, with dependent rather than independent reality; "not self-subsistent" is not "not real"
DEFENDED VERDICT	a QUALIFIED PANTHEIST: divine immanence is undeniable; divine infinity blocks reduction to the world we perceive

TRAP: pantheism and acosmism are OPPOSITE accusations. Treating them as one objection makes the 2022 answer incoherent.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 25/43: Spinoza: necessitarianism and the denial of contingency

=====

THE PROPOSITIONS THAT CARRY THE DOCTRINE

- I, P16 From the necessity of the divine nature there must follow INFINITELY MANY THINGS in INFINITELY MANY WAYS.
- [2020 Q4(b) quotes exactly this]
- I, P29 NOTHING IN NATURE IS CONTINGENT; all is determined by the necessity of the divine nature to exist and act in a certain way.
- I, P33 Things could have been produced in NO OTHER WAY and in NO OTHER ORDER.
- I, Def.7 That thing is FREE which exists solely from the necessity of ITS OWN NATURE and is determined to action BY ITSELF ALONE.

|

v

THE DERIVATION [2019 Q2(c): "what is, cannot be other than what it is"]

- 1 God, or Nature, is the one self-caused substance, acting from the necessity of the divine nature alone.
- 2 P16: infinitely many things follow from that necessity - modes follow from WHAT SUBSTANCE IS, as conclusions follow from premises.
- 3 THEREFORE modes are not products of a discretionary decree; there is no deliberation, no selection among alternatives, no purpose.
- 4 P29: contingency is a name for OUR IGNORANCE OF CAUSES, not an objective gap in the order.
- 5 Finite modes are determined by OTHER FINITE MODES in an endless series WITHIN the one necessary order.

|

v

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 26/43: Spinoza: necessitarianism and the denial of contingency (continued)

THREE DISTINCTIONS THAT MUST STAY CLEAN

- (i) God is free NOT because God could have chosen otherwise but because God is determined by NOTHING EXTERNAL (Def. 7).
- (ii) The necessity is LOGICAL-ONTOLOGICAL, not fatalistic compulsion by an external agent. There is no agent doing the pushing.
- (iii) Denying contingency is NOT denying causality; it is denying that the causal order could have run differently.

ALSO: the inference is ONTOLOGICAL, NOT TEMPORAL. It is not a story in which God exists first and produces a world afterwards.

|
v

THREE CRITICISMS OF P16, WITH REPLIES AND RESIDUES

necessity removes divine PERSONALITY -> will and intellect are not faculties outside nature; anthropomorphic choice would LIMIT God

RESIDUAL: providence, petition and worship are genuinely lost

EVIL follows necessarily from God -> good and evil express relations to human flourishing, not properties of infinite substance

RESIDUAL: suffering still belongs, unredeemed, to the necessary order

P16 ASSERTS MORE THAN THE DEFINITIONS PROVE -> an infinite cause must express itself infinitely

RESIDUAL: the derivation of DETERMINATE FINITE modes remains the hardest step in Ethics I

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 27/43: Spinoza: 'determination is negation' - provenance and use

PROVENANCE FIRST - THIS LINE IS ITSELF WORTH A MARK [2025 Q2(b)]

The exact Latin formula OMNIS DETERMINATIO EST NEGATIO IS NOT IN THE ETHICS.

Spinoza writes DETERMINATIO NEGATIO EST in LETTER 50 TO JARIG JELLES, 2 JUNE 1674.

The universalised slogan is HEGEL'S rendering, and that is how it entered the textbook tradition.

SAFE SENTENCE: "Spinoza's dictum, in Letter 50, that determination is negation - universalised by Hegel as omnis determinatio est negatio."

|
v

THE MEANING

To DETERMINE something is to make it definite, finite, BOUNDED.

To say a thing is THIS is to say it is NOT everything else.

FINITUDE THEREFORE CONTAINS NEGATION.

|
v

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 28/43: Spinoza: 'determination is negation' - provenance and use (continued)

```
=====
THREE CONSEQUENCES - EXACTLY WHAT A "COMMENT" ANSWER NEEDS
  FOR GOD          absolutely infinite, bounded by nothing external, so God
                   involves NO negation whatever: PURE AFFIRMATION,
                   undetermined by anything outside
  FOR FINITE MODES each is limited by OTHER MODES OF THE SAME NATURE - a body
                   occupies this region and excludes others; an idea expresses
                   only a bounded causal perspective; their determinacy marks
                   DEPENDENCE
  FOR KNOWLEDGE    inadequate knowledge treats a finite thing IN ISOLATION;
  AND FREEDOM      adequate knowledge understands it THROUGH THE AFFIRMATIVE
                   WHOLE, seeing it SUB SPECIE AETERNITATIS - under the aspect
                   of eternity

      |
      v
HEGEL'S CRITICISM AND THE REPLY
  CRITICISM: if determination is negation, the finite becomes MERE negation,
             and the world vanishes into substance -> ACOSMISM.
  REPLY: what is negated is INDEPENDENT SELF-SUBSISTENCE, not reality as
         such; modes POSITIVELY EXPRESS divine power in determinate ways.
  VERDICT: the dictum illuminates why finite beings are dependent, but it
         becomes reductive if LIMITATION is mistaken for UNREALITY. Spinoza needs
         BOTH the negation of independence AND the affirmation of modal
         expression.
  DIRECTIVE NOTE: "COMMENT" means short, pointed and THESIS-FIRST, stating what
         the sentence means INSIDE Spinoza's own system - never a general essay.
```

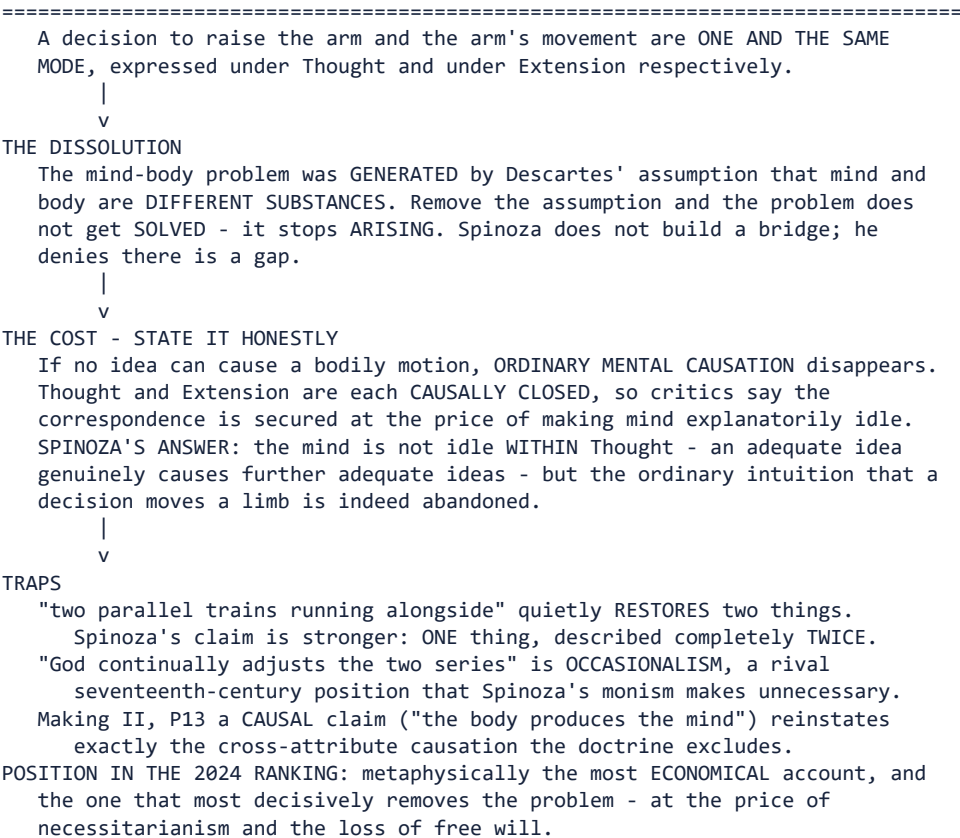
ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 29/43: Spinoza: parallelism dissolves the mind-body problem

```
=====
THE PROPOSITIONS
  II, P7   The ORDER AND CONNECTION OF IDEAS is the same as the ORDER AND
           CONNECTION OF THINGS.
  II, P13  The human MIND IS THE IDEA OF THE HUMAN BODY - so the mind's
           adequacy tracks the body's power of acting.

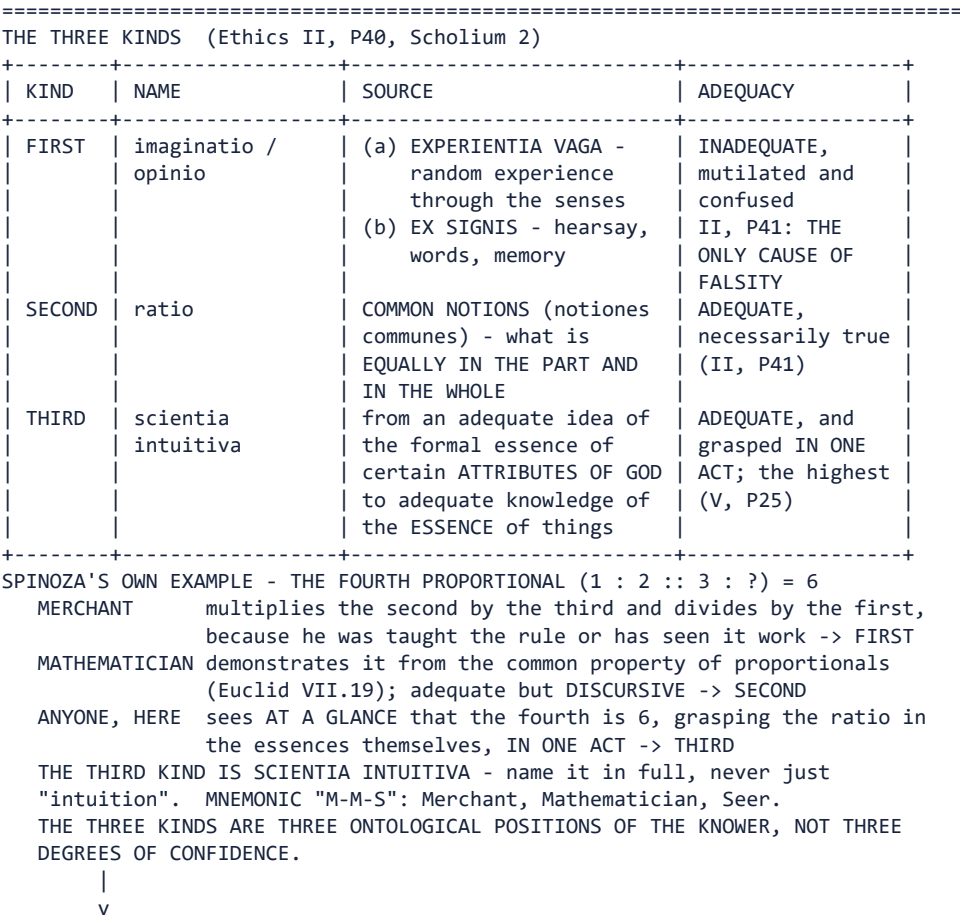
      |
      v
THE PICTURE
  IDEA_1 -----> IDEA_2 -----> IDEA_3   causation stays INSIDE Thought
  ||           ||           ||             the SAME modes, the SAME order
  BODY_1 -----> BODY_2 -----> BODY_3   causation stays INSIDE Extension

  >>> THERE ARE NO ARROWS BETWEEN THE ROWS. THAT IS THE WHOLE DOCTRINE. <<<
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 30/43: Spinoza: parallelism dissolves the mind-body problem (continued)



ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 31/43: Spinoza: three kinds of knowledge and freedom



ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 32/43: Spinoza: three kinds of knowledge and freedom (continued)

=====

THE ARGUMENT THAT MAKES KNOWLEDGE INTO FREEDOM

- 1 Everything follows necessarily from the nature of God or Substance.
- 2 An idea is ADEQUATE when understood through its cause - through its place in that necessary order.
- 3 BONDAGE (servitus) = being determined by causes EXTERNAL to my nature, which is exactly the condition of one whose ideas are inadequate, since inadequate ideas are the TRACES OF OTHER BODIES in mine.
- 4 FREEDOM (I, Def. 7) = being determined by MY OWN nature alone.
- 5 Adequate ideas ARE the mind acting from its own nature, for in having them the mind is the ADEQUATE CAUSE of what follows from them.
- 6 THEREFORE moving from the first kind to the second and third IS moving from bondage to freedom. KNOWLEDGE IS NOT A MEANS TO FREEDOM; IT IS FREEDOM.
- 7 At the limit the third kind sees things SUB SPECIE AETERNITATIS and generates the INTELLECTUAL LOVE OF GOD (amor Dei intellectualis, V, P32 Cor.) - the mind's highest good and blessedness (beatitudo).

|

v

STRIVING AND THE AFFECTS - RETAINED ONLY AS FAR AS THEY EXPLAIN FREEDOM

III, P6-P7 each thing strives to persevere in its being (CONATUS), and this striving IS THE ACTUAL ESSENCE of the thing. In a human being, conscious striving appears as DESIRE.

PASSIVE AFFECTS arise when the person is only a PARTIAL cause under external determination. ACTIVE AFFECTS arise from adequate ideas and register an INCREASE IN THE POWER OF ACTING.

FREE WILL IS AN ILLUSION: we are conscious of our DESIRES but ignorant of the CAUSES that determine them - a thrown STONE, if conscious, would believe it chose to fly.

ONLY GOD IS ABSOLUTELY FREE. Human freedom is RELATIVE and ACHIEVED.

LIVE WEAKNESS TO CONCEDE: II, P43 - "he who has a true idea knows at the same time that he has a true idea"; truth is the standard of itself and of the false (verum index sui). But SELF-CERTIFICATION is exactly what confident IMAGINATION also feels like.

CONCEDE ALSO: alternative possibilities never return, and even the achievement of freedom is itself necessitated.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 33/43: Leibniz: monads, hierarchy and indiscernibles

=====

THE ARGUMENT TO SIMPLES (Monadology Sec.1-3)

- 1 Extension is essentially DIVISIBLE.
- 2 Whatever is divisible is a COMPOSITE, an aggregate of parts.
- 3 An aggregate derives its reality from the reality of its constituents;
a heap of heaps of heaps, with no grains anywhere, is no heap.
- 4 THEREFORE extended things cannot be ultimate. There must be SIMPLE substances, and these cannot themselves be extended.

NOTE: this refutes SPINOZA too - if extension cannot be a possible essence of substance, Extension cannot be an attribute in Spinoza's sense.

|
A PARTLESS UNIT HAS NO SHAPE, NO SIZE, NO POSITION. WHAT INNER STATES REMAIN? Only REPRESENTING and PASSING FROM ONE REPRESENTATION TO THE NEXT.

|
v

GOD

the unique UNCREATED necessary simple substance; source of all monads; complete and infinite intelligence
CAUTION: "the supreme Monad" is common SHORTHAND - God is NOT merely the top member of the CREATED series

+-----+-----+-----+		
RATIONAL SPIRITS	ANIMAL SOULS	BARE MONADS
(minds)	(souls proper)	(bare entelechies)
APPERCEPTION - conscious	MEMORY, producing a	only obscure and
reflexive awareness;	"consecutiveness"	confused MINUTE
grasp of NECESSARY and	resembling reason;	PERCEPTIONS
ETERNAL TRUTHS; science	perception raised to	(petites
and morality; moral	distinct feeling	perceptions); no
community with God		apperception
+-----+-----+-----+		

EVERY monad at EVERY level has PERCEPTION and APPETITION.

PERCEPTION = the representation of the manifold in the simple.

IT DOES NOT IMPLY CONSCIOUSNESS.

APPETITION = the internal principle producing change; the tendency carrying one perception into the next.

PETITES PERCEPTIONS = perceptions below reflective awareness. Leibniz's

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 34/43: Leibniz: monads, hierarchy and indiscernibles (continued)

```

=====
                illustration: the ROAR OF THE SEA - we hear the whole
                roar, so we must in some way perceive each wave.
    APPERCEPTION = conscious reflexive awareness. TRAP: it must NOT be
                attributed to every monad.
    Each monad represents the WHOLE universe from its own point of view - "a
    perpetual living mirror of the universe".
        |
        v
TWO DOCTRINES THAT MAKE THIS WORK
NO WINDOWS (Monadology Sec.7): "Monads have no windows through which
    anything could come in or go out" - as it is USUALLY RENDERED; the
    French is Les Monades n'ont point de fenetres. No causal influx enters;
    all change arises INTERNALLY from appetite.
IDENTITY OF INDISCERNIBLES: no two monads are exactly alike, because God
    would have had NO SUFFICIENT REASON to create both rather than one.
    -> INDIVIDUALITY IS GUARANTEED, NOT MERELY PERMITTED. This is precisely
        what Spinoza's system cannot deliver, and it is Leibniz's motive.
        |
        v
AND WHAT ABOUT BODIES?
    An organism is coordinated by a DOMINANT MONAD together with an ORGANIC
    AGGREGATE of subordinate monads - coordination, NOT causal control through
    exchanged signals.
    Extended bodies are WELL-FOUNDED PHENOMENA (phaenomena bene fundata),
    grounded in ordered monadic aggregates: NOT ultimate substances, but
    NEITHER arbitrary private illusions. The adjective "WELL-FOUNDED" is doing
    the work; dropping it turns Leibniz into a subjective idealist, which he is
    not.
CONSEQUENCE: interaction is impossible IN PRINCIPLE, so the mind-body question
    must be answered some other way - see Panel 23.

```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 35/43: Leibniz: sufficient reason, worlds, harmony, freedom

```

=====
PRINCIPLE OF SUFFICIENT REASON (PSR)
    "Nothing is without a reason why it is so rather than otherwise."
        |
        +-----+-----+-----+-----+
        | GOD EXISTS| TWO KINDS OF | IDENTITY OF | THE BEST OF ALL |
        | contingent| TRUTH      | INDISCERNIBLES| POSSIBLE WORLDS |
        | things    | (below)    | (Panel 22)  | (below)         |
        | exist ->  |            |            |                |
        | the whole SERIES is contingent -> its reason cannot lie WITHIN the |
        | series -> a NECESSARY BEING outside it = GOD. Leibniz also accepts an |
        | ONTOLOGICAL route, with a repair: one must first show the concept of a |
        | supremely perfect being is POSSIBLE - that its perfections are      |
        | compatible - before inferring existence.                            |
        +-----+-----+-----+-----+
        |
        v
+-----+-----+-----+-----+
|          | TRUTHS OF REASON          | TRUTHS OF FACT          |
+-----+-----+-----+-----+
| Example  | a triangle has three sides;         | Caesar crossed the      |
|          | mathematics and logic              | Rubicon                 |
| Opposite | implies a CONTRADICTION             | is CONCEIVABLE          |
| Modality | NECESSARY                          | CONTINGENT, yet certain |
| Governed by | principle of contradiction        | the PSR                 |
| Analysis  | FINITE - reducible to             | INFINITE - completed    |
|          | identities                        | only by GOD             |
+-----+-----+-----+-----+
    COMPLETE INDIVIDUAL CONCEPT: every predicate ever true of an individual

```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 36/43: Leibniz: sufficient reason, worlds, harmony, freedom (continued)

```
=====
belongs to its concept, which God grasps entirely.
|
>>> SO IS EVERYTHING NECESSARY? NO - AND THIS IS WHERE THE MARKS ARE <<<
ABSOLUTE / LOGICAL NECESSITY   opposite implies a contradiction -> TRUTHS
                                OF REASON ONLY
HYPOTHETICAL / MORAL NECESSITY given God's choice of the best, the series
                                follows CERTAINLY - but its opposite remains
                                LOGICALLY CONCEIVABLE in another possible
                                world
|
v
POSSIBLE WORLDS AND THE BEST WORLD
God's understanding contains infinitely many possible individuals. Not all
possibles are COMPOSSIBLE - capable of existing together - so a possible
world is a MAXIMAL COMPOSSIBLE SET.
God actualises the world of GREATEST PERFECTION = THE GREATEST VARIETY OF
PHENOMENA GOVERNED BY THE SIMPLEST LAWS. "Best" does NOT mean maximum human
comfort or the absence of suffering.
THEODICY, as far as this topic owns it: evil is permitted because a world
containing it is, overall, the most perfect compossible WHOLE; perfection is
a property of the SYSTEM, not of each part alone.
VOLTAIRE, CANDIDE (1759): satire and RECEPTION, never doctrine.
|
v
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 37/43: Leibniz: sufficient reason, worlds, harmony, freedom (continued 2)

```
=====
PRE-ESTABLISHED HARMONY - LEIBNIZ'S OWN THREE OPTIONS
1 INFLUENCE   a rod between the two clocks   = DESCARTES' interaction
               -> rejected as unintelligible
2 ASSISTANCE   a keeper adjusting them at      = OCCASIONALISM
               every moment                   -> rejected as unworthy of a
               perfect craftsman
3 HARMONY     perfect construction AT THE      = LEIBNIZ
               OUTSET, so both keep the same
               time with no connection
TRAP: describing harmony as continuous divine intervention converts Leibniz
into an occasionalist. It is set ONCE, AT CREATION.
|
v
FREEDOM = THREE CONDITIONS, JOINTLY NECESSARY
SPONTANEITY   the action springs from the agent's own nature; no external
               compulsion - GUARANTEED BY WINDOWLESSNESS ITSELF
INTELLIGENCE  the agent deliberates and acts for perceived reasons, not by
               blind impact - this distinguishes a rational spirit from a
               bare monad
CONTINGENCY   the actual world is one of infinitely many possible worlds;
               the opposite of the act implies no contradiction
MECHANISM: reasons INCLINE WITHOUT NECESSITATING
(incliner sans necessiter) - the determination is MORAL, not LOGICAL.
RESIDUAL TO CONCEDE: since the complete concept of the ACTUAL agent is fixed
and this world is actualised, alternatives lie ACROSS worlds, not WITHIN
this one; a libertarian will call that contingency merely epistemic.
VERDICT: COHERENT COMPATIBILISM, NOT INDETERMINISTIC FREEDOM.
TRAPS: not a libertarian | not a fatalist | not an occasionalist | Candide is
       satire | spontaneity ALONE is not the doctrine.
```


ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 38/43: Seven-axis comparison and the criticism ledger

=====

THE SEVEN AXES THAT COVER EVERY COMPARATIVE QUESTION IN THIS TOPIC

AXIS	DESCARTES	SPINOZA	LEIBNIZ
substance	3: God, mind, matter	1: God, or Nature	infinitely many monads
God	personal, transcendent; veracity-guarantee	impersonal, immanent; IS all reality	necessary being; chose the best possible world
mind-body	INTERACTION (pineal gland)	PARALLELISM (double aspect)	PRE-ESTABLISHED HARMONY
freedom	libertarian free will	freedom = understanding necessity	compatibilism
method	doubt -> cogito -> reconstruction	geometrical demonstration	sufficient reason + complete concepts
the individual	a thinking SUBSTANCE	a MODE of God	a unique MONAD - a substance
the physical world	res extensa, mechanistic	a mode of the attribute Extension	WELL-FOUNDED PHENOMENON

READ ACROSS THE ROWS, NOT DOWN THE COLUMNS. The examiner almost always asks you to read across.

|
v

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 39/43: Seven-axis comparison and the criticism ledger (continued)

```
=====
CRITICISM -> REPLY -> RESIDUAL (the third column is where marks are earned)
DESCARTES
  the Circle (Arnauld) -> attended intuition vs remembered certainty ->
    RESIDUAL: the divine proofs themselves use remembered premises
  interaction gap (Elisabeth, 1643) -> the union is a PRIMITIVE NOTION ->
    RESIDUAL: a location, not a mechanism
  "substance" is equivocal -> analogical: absolute of God, relative of
    creatures -> RESIDUAL: Spinoza exploits exactly this concession
SPINOZA
  pantheism removes a personal God -> morality rests on adequate knowledge,
    not divine command -> RESIDUAL: providence and petition are lost
  ACOSMISM (Hegel) -> modes are real AS EXPRESSIONS ->
    RESIDUAL: dependent individuality remains thin
  determinism ends responsibility -> responsibility is reinterpreted; the
    free person acts from understanding -> RESIDUAL: alternatives never
    return
  "determination is negation" makes the finite merely negative -> finite
    things are POSITIVE modes limited by other modes -> RESIDUAL: the
    slogan is Hegel's universalisation of Letter 50
LEIBNIZ
  harmony is ad hoc and unfalsifiable -> the only route avoiding both
    unintelligible influx and monism, and requiring no continuous miracle
    -> RESIDUAL: the defence is comparative, not positive
  "best of all possible worlds" (Voltaire) -> "best" = maximum variety
    under simplest laws -> RESIDUAL: the perfection criterion is not
    independently testable
  fixed complete concepts erase freedom -> the opposite implies no
    contradiction -> RESIDUAL: alternatives lie across worlds, not within
    this one
    |
    v
RANKING REQUIRES A DECLARED CRITERION
  freedom = ALTERNATIVE POSSIBILITIES -> DESCARTES, at the price of an
    unintelligible interaction
  freedom = SELF-DETERMINATION -> SPINOZA, at the price of free
    will altogether
  freedom = RESPONSIBLE AGENCY UNDER
    SYSTEMATIC DETERMINATION -> LEIBNIZ [2024 safe verdict]
  mind-body by EXPLANATORY ECONOMY -> Spinoza | by FIDELITY TO EXPERIENCE ->
    Descartes | by SYSTEMATIC CONSISTENCY -> Leibniz
```

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 40/43: PYQ routes, directives, spine and the conclusion

=====

EXACT PYQ ROUTE MAP, 2018-2025 - FOURTEEN PRIMARY-OWNED PARTS

2018 Q1(b) 10m harmony -> windowlessness -> spontaneity + intelligence + contingency -> hypothetical necessity -> verdict

2018 Q2(a) 20m shared definition -> three enforcements -> costs -> "substance is a criterion, not a discovery"

2019 Q1(d) 10m five-step Meditation VI causal argument -> limits -> theological dependence

2019 Q2(c) 15m P16 -> three distinctions -> ethical consequence -> responsibility objection

2020 Q1(b) 10m monadic structure -> determination -> three conditions -> SIGNPOSTED FIRST-PERSON PARAGRAPH

2020 Q4(b) 15m P16 + P18 -> four consequences -> three criticisms with replies

2022 Q2(c) 15m four-step monism -> attributes and modes -> DECLARED pantheism verdict -> acosmism

2022 Q4(b) 15m doubt -> cogito -> res cogitans -> mediated world -> certainty vs substantiality

2023 Q1(c) 10m interpret Def. 7 -> stone analogy -> adequate causation -> concession

2023 Q2(c) 15m three kinds of ideas -> insufficiency -> DISPOSITIONAL innateness -> Locke's two tests -> adjudication

2024 Q2(b) 15m substance argument -> ontological "in" -> P18 -> three objections and replies

2024 Q3(c) 15m ANNOUNCE CRITERION -> all three accounts -> ranked verdict -> the winner's cost

2025 Q2(a) 20m five tenets -> seven Cartesian stages -> unifying logic -> four vulnerabilities

2025 Q2(b) 15m LETTER 50 PROVENANCE -> meaning -> God, modes, knowledge -> acosmism -> ruling

SOURCE NOTE: the 2019, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I wordings were read from the official papers held locally; the 2018 and 2020 Paper I papers are NOT in the repository, so those two follow the verified PYQ ledger.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 41/43: PYQ routes, directives, spine and the conclusion (continued)

=====

DIRECTIVE DECODER

DISCUSS	exposition + assessment, roughly 60:40
CRITICALLY DISCUSS/EXAMINE	assessment DOMINATES; a verdict is compulsory
COMMENT	short, pointed, thesis-first, inside the author's own system
EXPLAIN	foreground the DERIVATION, not a paraphrase
SUBSTANTIATE YOUR VIEW	take a side and defend it with textual grounds
WITH YOUR OWN COMMENTS	a signposted FIRST-PERSON final quarter
"WHOSE ACCOUNT ...?"	rank all three against a stated criterion and DEFEND the ranking
"WHAT IS THE REASON ...?"	give a MECHANISM, not a table

ANSWER SPINES AND LENGTH BANDS

10 MARKS	D-R-A-E	Define -> Reconstruct -> Apply a named text -> Evaluate about 150-200 words
15 MARKS	D-R-D-E-V	Define -> Reconstruct -> Debate -> Evaluate -> Verdict about 250-300 words
20 MARKS	C-M-C	Common premise -> Mechanism of divergence -> Comparative costs and conclusion about 340-400 words

PARAGRAPH CONTROL: CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 42/43: PYQ routes, directives, spine and the conclusion (continued 2)

=====

PROVENANCE AND CITATION DISCIPLINE

Cite Spinoza STRUCTURALLY (I, Def. 7; I, P15; I, P16; I, P18; I, P29; II, P7; II, P13; II, P40 Sch. 2; V, P32 Cor.) - translation-invariant.
"Determination is negation" = LETTER 50, 2 June 1674; universalised by HEGEL. NOT a sentence of the Ethics.
"The ghost in the machine" = GILBERT RYLE, The Concept of Mind, 1949.
NOT Descartes.
CANDIDE (1759) = VOLTAIRE'S SATIRE. NOT Leibniz's doctrine.
"Monads have no windows" and "incline without necessitating" are STANDARD RENDERINGS - say so.
"cogito, ergo sum" is from the DISCOURSE and PRINCIPLES I.7, not the Meditations.
inspectio mentis = "purely mental scrutiny" (Cottingham-Stoothoff-Murdoch) or "inspection of the mind" (Haldane-Ross) - name the edition or paraphrase.

FINAL TRAP SHEET - TEN LINES

- 1 The cogito is not a syllogism and does not by itself prove a soul.
- 2 The wax argument does not prove that bodies exist.
- 3 Descartes' "substance" is ANALOGICAL - Principles I.51.
- 4 Thought and Extension are Spinozist ATTRIBUTES, not substances.
- 5 Spinoza's freedom is not indeterminism, and Spinoza is not an atheist.
- 6 Pantheism and acosmism are OPPOSITE charges.
- 7 Monads never interact, and not every monad apperceives.
- 8 Harmony is set ONCE at creation; continuous adjustment is occasionalism.
- 9 Leibnizian certainty is NOT absolute necessity.
- 10 A comparative answer without a declared CRITERION stays descriptive.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 43/43: PYQ routes, directives, spine and the conclusion (continued 3)

=====

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

All three men accept that reason can reach a necessary intelligible order, and all three inherit ONE definition of substance. The differences are produced by how strictly that definition is enforced: loosely, giving three substances and an interaction Descartes cannot explain; strictly, giving one substance and a world in which individuality and alternatives are lost; strictly plus simplicity, giving infinitely many substances whose agreement must be arranged by God in advance.
Judged by EXPLANATORY ECONOMY Spinoza wins; by FIDELITY TO EXPERIENCE Descartes wins; by SYSTEMATIC CONSISTENCY Leibniz wins.
THAT NO SINGLE CRITERION SELECTS ONE ANSWER IS ITSELF THE STRONGEST EVIDENCE THAT WHAT DESCARTES BEQUEATHED WAS A PSEUDO-PROBLEM RATHER THAN A PROBLEM - AND IT IS WHY THE NEXT SYLLABUS ITEM, EMPIRICISM, BEGINS BY ATTACKING THE INNATE RESOURCES ON WHICH THE WHOLE PROGRAMME RESTS.